



PATH 01

Sell an AI playbook

You already know one job well enough to write it down. A stranger will pay to skip the guessing.

19 minute read · 4,211 words

Who this is for

Someone who can explain a single result — a week of content, a client intake, a job application pack — better than a blank chat window.

Time to first

7–21 days if you already know the job

Tools

First sale

A \$19–\$47 download bought by a person who is not you.

Cash window

\$19–\$47 first offer

Leave this alone

Google Docs or Word, Stripe Payment Link or Stan Store, one simple page, a second email to test-buy.

A 200-page 'everything AI' book, fifteen products, or waiting for a course platform.

What this actually is

A job, written down

A playbook is not a memoir about AI. It is a job, written so a tired person can finish it without inventing the steps. The buyer is not shopping for inspiration. They are shopping for a sequence they can run this week.

Narrow beats free

The products that sell in this category are narrow. "How to use ChatGPT" sits in a pile of free posts. "A 10-day content system for a one-person landscaping company" is a product. The more specific the job, the less you compete with free generic advice.

Draft with AI. Ship the rewrite.

You are allowed to use AI to draft. You are not allowed to ship the draft. The money is in the rewrite: your examples, your order of operations, your "do this next" at the end of every chapter. If a chapter does not end with a next action, it is an essay. Cut it or finish it. Read a chapter to someone who does the job. If they ask "so what do I do?" rewrite it. If they say "I can do that tonight," keep it.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

This path fits if you have done a job more than three times and can name what went wrong the first time. That scar tissue is the product. People pay for the mistakes you already made.

You do not need a following. You need one finished result you can explain in plain English: a week of content, a client intake, a job application pack, a month-end close.

Skip this path if

Skip this path if you have never finished a result for anyone, including yourself. Write the playbook after you have a result, not as a way to avoid getting one. If you need cash this week, use a service path first (Productized AI service or Local businesses + AI), then turn the notes into this playbook.

The honest middle

If you have done the job twice and the third time is this week, capture that run as you do it. The playbook is the notes, cleaned. You are not waiting to become an expert. You are waiting to have a sequence you would hand a tired friend.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you outline

Write this sentence before you outline: "I help [specific person] get [named result] in [time] using [named tools], even if [honest objection]." If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have an offer yet.

Specific person is a job plus a constraint. Named result is a file or a week of work, not a feeling. Time is days or hours. Named tools are what they already have. Honest objection is why they have not done it.

Sentences that work

I help one-person landscapers get 10 Google-ready posts in 10 days using ChatGPT and photos they already have, even if they hate writing and only have 20 minutes at night.

I help solo accountants close the month in Claude with a checklist they can rerun, even if their books are messy.

I help realtors write listing descriptions that do not sound like brochures, in one sitting, using the MLS notes they already typed.

Price the result, not the page count. First playbooks sell at \$19-\$47. Raise to \$67-\$97 when the file has templates, scripts, and a 14-day plan. Do not start at \$297. You have no proof yet.

One sentence, one product

If you need "and" to name the result, you have two products. Split them. Sell the one you can finish this week.

What "done" looks like

The bar for the file

The playbook is done when a stranger can finish chapter one without you in the room. That is the bar. Everything else is decoration.

Done also means: 8-15 chapters, each titled as a verb plus an object, each ending with one next action. A cover that states the job. Page numbers. Your email on the last page for questions you actually want. A template or prompt they can copy.

The bar for the checkout

One product, one price, one file. A Stripe Payment Link or Stan page whose title matches the one-sentence offer. You have bought it yourself from a second email, on a different browser, and the file arrived and opened.

The bar for the first week

Ten personal messages sent, at least one person who is not you owning the file, and a note of what they used. That note becomes the next post. If nobody has the file yet, send the next three messages before you rewrite the cover.

Pricing that holds

Start where proof is

\$19 is a coffee-and-a-tip price. People will try it if the job is named. \$29 is the default first playbook if you include a template or a prompt block. \$47 is fair when there is a 10- or 14-day plan plus scripts. Do not hide the price behind "DM me." Put it on the page. Pick \$29 or \$47 and sit there until a stranger has bought.

When to raise

Raise after a stranger sale and a sentence from them about what they used. Then add the missing template or a 14-day calendar and move to \$67-\$97. Raise because the file does more, not because you got bored of \$29. Do not add five bonuses to justify a jump. Add one working file.

What not to do

Do not start at \$297. You have no proof yet. Do not do \$9 "to get traction." You will attract collectors, not operators. Do not price by word count. A tight 18-page job at \$29 outsells an 80-page tour of your opinions.

Refunds: offer them, no speech. "If it is not useful, email me and I will refund." You will refund almost nobody if the first chapter works.

The first 72 hours

Hours 1-3: pick and name

Pick the buyer and the result. Write the one-sentence offer. If you have two ideas, pick the one you can finish without research you have not done. Put the sentence at the top of a Google Doc. Do not survey Twitter. Do not build a waitlist. One buyer, one result, one sentence.

Hours 4-8: outline like a tired person

Outline 8-15 chapters. Each chapter title is a verb plus an object: "Write the three hooks," "Set the checkout," "Send the ten messages." Put a next action under each. First chapter: what "done" looks like. Last chapter: what they do next week. Middle chapters are the work.

Paste this if you want a starting outline, then rewrite every title in your voice:

You are outlining a paid playbook, not a blog. Buyer: [person]. Result they can finish: [result]. Time: [days]. Tools they already have: [tools]. Honest objection: [objection]. Give me 12 chapter titles as verb + object. Under each, one next action a tired person can do in 20 minutes. No hype. No "mindset" chapters.

Day 2: ugly draft, then human

Draft ugly. Use AI for a first pass if you want, then rewrite every paragraph in the voice you would use to a friend at a kitchen table. Cut hype. Keep the steps. Read a page out loud. If you would not say it, delete it. Do not format. Do not design a cover. Words first.

Day 3: checkout, self-buy, ten asks

Make the checkout. One product, one price, one file. Buy it yourself from a second email. If the download fails, nothing else matters. Then send ten messages to people who already know you. That is the whole 72 hours.

One buyer, one result, one sentence

8-15 chapters that each end with a next action

Ugly complete draft, then a human rewrite

Working checkout, self-purchase, ten asks

The path, step by step

Steps 1-4: name, gather, outline, draft

Step 1. Name the job on a sticky note. If it takes more than one line, it is two products. Split it. Write the sticky note in the buyer's words, not yours.

Step 2. Collect the raw material you already have: old emails, checklists, prompts that worked, screenshots of a finished result. Dump it into the same Doc under Raw. You will mine it, not show it.

Step 3. Outline for a reader who is tired. First chapter: what "done" looks like. Last chapter: what they do next week. Middle chapters are the work. If a chapter is "Why AI matters," delete it. They already bought.

Step 4. Draft. Do not format yet. Do not design a cover. Words first. Leave holes marked HOLE rather than stopping to research a tool you do not use.

Steps 5-8: voice, files, PDF, checkout

Step 5. Rewrite for voice. Read a page out loud. If you would not say it, delete it. Keep one example per chapter from real work.

Step 6. Add the working files: a template, a prompt block, a checklist. Buyers pay more when they can copy, not just read. Put the checklist on its own page at the back so they can print it.

Step 7. Export a clean PDF. Number the chapters. Put your email on the last page. Filename: something a tired person can find later, like landscaper-10-day-content-playbook.pdf.

Step 8. Checkout. Stripe Payment Link or Stan. Title matches the one-sentence offer. Description is five lines: who, result, time, what is in the file, price.

Steps 9-12: test, ask, learn, then stop

Step 9. Test-buy. Different browser, different email. Confirm the file arrives and opens on a phone.

Step 10. Ten personal messages. Not a broadcast. "I wrote this for [job]. \$19. If it is useful: [link]. If not, ignore."

Step 11. After the first stranger sale, ask what they used. That sentence becomes your next ten posts. "Which chapter did you actually do?" is better than "Did you like it?"

Step 12. Only then add a second product or a \$9 membership. Not before.

A worked example

Dana, one-person landscaping companies, \$29

Dana already writes a few Google posts for her own company when she remembers. She is not a "content person." She is a person who got tired of a blank chat window every Sunday night. She writes a playbook called "10 days of Google-ready posts for a one-person landscaping company." Price: \$29. File: one PDF plus a one-page caption template.

Her one sentence: "I help one-person landscapers get 10 Google-ready posts in 10 days using ChatGPT and job photos they already have, even if they hate writing and only have 20 minutes at night."

What she put in the file

Twelve chapters, each with a next action:

What done looks like — 10 posts scheduled, each with a photo, a caption, and a phone-number line.

Pull 10 photos off your phone from jobs you finished this month.

Pick three post types only: before/after, this-week offer, FAQ.

Write the three hooks you will reuse.

Turn one finished job into a before/after caption.

Write the "this week" offer without sounding cheap.

Write the FAQ post that answers "why does this cost that?"

Paste the batch prompt and generate the other seven captions.

Put the phone number in the last line of every post. Same line, every time.

The 10-day calendar (which post, which photo, which morning).

What to do when nobody comments (you still posted; call three old clients).

What you do next week (repeat the same three types; do not invent a fourth).

She included one prompt they paste with a photo description and a price, and a caption template with blanks. She did not include a module on personal branding.

How she sold the first copies

Day 3 she made a Stripe Payment Link titled the same as the sentence. She bought it from her other Gmail. The PDF opened on her phone. Then she sent ten texts: owners she had swapped trailers with, people from a local Facebook group she already helps, her cousin who runs a lawn crew, and old clients who ask how she "does the posting."

The text: "I put a short playbook up for one-person landscaping companies that need 10 Google posts. One file, \$29, instant download. If that is useful: [link]. If not, no need to reply."

Two people she knew bought on day 3. A stranger bought on day 11 after she posted one before/after from her own yard with the last line "I wrote the 10-day sequence I use. \$29. Link in bio." She asked the stranger which chapter they used. They said chapter 5, the before/after caption. That became her next five posts. She did not write book two.

Copy you can actually send

DM (text or email)

I put a short playbook live for [job]. One file, \$19, instant download. If that is useful: [link]. If not, no need to reply.

Post

Blank chat is expensive. I wrote the sequence I actually use for [result]. \$19. Link in bio.

Or, with a photo of the finished job, not the PDF cover:

This is 10 days of posts for a one-person [trade], written so you can do it after dinner. \$29. Not another AI dump.

Listing title and body

Title: [Job] in [time] — a playbook for [person], not another AI dump.

Body, five lines:

Who it is for: [person].

What they finish: [result] in [time].

What they get: a PDF with [N] chapters, a paste-ready prompt, and a checklist.

What they need: [named tools], no extra subscriptions.

Price: \$29. Instant download. Email me if it is not useful and I will refund.

Email to people who already know you

Subject: the [job] sequence, written down

I got tired of explaining this in pieces, so I wrote a short playbook. It is the order I actually use for [result], including the prompt and the checklist. \$19, one file.

If you want it: [link].

If you do not, delete this. I will not follow up.

Reply to an objection

"I can just ask ChatGPT."

You can. The playbook is the order, the examples from [job], and the next action at the end of each chapter so you do not stall at a blank window. If you already have a sequence you like, you do not need this. If you keep starting over, \$19 is cheaper than another Sunday night.

"I do not have time to read a book."

It is [N] short chapters. Chapter one is what done looks like. Chapter two is a 20-minute task. If you cannot do chapter two this week, wait.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1: outline and ugly draft

No public launch. Two evenings. Evening one: sticky note, one sentence, outline of 8-15 chapters with next actions. Evening two: ugly draft of the whole thing, holes marked HOLE. Do not open

Canva. Finish the words. If you only have 45 minutes a night, do three chapters a night for four nights.

Week 2: rewrite, templates, checkout, ten asks

Rewrite out loud. Add one template and one prompt block. Export the PDF. Set Stripe or Stan. Test-buy from a second email on your phone. Send ten personal messages. First sale is allowed to be someone you know. Do not add a second product this week.

Week 3: teach one chapter, three times

Three posts or emails that teach one chapter. Soft link. Example: post the before/after caption formula. End with "I wrote the rest of the 10-day sequence. Link in bio." If you are not public, send three more personal messages instead of posts.

Week 4: fix, do not expand

Fix whatever the first buyers tripped on. A broken download. A prompt that needed one extra line. A chapter that assumed they had a desktop. Do not write book two. If nobody bought, send ten new asks to people who do the job, then look at the title. The title is usually the problem, not the prose.

Quality bar

Voice

Kitchen table, not conference stage. Short sentences. Named tools. Named times. If a paragraph could run in a motivational clip, cut it. Read the first page to someone who does the job. "I could do that" means you passed.

Structure

Every chapter: one point, one example, one next action. Put the working files where they can steal them — a box, a back page, a second PDF in the zip. Number the chapters. Use the same words in the title, the checkout, and the first paragraph.

Proof inside the file

One real example per chapter beats five generic screenshots. Blur names. Keep the texture: the actual price, the actual photo description, the bad first draft and the good second.

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

Count these

Checkout works: self-purchase from a second email, file opens on a phone.

Messages sent: ten in the first 72 hours, then ten more if nobody bought.

Sales from people who are not you. One stranger sale is the real start.

"Which chapter did you use?" answers. That sentence is your next post.

Refunds. If you get more than one in the first ten sales, chapter one is unclear or the title oversold.

Ignore these

Landing page visits with no checkout. Follower counts. Cover polish. Word count. A playbook with 12 visitors and three sales is healthy. A playbook with 2,000 visitors and zero sales has a broken offer or a broken title.

A simple weekly log

One line a week: date, messages sent, sales, refunds, one buyer sentence.

Objections you will hear

"I can get this free from ChatGPT."

Plain answer: they can get a draft. They cannot get your order of operations, your examples from this job, and a next action at the end of every chapter. If they already have that sequence, they should not buy. If they keep staring at a blank window, \$19 is the sequence.

"I do not know if I am qualified to write this."

If you have done the job three times and can name what went wrong the first time, you are qualified for a \$19-\$47 playbook. You are not applying to teach a university course. You are handing a tired person the notes you wish you had.

"Nobody will pay for a PDF."

People pay for PDFs every day when the job is named and the checkout is simple. Name the person, the result, and the time. Put the price on the page. Ask ten people.

"I need a course platform / a big list / a funnel."

You need Google Docs, a Payment Link, and ten messages. A course platform is how people delay chapter one. After a stranger has bought, you can put the same file on a nicer page. Not before.

"What if they want a refund?"

You refund them. One sentence. Then you ask what they expected. If two people say the same thing, you fix that chapter. Refunds are cheaper than a reputation for arguing.

How this feeds other paths

Products that grow out of the same notes

The playbook is often the first product because it is the sequence in your head, written down. The same notes become Niche prompt stacks (the prompt blocks, sold on their own), Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack (the instructions, installed so they never paste again), and AI templates and SOPs (the checklist as a filled file).

Do not split them until the playbook has a stranger sale. If they say "can I just have the prompt," that is a prompt stack. If they say "I want this inside Claude," that is a skill pack.

Distribution that uses the same chapters

AI-assisted short-form: each chapter is a 20-second video. Same offer at the end. A weekly AI letter: one chapter taught, one link to the file. Your front door: a diagnostic that tells them which chapter they need, then the playbook.

Services and later products

Local businesses + AI and Productized AI service are how you get paid while the playbook is still a draft — do the job once for a nearby owner, then write what you did. A small AI membership comes after, when you have updates worth a monthly. Do not open all of those doors this month. Finish the playbook.

Mistakes that kill this path

The usual deaths

Writing for "entrepreneurs." That is not a buyer. Writing 80 pages of theory. Shipping a ChatGPT paste. Hiding the price. Launching with five bonuses and no core file. Waiting until it feels ready. Naming it "The AI Playbook" with no job in the title.

The quieter deaths

Building a course platform before a PDF. Adding a membership so you can delay shipping. Redesigning the cover four times. Putting your whole catalog in the listing. Using someone else's examples from a different trade.

The bar, again

The playbook is ready when a stranger can finish chapter one without you in the room. Ship at that bar. Fix after the first ten asks.

Tools and how you actually use them

Writing

Google Docs or Word. One document. The model you already use is enough for the ugly draft. The rewrite is you. Export PDF. Open it on your phone. If the font is tiny or the prompt boxes break, fix the Doc, export again.

Checkout

Stripe Payment Link or Stan Store. One product. Title = the offer sentence, shortened. After payment, the file. You do not need a full site. A simple page that repeats the five-line listing is enough.

The second email

Create it before you launch. Buy your own product. If the download never arrives, fix that before you send a single ask. This step feels small. It is the whole business on day three.

Ship checklist

Before anyone else sees it

- One-sentence offer with all five brackets filled
- 8-15 chapters, verb + object titles, each ending with a next action
- First chapter is what done looks like; last chapter is next week
- One real example, names blurred; one prompt they can paste; one checklist
- Rewrite read out loud; hype cut
- PDF opens on a phone; email on the last page

Before you send the ten asks

- Checkout title matches the offer; price on the page (\$19-\$47)
- Bought from a second email, different browser; file arrived and opened
- Ten names written down; message copied, link tested
- No second product, no bonus pile

After the first sale

Ask: which chapter did you actually use?

Fix the first trip-up

Do not start book two

FAQ

Do I need a big audience?

No. You need ten people who already know you or do the job, a working checkout, and a file that survives chapter one without you.

How long should it be?

Long enough that a tired person can finish the job, short enough that they will start tonight. Most first playbooks are 12-25 pages including the checklist. If you are at 80 pages, you wrote essays. Cut or split.

Can I use AI to write the whole thing?

You can use it to draft. You cannot ship the draft. The buyer is paying for your order, your examples, and your next actions. A pasted ChatGPT article with a cover is the fastest way to a refund.

What if I do not have screenshots or old emails?

Run the job once this week for yourself or for one person. Capture as you go. If you cannot run the job this week, this is not your path yet. Do a service job, then write.

Stripe or Stan?

Either. Stripe Payment Link is enough if you are comfortable with a raw link. Stan is enough if you want the page and the file in one place. Pick one tonight. Do not compare six platforms.

Should I put it on Etsy or Gumroad too?

Not in week one. Sell where you can send a link to ten people. After a stranger sale, you can add a marketplace if the title matches how people search.

What do I do after ten asks and zero sales?

Ask one of the ten: "Was the job wrong, the price wrong, or the timing wrong?" Then look at the title. Most first misses are a vague title. Rewrite the sentence. Send ten new asks. Do not rewrite the whole PDF yet.

Can I charge \$97 on day one if I include a call?

You can, but you just built a service with a PDF attached. If you want the playbook path, keep the file at \$19-\$47 and do not include your calendar. If you want to get paid this week with your time, use Productized AI service and come back.

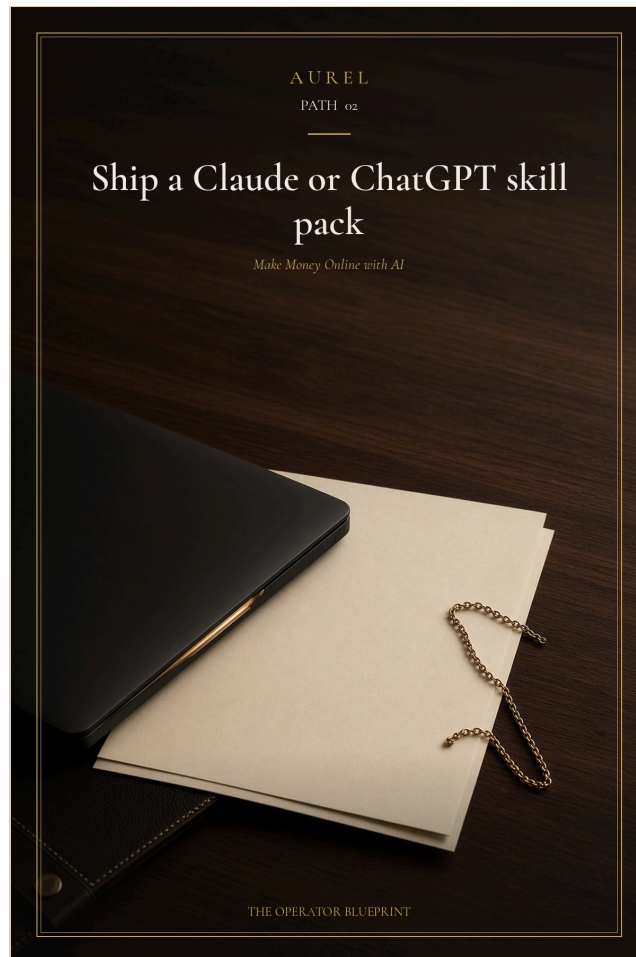
When do I write the second playbook?

After a stranger has bought the first, told you what they used, and you have fixed the trip-ups. Then only if they ask for the next job.

Is a playbook the same as a prompt pack?

No. A playbook is the sequence, with prompts inside it. A prompt stack is the prompts, with a one-page SOP for which to use when. Dana wrote a playbook because landscapers needed the 10-day order, not 200 clever lines.

THE OPERATOR SUITE · PATH 02



PATH 02

Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack

They already pay the model. They are paying you to stop starting from zero.

18 minute read · 4,000 words

Who this is for

People who use Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini every week and keep rebuilding the same chat.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

One \$19 order from someone who used the model this week.

Cash window

\$19–\$39

Leave this alone

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs, a zip of the skill files, a one-page install, Stripe.

A 200-prompt dump with no job in the title. Competing with free GitHub lists on volume.

What this actually is

A small appliance, not a prompt PDF

A skill pack is a working stack: instructions the model follows, examples of good output, and a way to install it in under ten minutes. It is not a PDF of prompts. It is closer to a small appliance. Plug it in, get the job.

The buyer has already decided AI is useful. Their pain is the blank window. Your job is to replace that window with a named job: weekly content, invoice follow-up, meeting notes into tasks, a listing description, a study plan.

The title is the product

If they cannot tell from the title what file they get and what job it does, they will not buy. "Claude Power Pack" is a mood. "Client follow-up skill for solo bookkeepers" is a product.

A skill pack ships as files they can paste or upload: a system-instructions file, one sample input, one sample output, and a one-page install. If you only send a list of prompts, you shipped a weaker version of Niche prompt stacks. This path is the installable version of a job.

What you are not selling

You are not selling access to a model. They already pay Anthropic or OpenAI. You are not selling 200 clever lines. You are selling the first message being raw material — an overdue invoice list, a messy email thread — and the model already knowing the format, the tone, and when to stop and ask.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

You use Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini every week and keep rebuilding the same chat. You have a job you have run in a window more than twice. You can write instructions as if you will never be in the room: role, inputs, output format, quality checks, what to ask if information is missing.

You do not need to be a developer. You need to have finished the job in a chat and been annoyed that you had to re-explain it the next time.

Skip this path if

Skip if you have never run the job in a model yourself. Skip if you want to compete with free GitHub lists on volume. Skip if your title would be "200 ChatGPT prompts." That market is noise, and this path loses when you play it.

If you need cash this week and you do not already live in these tools, write a playbook or take a service job first. A skill pack is fast only if the job is already in your fingers.

The buyer on the other side

The buyer is not a prompt tourist. They already have a Plus or Pro tab open. They are a bookkeeper, a recruiter, a clinic manager, a realtor who pastes the same messy input every Friday and rewrites the instructions from memory. They will pay \$19 to never start from zero again.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this first

"I help [specific person] finish [named job] in [named tool] in under [time], even if they are not a prompt person." If you cannot name the tool and the job, you do not have a skill pack. You have a vibe.

Examples that work: a solo bookkeeper who needs client follow-up emails from an invoice list in Claude; a recruiter who needs a scored shortlist from a pile of messy resumes; a tradesperson

who needs a job-to-Google-post in one paste.

What they get, said plainly

They get a zip: system instructions (or a Custom GPT / Claude Project recipe), a sample input, a sample output, and a one-page install they can follow on a tired night. They do not get a course. They do not get a community. They get the appliance.

Price the job, not the file count

First skill packs sell at \$19. \$29-\$39 is fair when the install is clean, the sample is real, and you include a 20-second screen recording of blank chat versus the skill. Do not bundle 40 jobs to justify \$49. One job, done, at \$19, outsells a suitcase of half jobs.

What "done" looks like

The install test

Done means a person who did not write it can install it in under ten minutes and get a usable first output from the sample. If they need you on a call, it is not a skill pack yet. It is a service.

Write the install as clicks: where to open, what to paste, what to send first, how they know it worked. If a step is "set up your workspace," you hid the work.

The quality test

Run the skill on a real example. Save that output as the sample in the zip. Then run it on a broken example — missing amount, missing date, rude client note — and confirm it asks once and stops instead of guessing. Silent guessing is how people lose trust.

The sales test

Checkout title is the job. Price is \$19. You have bought it from a second email. The zip opens. The install PDF is one page. You have asked five people who already use Claude or ChatGPT. Done is not a catalog page with six other ideas.

Pricing that holds

\$19 is the default

One \$19 order from someone who used the model this week is the first sale that matters. \$19 matches "I already pay for Claude; this saves me the blank window." It is low enough to try tonight and high enough that you will answer a support email.

Do not price at \$9. You will attract collectors who never install it, and you will hate the one-star "too simple" review from someone who wanted 200 prompts.

When \$29-\$39 is honest

Raise when you have: a 20-second screen, a real sample, failure modes in the instructions, and at least one stranger who installed it without you. That is a better product, not a different mood. Stay under \$39 until you have a version history and a second related skill you can bundle.

What you never do

Do not promise it works on every model. Build for one: Claude Projects, Custom GPTs, or Gemini Gems. Say which one on the listing. If a buyer uses the other, refund and point them at the install they would need — or do not sell it to them. Do not add a \$97 "with a setup call" on day one unless you mean to run Productized AI service instead.

The first 72 hours

Pick the job and write the room

Pick one job you have done in a chat more than twice. Open a new project. Write the system instructions as if you will never be in the room: role, inputs they must paste, output format, quality checks, what to ask if information is missing.

Paste this to get a first draft of the instructions, then rewrite every line in your voice:

Write system instructions for [tool] that a tired [person] will use. Job: [job]. The user's first message is only the raw material: [what they paste]. You will return [format]. If [critical field] is missing, ask once, then stop. Do not invent numbers. Include three quality checks you run before you show the draft.

Run it, package it, film it

Run it on a real example. Save the output as the sample. Write a one-page install: where to click, what to paste, how to test. Zip it. Price \$19. Record a 20-second screen: blank chat versus the skill.

Put the video and the checkout in one place. Ask five people who already use Claude or ChatGPT. Do not explain the catalog of other ideas you have.

The 72-hour list

- One job, written as system instructions

- One real example output in the zip

- One-page install a tired person can follow

- Twenty-second screen recording

- Five asks, not fifty features

The path, step by step

Steps 1-4: watch, write, fail, version

Step 1. Watch how the buyer actually works. If they live in email, do not build a Notion skill. If they live in Claude on a phone, the install cannot assume a desktop sidebar they have never opened. Sit with one real run of the job.

Step 2. Write the skill so the first message from the user is just the raw material. The skill should not need a prompt engineer on their side. If they have to write a paragraph of instructions after they install it, you failed.

Step 3. Add failure modes: "If the invoice amount is missing, ask once, then stop." Silent guessing is how people lose trust. List the three fields you will never invent. Put that list in the instructions, not in a blog post about your process.

Step 4. Version the file. v1 is allowed to be narrow. You will ship v1.1 after the first buyer. Put "v1.0" in the README and the filename. When you fix install wording, bump it. Buyers should know they can re-download.

Steps 5-8: package, title, prove, sell

Step 5. Package: README, skill or instructions file, sample input, sample output. That is enough. The README is the one-page install, not a manifesto. Filename the zip after the job: bookkeeper-client-followup-claude-v1.zip.

Step 6. Checkout title is the job. Thumbnail is the screen recording still. Description names the tool, the install time, and the sample. "Works in Claude Projects. Ten-minute install. Sample invoice list included."

Step 7. Record the 20-second screen. Left: blank chat, slow. Right or after: paste the raw list, get the follow-ups. No music. No intro. The last two seconds are the \$19 line and the link.

Step 8. Sell where those users already complain: X threads, Reddit help posts, Discord. Help first. Link in profile. Do not dump the zip in a comment. Dump the result of the job, then let the profile hold the buy link.

Steps 9-12: ask, support, patch, stop

Step 9. Five personal asks to people who already use the model. "I built a [job] skill for [person]. \$19, ten-minute install. If you want it: [link]. If not, ignore."

Step 10. After purchase, a three-line email: install, test with the sample, reply if it breaks. That reply is your product roadmap.

Step 11. Fix whatever the first buyer could not install. Ship v1.1. Same checkout, new zip. Email the people who already bought.

Step 12. Do not add a second skill until this one has a stranger sale. One appliance that works beats a store of toys.

A worked example

Marcus, solo bookkeepers, \$19

Marcus is a solo bookkeeper. Every Friday he writes the same follow-up emails: invoice sent, invoice 7 days late, invoice 21 days late, polite close-the-loop. He used to paste a messy spreadsheet into Claude and spend twenty minutes restating the tone. He ships a Claude skill: "Client follow-up for solo bookkeepers." Price: \$19.

His one sentence: "I help solo bookkeepers turn an invoice list into send-ready follow-up emails in Claude in one paste, even if they are not a prompt person."

What is in the zip

SKILL.txt — system instructions: you are writing follow-ups for a solo bookkeeper. Inputs: client name, invoice number, amount, days late, last contact. Output: subject line plus a short email in the bookkeeper's voice (plain, not cute). Never invent an amount or a date. If amount or days late is missing, ask once, then stop. Three tones: reminder, firm, final. Default to reminder unless days late is over 14.

SAMPLE-INPUT.txt — eight fake invoices, names blurred from a real week, amounts intact in spirit.

SAMPLE-OUTPUT.txt — the eight emails the skill produced, which Marcus actually sent after a human pass.

INSTALL.pdf — one page: open Claude, new Project, paste SKILL.txt into instructions, drop SAMPLE-INPUT as the first message, compare to SAMPLE-OUTPUT, then paste your own list.

He recorded 20 seconds: blank chat ("write follow-ups for these invoices") versus the Project with the skill. Same list, two very different first drafts.

How he sold it

He asked five people: two other bookkeepers in a Slack, his old firm colleague, a freelancer Discord, and a person who had tweeted "Claude keeps making up invoice amounts." He did not pitch a catalog. Two of the five bought. A stranger bought on day 6 after he replied to that tweet with the result (amounts correct, tone plain) and left the link in his profile.

The first buyer could not find "Project instructions" on mobile. Marcus added two screenshots to INSTALL.pdf, bumped to v1.1, and emailed both buyers. He did not start a second skill for tax organizers. Not yet.

Copy you can actually send

DM

I built a [job] skill for [person] who already uses Claude. Ten-minute install, \$19. If that is useful: [link]. If not, no need to reply.

Post

I wasted two hours prompting this. The skill does it in one paste. \$19.

Or, with the screen still:

Blank chat vs the follow-up skill. Same invoice list. Left one invented an amount. Right one asked. \$19, install in 10 minutes. Built for solo bookkeepers. Not a prompt dump.

Listing

Title: Client follow-up skill for solo bookkeepers — install in 10 minutes.

Body:

What you get: Claude Project instructions, a sample invoice list, a sample of the emails, and a one-page install.

What you do: paste your list. Get send-ready follow-ups. It will not invent amounts.

What you need: Claude (Projects). Not a prompt engineer.

Price: \$19. Instant zip. Email me if it breaks.

Email after purchase

Subject: install, then test with the sample

Open the INSTALL page. Ten minutes.

Run SAMPLE-INPUT first. Match it against SAMPLE-OUTPUT so you know it loaded.

Then paste your own list. If it breaks, reply to this with a screenshot. I will fix the file.

Reply to an objection

"Can't I just save a prompt?"

You can. A skill pack is the instructions plus failure modes plus a sample so you know it loaded. If your saved prompt already asks for missing amounts and never invents them, you do not need this. If you rewrite the instructions every Friday, \$19 is cheaper than another Friday.

"Does it work in ChatGPT?"

This one is built for Claude Projects. I will not pretend it is the same in a Custom GPT. If you only use ChatGPT, do not buy this version. Refund if you already did.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Days 1-2: write and test

One job you already run. Write the instructions. Run a real example. Run a broken example. Save both. You can do this in two evenings after work. Do not design a landing page yet.

Day 3: package and checkout

README, skill file, sample in, sample out. Zip. \$19 Payment Link or Stan. Buy it from a second email. Record the 20-second screen on your phone if you have to.

Days 4-7: five asks, one post a day

Five personal messages. Post the screen recording once a day in one place — same clip, same offer. Help in two threads where people complain about the job. Link stays in the profile.

Week 2: patch, then wait

Fix whatever the first buyer could not install. Ship v1.1. Do not add a second skill until this one has a stranger sale. If nobody bought, the title or the tool is wrong. Ask one of the five: "Would you even install this?" Then change the title, not the whole stack.

Quality bar

Instructions that survive you leaving the room

Role in one line. Inputs named. Output format named. Three quality checks. A stop rule for missing facts. No "be helpful" filler. No claim that it replaces a bookkeeper, a lawyer, or a clinician. It drafts. They send.

The sample is real enough to trust

Blur names. Keep the ugly: a client who pays late every time, a line with a missing PO, a note in all caps. If the sample is a perfect table, the skill will look smart and fail on Friday.

Install a tired person can finish

One page. Numbered clicks. One screenshot if a menu is hidden. A line that says "you will know it worked when the sample output looks like this." If they have to watch a 12-minute video, you wrote a course. Cut it.

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

Count these

Installs that produce a first output from the sample (ask: "Did the sample run?")

Stranger sales at \$19

"It broke" emails — these are the roadmap

Time-to-install reports. If two people say it took 30 minutes, the one-pager failed

Refunds because of the wrong model. That is a listing problem. Fix the title.

Ignore these

Stars on a prompt marketplace. How many skills you listed. GitHub-style star counts. Views on the screen recording if nobody clicks the checkout. Lines of instructions. "Community" member counts you do not have yet.

One line a week

Date, asks sent, sales, break-emails, version number. If v1.0 never becomes v1.1, you are not talking to buyers.

Objections you will hear

"I already have a Custom GPT / a Project."

Good. This is a better set of instructions plus a sample so they can test it. If theirs already does the job, they should not buy. If they keep tweaking it every week, \$19 is the freeze-frame that works.

"Skills are going to be free from the labs."

Some will be. Generic ones. A client-follow-up skill that knows a solo bookkeeper's tone and will not invent an amount is not on the default home screen. You are selling the job, not the concept of a skill.

"I am not technical."

Neither is the buyer, if you wrote the install. If you cannot write the install without the word "repo," this path will hurt. Use Claude Projects or Custom GPTs, not a local install.

"What if the model changes and it breaks?"

You version the file. You date the README: "Tested on Claude, [month year]." You email v1.1 to people who bought. That is the job after the first sale. It is also why you do not sell 40 jobs in one zip — you cannot maintain them.

"Can you just set it up for me?"

Yes, as a service, for a different price. This path is the zip. If you want setup-for-hire, that is Custom project setups or Productized AI service. Do not throw a call into a \$19 product.

How this feeds other paths

Same job, other shapes

The instructions inside the skill are a Niche prompt stack if someone wants to paste instead of install. The sequence you used to build it is Sell an AI playbook. The checklist in the README is an AI template. Let the first buyers tell you which shape they asked for.

Where it gets sold

AI-assisted short-form: the 20-second blank-vs-skill clip is the whole path. A weekly AI letter: one failure mode explained, link to the zip. Your front door: a diagnostic ("do you rewrite the same Claude chat every Friday?") then the skill.

When it becomes a service or a membership

Local businesses + AI: install the same skill for a nearby owner and charge a setup fee. Custom project setups and Automation setups are the grown-up version for people who want it connected to their inbox. A small AI membership is how you send v1.2, v1.3 as the model changes — after the \$19 file has strangers using it.

Do not open a membership to avoid shipping v1.

Mistakes that kill this path

The listed ones

Shipping prompts without install steps. Promising it works on every model. Bundling 40 jobs so none of them are good. Using other people's copyrighted prompt packs as your file.

The quieter ones

A title with no job. A sample that is too clean. Instructions that guess at missing money or medical facts. A 14-page install. A video instead of a one-pager. Asking fifty people for feature ideas before five people have installed v1. Naming it after yourself instead of the job.

The trust ones

Invented numbers. Invented legal language. A "medical" or "legal" skill that claims it is compliant. This path drafts operational writing. It does not practice. Put that limit in the instructions and on the listing.

Tools and how you actually use them

Where the skill lives

Claude Projects: paste the instructions into the project. Custom GPTs: paste into the GPT builder instructions. Gemini Gems: same idea, different menu. Pick one for v1. Write the install for that one only.

You are not shipping an API app. You are shipping text files a human pastes. If you need Zapier, you wandered into Automation setups.

The zip and the page

Folder: README (the install), SKILL or INSTRUCTIONS, SAMPLE-INPUT, SAMPLE-OUTPUT. Zip it. Stripe Payment Link or Stan delivers the zip. That is the stack from the original tools line. Do not add a course platform.

The 20-second screen

Phone screen record is enough. Desktop is cleaner if the buyer is on desktop. Show the blank chat failing or stalling, then the skill succeeding on the same paste. No intro bumper. The still from second 3 is the thumbnail.

Ship checklist

Before you zip

- One job in the title

- Instructions: role, inputs, output format, quality checks, stop rules

- Will not invent named fields (amounts, dates, diagnoses)

- Real sample input and sample output

- Broken-example test: it asked, then stopped

- One-page install with the actual clicks

- Version number on the README

Before you ask anyone

- Zip opens on a phone

- Checkout title = the job; price \$19

- Self-purchase from a second email

- 20-second screen recorded

- Five names who already use the model

- After-purchase three-line email written

After the first install

- Fix the install trip-up

- Ship v1.1 to people who bought

No second skill until a stranger sale

FAQ

Is this just a prompt pack?

No. A prompt pack is paste-as-you-go. A skill pack is installed once so the first message can be the raw material. If they want 25 separate prompts for a clinic week, that is Niche prompt stacks. If they want follow-up to live in Claude, that is this.

Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini?

Pick the one you actually use for this job. Write for that one. Saying "works everywhere" is how you get refunds.

Do I need to code?

No. You need to write instructions and a one-page install. If you are building an API wrapper, you left this path.

What if Anthropic or OpenAI ships this exact skill?

Then you sell the version that knows this job's tone and failure modes, or you move to the playbook and the service. Generic will always be free later. Specific stays yours if the sample is real.

How many skills should I launch with?

One. Five asks. One stranger sale. Then a second skill only if they ask for the next job.

Can I put it on a GPT store or a skill directory?

After it works at \$19 on your own checkout. Directories are extra. They are not the first 72 hours.

What do I do when a buyer says it "sounds like AI"?

The instructions need their voice. Add three sample sentences they actually send. Marcus put two real follow-ups he had already mailed (names changed) into SKILL.txt under "match this tone." That killed the peppy bot voice.

Is \$19 too low if it saves a Friday every week?

It is the right first price. Raise to \$29-\$39 after a stranger has installed it and you have the screen and the failure modes. Do not start at \$79 with no proof.

What if they want it connected to Gmail?

That is Automation setups or Custom project setups, priced as a project. Do not promise inbox connection inside a \$19 zip.

Can I use someone else's skill as a base?

No. Do not use other people's copyrighted prompt packs as your file. Write the instructions from the job you actually do. The scar tissue is the product.



PATH 03

Niche prompt stacks

Twenty-five prompts that finish a job beat a thousand that sound clever.

17 minute read · 3,716 words

Who this is for

A trade or hobby you know from the inside: realtors, tutors, gyms, writers, clinics.

Time to first

5–14 days

Tools

First sale

A niche buyer who uses the first prompt the same day.

Cash window

\$12–\$29

Leave this alone

A PDF or Notion doc, three before/after examples, Stripe or Etsy or Stan.

Generic '1,000 ChatGPT prompts.' That market is dead and noisy.

What this actually is

Why niche wins

Generic prompt packs are free on every platform. A stack for "pediatric clinic SMS that stays compliant-sounding and human" is not. You are selling vocabulary and constraints the general pack does not have: the words that trade uses, the lines it will not cross, the format that actually gets sent.

Twenty-five prompts that finish a job beat a thousand that sound clever. The buyer is not collecting prompts. They are trying to get through this week's writing: texts, emails, captions, listings, lesson notes.

The three parts every prompt needs

Every prompt in the stack needs three parts: inputs (what they paste), output format (what they get), and a done check (how they know it is usable). Without those, it is a toy.

A prompt that says "write a reminder text" is free and useless. A prompt that says "Paste parent first name, child first name, appointment day, appointment time, clinic phone. Return one SMS under 160 characters. No diagnosis language. No 'just checking in.' Done when a tired parent could tap send." is a product.

What you are not selling

You are not selling medical, legal, or financial advice. You are not selling a promise that a model is "HIPAA compliant" or "court ready." You are selling writing help for repeating operational jobs — reminders, reschedules, bios, captions — with the constraints a practitioner already lives with. If you cannot name those constraints from the inside, skip this niche.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

You know a trade or hobby from the inside: realtors, tutors, gyms, writers, clinics. You have sat in the job long enough to list the ten writing tasks people hate. You can tell a good reminder from a creepy one. You already belong to a group or forum where those people talk.

You do not need a huge audience. You need the niche word they would search, and enough respect in that room to share once without getting banned.

Skip this path if

Skip if your only edge is "I use ChatGPT a lot." Skip if you planned to copy someone else's stack and swap the niche word. Skip if you want to write for "everyone who uses AI." That is the dead market in the leave-alone line: generic 1,000-prompt dumps.

Skip medical, legal, or financial claims. If the job is diagnosis, contracts, or investment advice, this path is the wrong container. Operational writing around those fields can be fine (appointment SMS, not treatment plans). Know the line.

The buyer

A niche buyer who uses the first prompt the same day. They have a shift or a showing tomorrow. They will not "go through the course." They will paste one input and send one message. Your stack has to survive that first paste.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this

"I help [niche person] write [repeating job] every week with 25 prompts that include inputs, output format, and a done check, even if they hate sounding like a robot."

Title includes the niche word they would search. "25 prompts for pediatric clinic SMS and emails" is searchable. "Ultimate AI Prompt Vault" is not.

What they get

A PDF or a Notion doc. Twenty-five prompts covering a month of the weekly jobs. Three before/after examples, names blurred. A one-page SOP: which prompt when. Price \$12-\$29. Default \$19.

What they do not get

A thousand prompts. A claim of compliance. A community. A new model. They get the vocabulary and the constraints, in an order that matches a real week.

What "done" looks like

The file

Twenty-five prompts. Each has inputs, output format, a constraint ("I will not..."), and a done check. A one-page SOP that maps the week: Monday reminder, Tuesday waitlist, and so on. Three before/after pairs from realistic inputs. A dated line: "Tested on [model], [month year]."

If a prompt is clever but would never be sent in that trade, it is not done. Cut it.

The proof

You have run all 25 on real or realistic inputs. You kept the three best before/after pairs. Names blurred. Texture kept: the short-notice cancellation, the parent who texts at 9 p.m., the price question you are allowed to answer.

The checkout

Title has the niche word. Price is on the page. You have bought it from a second email. You have asked, helpfully, once, in a group you already belong to. Done is not five marketplace listings and a brand name.

Pricing that holds

\$19 is the home price

\$12 is for a tiny stack (10 prompts, one job). \$19 is the default for 25 prompts plus SOP plus three proofs. \$29 is fair if you add a one-page weekly calendar. Stay in the \$12-\$29 window from the original cash line. This is not a \$97 course.

Why cheap still needs a spine

A \$19 file with no done checks is a worse buy than a \$19 file with 25 complete prompts. Do not race to \$9 to "beat" Etsy. Race to a title that matches search and a first prompt they can use today.

When to bundle

Week 4, if they ask: add the calendar or checklist and raise to \$29, or keep \$19 and add the extra page. Do not invent a \$49 "pro vault" with the same 25 prompts in a different font.

The first 72 hours

List the jobs, then write

List the ten repeating writing jobs in that niche. Pick the five that happen every week. Write five prompts each, or write 25 that cover a month of work. Do not start with "fun" prompts. Start with the Friday-afternoon ones.

Paste this to draft a prompt, then rewrite it in the trade's voice:

Write a prompt for [person] who has to [job] every week. The prompt must have: (1) inputs they paste, named; (2) output format, including length; (3) a hard constraint of what it will not say; (4) a done check in one line. Kitchen-table English. No hype. No medical, legal, or financial claims.

Run, proof, SOP, price

Run all 25 on real or realistic inputs. Keep the three best before/after pairs as proof. Write a one-page SOP: which prompt when. Price \$19. Title includes the niche word they would search. Ask in the Facebook group or forum you already belong to — helpfully, once.

Helpfully means: answer someone's actual question with a useful line, then mention the file once in your profile or in a comment if the group allows it. Not a dump of 25 prompts in the thread.

The 72-hour bar

If you do not already know the ten jobs, you do not have 72 hours. You have research. Sit with a practitioner (even if it is you) before you write a single prompt.

The path, step by step

Steps 1-4: sit, form, polish, prove

Step 1. Sit with a practitioner, even if it is you. Write the jobs they hate writing. Ten of them. Star the five that happen every week. Those five become the spine of the 25.

Step 2. For each job, write the prompt as a form: "Paste [x]. I will return [y] in [format]. I will not [constraint]." If you cannot fill those blanks, you do not have a prompt. You have a slogan.

Step 3. Add a second-pass prompt: "Tighten this. Keep the facts. Cut the fluff." Bundles sell when there is a polish step. Pair it with the draft prompt so they are not stuck with a first-pass robot paragraph.

Step 4. Show three before/after. Blur names. Keep the texture of real work. Before is what they would have sent (or a generic ChatGPT dump). After is what your prompt produced, edited by you so it is actually sendable.

Steps 5-8: date, SOP, file, title

Step 5. Update when the model changes. A dated "tested on [month year]" line builds trust. Put it on page one and next to the three proofs.

Step 6. Write the one-page SOP. A table: day or trigger, job, prompt number, where it gets sent (SMS, email, Google). This is the difference between a pile and a stack.

Step 7. Put it in a PDF or a Notion doc. PDF is simpler for Stripe and Etsy. Notion is fine if you include a duplicate-this link and a PDF backup. Three before/after screenshots in the file, not only on the sales page.

Step 8. Title includes the niche word they would search. "25 prompts for pediatric clinic SMS and parent emails — inputs, format, done check." Not "AI magic for healthcare creators."

Steps 9-12: checkout, share, listen, stop

Step 9. Checkout. Stripe, Etsy, or Stan. Sell on your site first. Marketplace second if the titles match search. Test-buy from a second email.

Step 10. Ten personal shares in the niche: DMs, a helpful comment, a post in a group you already belong to, once. Help first.

Step 11. Ask the first buyer which prompt they used the same day. That prompt becomes your public example.

Step 12. Only add a calendar or a second stack if they ask. Do not copy someone else's stack and swap the niche word. That is both a mistake and a way to get a file that does not match how the job is actually done.

A worked example

Priya, pediatric clinic SMS and emails, \$19

Priya has worked the front desk of a pediatric clinic. She knows the week: reminder texts, waitlist offers, "we have a cancellation" messages, after-visit thank-yous, vaccine-clinic hours, school-note instructions, no-show follow-ups, form reminders, weather closures, and the "please use the patient portal" redirect. She does not write treatment advice. She writes the operational messages parents actually need.

Her stack: "25 prompts for pediatric clinic SMS and parent emails." Price: \$19. File: PDF plus a one-page SOP.

Her one sentence: "I help pediatric clinic staff write the week's SMS and emails in 25 prompts with inputs, format, and a done check, even if they are scared of sounding cold or of saying the wrong medical thing."

What the 25 cover

Five weekly jobs, five prompts each:

Appointment reminders (SMS, 24-hour, same-day, sibling double-book, interpreter need).

Schedule changes (cancellation, waitlist offer, weather, provider out, running late).

After-visit admin (thank you, forms still due, portal how-to, school note pickup, billing office hours — not bills as advice).

Front-desk FAQs the clinic is allowed to answer (hours, parking, what to bring, sick-visit vs well-visit booking, "we cannot diagnose by text").

Polish passes (shorten to 160 characters, warmer without being cute, Spanish-language draft to be checked by a bilingual staffer, cut diagnosis language, done-check against the clinic's "never say" list).

Every prompt starts with Paste: [fields]. Every prompt ends with Done when: [send test]. Every prompt includes I will not: diagnose, guess a result, promise a clinical outcome, or scold a parent.

How she proved and sold it

She ran all 25 on realistic inputs (fake names, real rhythms). She kept three before/after: a reminder that sounded like a bill collector, a waitlist text that leaked another child's name (her prompt forbids extra names), and a thank-you email that invented a follow-up plan (her prompt forbids plans). Those three are why someone trusts the file.

She asked once in a clinic-managers Facebook group she already helped in: she answered a thread about no-show texts with two principles (no shame, one next step, no clinical content),

then linked her profile. Listing title had "pediatric clinic SMS." Two people from the group bought. A stranger found it on day 10 because the title matched what they searched. She asked what they used first. Prompt 3, same-day reminder. She did not add a "HIPAA pack." She dated the PDF "tested March 2026."

Copy you can actually send

DM

I put together 25 prompts for [niche job] — each one has inputs, output format, and a done check. \$19. If that is useful: [link]. If not, ignore.

Post

Generic prompt packs are free. This one is for [person] who has to write [job] every week. \$19.

Listing

Title: 25 prompts for [niche job] — inputs, output format, done check. Tested this month.

Body:

Who: [person] who writes [job] every week.

What: 25 prompts, a one-page SOP for which to use when, three before/after.

What it will not do: medical, legal, or financial claims. No "compliance certificate."

Tested on [model], [month year].

Price: \$19. Instant download.

Email

Subject: 25 prompts for [job], not 1,000 generic ones

I was tired of [person] staring at a blank text window every [day]. Each prompt tells you what to paste, what you get, and how you know it is sendable. \$19.

[link]

If the niche is wrong, delete this.

Reply to an objection

"I already have ChatGPT."

Good. These prompts are the constraints and the vocabulary for [niche], not a new model. If your current prompt already refuses extra names, diagnosis language, and 200-character rambling, you do not need this. If you rewrite the instructions every time, \$19 is the freeze.

"Is this HIPAA / legally compliant?"

No pack of prompts is a compliance program. These are writing aids for operational messages. Your clinic's policies still apply. I will not sell you a "HIPAA prompt." I will sell you SMS that stay human and avoid diagnosis language. If you need a compliance vendor, that is a different purchase.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1: 25 prompts and three proofs

Two evenings to list the jobs, three evenings to write and run 25. Keep the three best before/after. Do not list it yet if you have not run them all. A prompt you have not run is a guess.

Week 2: listing live, ten personal shares

Checkout. Title with the niche word. Ten shares in the niche: DMs, one helpful group comment, one post. Help first. First sale can be someone you know who does the job.

Week 3: add the SOP

If buyers ask "which one do I use on Monday," you needed the SOP. Add the one-page which-prompt-when. Email it to people who already bought. Do not start a second niche.

Week 4: bundle only if they ask

A calendar or checklist if they ask for it. \$19 stays, or \$29 for the bundle. Update the "tested on [month year]" line if the model moved. Do not copy someone else's stack and swap the niche word.

Quality bar

Every prompt is a form

Paste [x]. I will return [y] in [format]. I will not [constraint]. Done when [check]. If a prompt is a clever one-liner, it fails the bar.

It matches how the job is actually done

Clever prompts that do not match the job are a listed mistake. Sit with a practitioner. If clinics send SMS under 160 characters, do not return a paragraph. If they are not allowed to name another patient, the prompt forbids extra names.

No claims you cannot stand behind

No medical, legal, or financial claims. No "HIPAA compliant prompts." No "this will win your case." Operational writing only. Put the limit on page one and in every clinical-adjacent prompt: "I will not diagnose, guess a result, or tell a parent to skip a visit."

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

Count these

First-prompt-used-the-same-day (ask the buyer)

Stranger sales

Which prompt number they used

Refunds for "I thought this was compliance / medical advice" — listing problem

Prompts that failed the run-through and got rewritten before launch

Ignore these

Prompt count above 25. Etsy hearts. "1,000 prompts" as a flex. Downloads of a free 5-prompt teaser that never converts. Page views from people searching "free ChatGPT prompts."

One line a week

Date, shares, sales, prompt-used-first, tested-on date. If the tested-on date is six months old, run the 25 again before you advertise.

Objections you will hear

"There are free prompt lists everywhere."

Yes. Generic ones. This stack is the vocabulary and constraints for [niche]. If a free list already has your "I will not" line and your done check, use the free list. If it writes a paragraph a parent will not send, \$19 is the niche version.

"Is this HIPAA / legally safe?"

No prompt pack is a compliance program. These are writing aids for operational messages. Clinic policy still applies. I will refund you if you bought thinking this was a legal product. It is not.

"Can't I write my own prompts?"

You can. You are paying for 25 that already ran on realistic inputs, with before/after, and a SOP for which to use when. If you like writing prompts, write them. If you have a clinic week to get through, buy the stack.

"Will they still work next month?"

Models move. The file is dated. When they move, you run the 25 again and send v1.1. That is why you sell 25 for one niche, not 1,000 for everyone.

"Can you add clinical advice prompts?"

No. Operational writing only. That is a hard line on this path. If they need clinical content, they need a clinician, not a \$19 PDF.

How this feeds other paths

Products that are the same job in another shape

The SOP and the sequence become Sell an AI playbook. The installed version of the best five prompts becomes Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack. The calendar becomes AI templates and SOPs. Do not split until a stranger has used prompt one the same day.

Where the before/after go

AI-assisted short-form: one before/after per video. A weekly AI letter: one prompt taught, link to the 25. Your front door: "which of these five weekly jobs hurts" then the stack. Live drops of AI packs: a dated zip when the model changes.

Services

Local businesses + AI and Productized AI service: sit with one clinic, write their 25, charge a project fee, then productize the generic version with names removed. Custom project setups if they want it inside their SMS tool. Do not promise that inside the \$19 PDF.

Mistakes that kill this path

The listed ones

Clever prompts that do not match how the job is actually done. Medical, legal, or financial claims. Copying someone else's stack and swapping the niche word.

The quiet ones

A title without the niche word. Prompts with no done check. Before/after that are fake-clean. A thousand-prompt dump to "look like value." Promising HIPAA, court, or tax outcomes. Selling to "entrepreneurs." Skipping the run-through so you only discover a bad prompt after a refund.

The ethics ones

Do not put another child's name in a waitlist text example. Do not invent clinical advice to make a before/after dramatic. Do not scrape a clinic's real SMS. Blur, reconstruct, respect the room.

Tools and how you actually use them

The file

A PDF or a Notion doc. PDF is easier to deliver. Notion is fine with a duplicate link and a PDF export as backup. Three before/after examples in the file. Stripe, Etsy, or Stan for checkout. That is the original tools line. Do not add a prompt marketplace account in week one.

How you run the 25

One sitting per job family. Paste realistic inputs. Save the output. If you would not send it, rewrite the prompt, not the output. The product is the prompt that produces sendable work, not a hand-edited miracle you cannot reproduce.

Dated tests

Page one: "Tested on [model], [month year]." When the model changes, rerun the three proofs. If they break, fix the prompts, bump the date, email buyers if you have their addresses.

Ship checklist

Before the file is a product

Niche word in the title

25 prompts, each with inputs, output format, constraint, done check

All 25 run on realistic inputs

Three before/after, names blurred

One-page SOP: which prompt when

No medical, legal, or financial claims

"Tested on [month year]" on page one

Second-pass polish prompts included

Before you share

Price \$19 (or \$12-\$29)

Self-purchase works

Ten personal shares listed

One helpful group ask, once

Refund line for people who wanted a compliance product

After the first use

Ask which prompt they used the same day

Fix that prompt if they tripped

Do not add a second niche

FAQ

Why 25? Why not 100?

Twenty-five that finish a month of weekly jobs beat 100 clever orphans. If you have more, you probably have a second stack. Sell this one first.

PDF or Notion?

Either. PDF for Stripe and Etsy. Notion if your buyer already lives there. Include the three proofs in both cases.

Can I sell on Etsy in week one?

You can. Site first is cleaner so you can email v1.1. Etsy second if the title matches search. Generic "ChatGPT prompts" on Etsy is a graveyard. "Pediatric clinic SMS prompts" is a search.

What if I am not in that trade?

Sit with a practitioner or skip the niche. Swapping the niche word on someone else's stack is a listed mistake and it produces prompts that do not match the job.

Can I include clinical or legal language?

No. Operational writing only. No medical, legal, or financial claims. If Priya's clinic stack starts drafting treatment plans, she cut those prompts. Appointment SMS, not care.

Do I need before/after on the sales page?

Yes. Three. Blur names. Keep the texture. They are the reason a stranger believes this is not another free list.

\$12 or \$19?

\$19 for 25 plus SOP plus proofs. \$12 if you only have one job and ten prompts. \$29 if they asked for the calendar. Stay in \$12-\$29.

What do I do when the model changes?

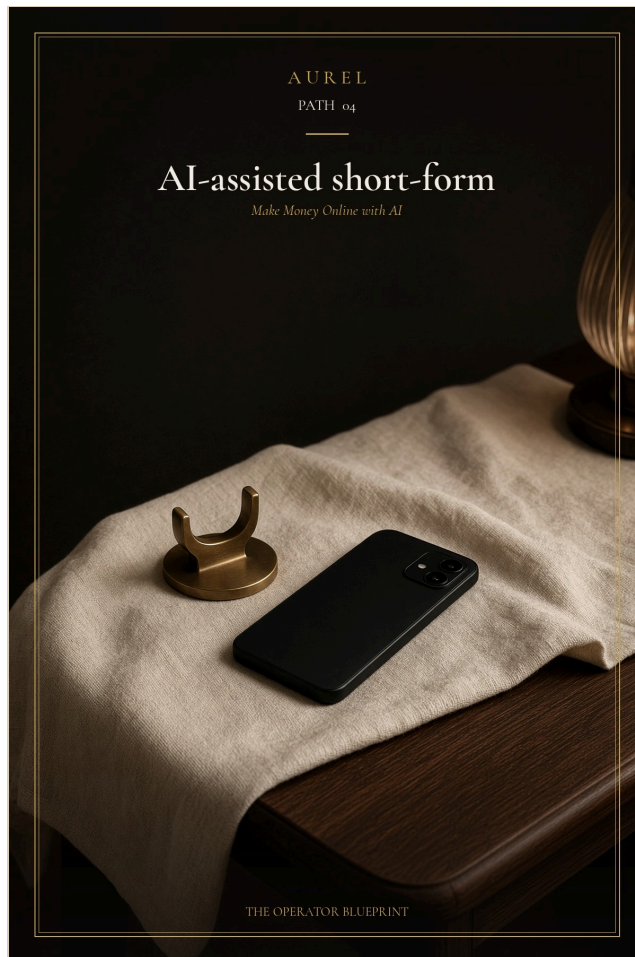
Rerun the 25. Fix what broke. Date the file. Email v1.1 if you can. That is why you do not sell 1,000.

Can I copy a competitor and change "realtor" to "clinic"?

No. Copying someone else's stack and swapping the niche word is how you ship clever prompts that do not match the job. Write from the inside.

Is this the same as a skill pack?

No. Prompt stacks are paste-as-you-go. Skill packs are installed so the first message is raw material. If they want 25 separate jobs for a clinic week, this path. If they want one follow-up machine in Claude, Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack.



PATH 04

AI-assisted short-form

AI writes the outline. You say it. The offer sits at the end, every time.

17 minute read · 3,668 words

Who this is for

You can talk to a camera or screen-record, and you have one thing to sell.

Time to first

14–30 days of posting

Tools

First sale

A profile visit that becomes an email or a \$19 checkout.

Cash window

Traffic to a \$19–\$47 file

Leave this alone

Phone, CapCut, one platform for 30 days, Stan or Beacons.

Five platforms. Faceless slideshows with no offer. Buying views.

What this actually is

The job of a video

Every video does one of three things: teach a small piece, diagnose a mistake, or send them to the next step. If it does none of those, it is entertainment you are not getting paid for.

This path is not "become a creator." It is 14-30 days of posting on one platform so a profile visit becomes an email or a \$19 checkout. The offer sits at the end, every time. Same offer. Same link in the bio. You already have one thing to sell — a playbook, a skill pack, a prompt stack, an SOP. Short-form is how strangers find it.

What AI is for

AI is useful for hooks and outlines. It is poison if you read it like a press release. Generate ten hooks. Speak the three you would actually say to a friend. Cut the rest.

You do not post AI voiceover over stock clips and call it a business. Faceless slideshows with no offer are in the leave-alone line. If you will not show your face, screen-record the work. Either way, a human says the words.

What this is not

Not five platforms. Not buying views. Not a 20-second tour of your whole catalog. Not waiting for the algorithm to "pick you" before you put a link in the bio. The algorithm is not the bottleneck. Volume of honest posts is.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

You can talk to a camera or screen-record, and you have one thing to sell. You do not need to like how you look. You need to be willing to post 30 times on one app without switching when a post dies.

You already have the file, or you will have it in week 1 (a \$19 SOP is enough). Short-form without an offer is a hobby. Short-form with a \$19-\$47 file is this path.

Skip this path if

Skip if you will not press record. Skip if you planned to run TikTok, Instagram, Shorts, LinkedIn, and Pinterest "to be safe." Skip if you want to buy views or followers. Skip if you have no file and no email capture — then go write the playbook or the SOP first.

If you freeze on camera, screen-record the job: the SOP, the prompt, the before/after. Your voice on the work is enough. If you will not even do that, this path will punish you for 30 days and then you will quit.

The honest middle

Shy is allowed. Inconsistent is not. One platform, one offer, 30 days. That is the deal.

The offer, named in one sentence

One line in the bio

The bio is the offer. Not a menu. Not "links, courses, coaching, merch." One file, one price, one link (Stan or Beacons). Example: "The 1-page [job] SOP. \$19. I post how I use it."

If you cannot name the file in one line, you do not have an offer. Go back to Sell an AI playbook or AI templates and SOPs and ship the file, then return.

What every video points at

The same checkout. Teach a piece of the SOP, diagnose a mistake the SOP prevents, or walk through one step. Last line, spoken: "The file is \$19. Link in bio." Same words, every time, so

people who watch three videos know the next step without thinking.

Price on the path

This path does not sell the videos. It sells traffic to a \$19-\$47 file. If you have nothing at checkout, you are posting for free. Put the file up before day 1 of posting, even if it is ugly. You can pretty it later. You cannot retrofit an offer onto 30 videos with no link.

What "done" looks like

After 72 hours

One platform chosen. One-line offer in the bio. Checkout works. Three 20-second videos filmed (a mistake, a principle, a walkthrough). One posted today. Five more batched or scheduled. Twenty hooks on a note, three of them spoken in your mouth.

After 30 days

Thirty posts on that one platform. Same offer at the end. Comments read; at least five scripts taken from objections. Five shapes that got saves or comments, kept. The rest, retired. At least one profile visit that became an email or a \$19 checkout — that is the first sale this path names.

What done is not

A viral post with no link. A second platform "because this one is dead." A new offer in week 2. A ring light haul. Done is boring on purpose: volume, one file, one place.

Pricing that holds

The file, not the video

You are not selling a "content package." You are pointing at a \$19-\$47 file. \$19 SOP is the cleanest first product for this path. \$29-\$47 if the file already has templates. Do not launch a \$97 cohort from a 20-second clip. The clip cannot hold that weight yet.

Do not hide the price

Say "\$19" out loud at the end. People who will never buy still respect a number. People who might buy should not have to DM you to hear it. Pin a comment with the next step if the platform allows it: "SOP is \$19. Link in bio."

Views are not revenue

Buying views is in the leave-alone line. A cheap view on a video with no offer still converts to zero. Spend nothing on ads until a stranger has bought from organic posts and you know which shape they watched. Creator ads with AI scripts is a later path, not day one.

The first 72 hours

Pick the room and the line

Pick one platform. TikTok, Instagram, or YouTube Shorts — not all three. Write the one-line offer that every video can point to. Put it in the bio with Stan or Beacons. Test the link on your phone.

If you already spend time watching one of those apps, post there. Do not pick the "serious" platform you never open.

Hooks, three films, post today

Generate 20 hooks. Film three 20-second videos: a mistake, a principle, a walkthrough. Same offer at the end. Same link in the bio.

Paste this, then speak only the lines you would say to a friend:

Give me 20 spoken hooks for a 20-second video. Buyer: [person]. File I sell: [SOP name], \$19. Each hook is one sentence I would say in a kitchen. Pattern: "Stop doing [common thing] if you want [result]." No hype. No "wait for it." No hashtags in the hook.

Publish one a day starting today. Batch the next five on day three. That is the 72 hours. The algorithm is not the bottleneck. Volume of honest posts is.

Do not do these in the 72

Do not buy a ring light if your phone camera works. Do not open a second account. Do not design a brand kit. Do not wait until Monday.

The path, step by step

Steps 1-4: offer, hook, style, batch

Step 1. One offer in the bio. Not a menu. Stan or Beacons, one button, one file. If you have two products, pick the \$19 one for 30 days. The other can wait.

Step 2. A hook formula: "Stop doing [common thing] if you want [result]." Then show the better way in 15 seconds. The hook is spoken in the first second, also on-screen for people who watch muted.

Step 3. On-screen text for people who watch muted. Your face or your screen — pick one style and keep it for 30 days. Switching from talking-head to slideshow to car-vlog trains nobody, including you.

Step 4. Batch. Two hours, ten videos, beats ten days of "I should post." Phone on a stack of books. Same shirt is fine. Same wall is fine. CapCut to add captions. Export, schedule or dump into a folder named by day.

Steps 5-8: comments, pin, types, end card

Step 5. Read comments. The objections are next week's scripts. Paste them into AI and ask for outlines, then rewrite. "This is too simple" becomes a video that shows the mistake of overbuilding. "I do not have time" becomes a 20-second timer of you doing one step.

Step 6. Pin a comment with the next step if the platform allows it. "SOP is \$19. Link in bio. One job, not a catalog." Do this on every post for 30 days so you are not relying on people to read a tiny bio.

Step 7. Film the three types on a loop: a mistake, a principle, a walkthrough. You do not need a fourth type in month one. Variety is how people stall.

Step 8. End card, spoken, every time: "The file is \$19. Link in bio. One job, not a catalog." Same words. Boredom here is a feature. Recognition is the point.

Steps 9-12: captions, 30, keep, do not switch

Step 9. CapCut auto-captions, then fix names and the \$19 line. Wrong captions kill trust. 15 minutes a batch is enough.

Step 10. Post one a day. If you miss a day, post two the next. Do not "restart on Monday." The 30-day clock includes the ugly days.

Step 11. After 30 videos, keep the 5 that got saves and comments. Repeat those shapes. Kill the rest. Saves and comments beat views. Views without saves are tourists.

Step 12. Do not switch platforms when a post dies. Dead posts are normal. Switching is how you stay at video three forever.

A worked example

Jordan, one platform, 30 days, \$19 SOP

Jordan has a one-page SOP: "Friday follow-up for solo service people" — a sequence they already use to email clients who went quiet. Price: \$19. They pick Instagram. They do not open TikTok "as well." Bio: "Friday follow-up SOP. \$19. I show the steps here." Link: Stan.

They generate 20 hooks. They speak three:

Stop rewriting the same 'just checking in' email every Friday if you want people to actually reply.

If your follow-up is three paragraphs, they are not ignoring you. They are tired.

I time this. One client, 90 seconds, send. The SOP is \$19.

The 30-day shape

Week 1: seven videos, same offer. Three mistakes (the long email, the guilt tone, the missing next date), two principles (one ask, one next date), two walkthroughs (screen-record the SOP, fill it for a fake client).

Week 2: comments become scripts. Someone says "this only works if you have a list." Jordan films: "You need three names, not a CRM." Someone says "AI emails sound fake." Jordan films the human pass: "Generate, then cut the smile."

Week 3: repeat the two shapes that got saves — the 90-second timer and the "three paragraphs" diagnosis. Same words, new example.

Week 4: one longer walkthrough (60-90 seconds) of filling the SOP, still pointing at the same \$19 checkout. No live required if they hate live; a longer screen-record counts.

What happened

Views were uneven. Two posts did nothing. One walkthrough got saves from other solo operators. A stranger bought on day 18 from the bio after watching the timer video and the three-paragraph video. Jordan asked what they watched. They said the timer. That became the next five posts. Jordan did not start TikTok on day 19. They did not explain their other two file ideas in a 20-second clip. They posted the SOP, \$19, one platform.

Copy you can actually send

Hook (spoken, first second)

Stop starting from a blank chat if you need [result] this week.

Other hooks that fit the formula:

Stop doing [common thing] if you want [result].

If your [artifact] looks like this, that is why [bad result].

I timed this. [N] seconds. Then I sent it.

End card (spoken, last two seconds)

The file is \$19. Link in bio. One job, not a catalog.

Caption

One sentence that repeats the hook. Then: SOP is \$19, link in bio. No 15 hashtags. Three at most if the platform is picky, none if it is not.

Pin comment

SOP is \$19. Link in bio. If you want the [job] sequence without guessing, that is the file.

DM when someone comments "link?"

Here: [link]. \$19, one page, instant. If it is not useful, email me and I will refund. I will not hop on a call to recap the SOP.

Reply to an objection on camera

"I do not want to show my face."

Then screen-record the SOP. Your voice on the page is enough. Faceless slideshows with no offer are how people post for months and sell nothing. The offer still sits at the end.

"I need more followers first."

You need a profile visit that becomes a checkout. Fifty of the right watchers beat 5,000 tourists. Do not buy followers. Post the next one.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1: 7 videos, same offer

Evenings: one batch session (two hours, seven clips) on Sunday or Monday. Post one a day. Same end card. Do not check analytics for more than five minutes. You do not have enough posts to learn anything yet.

Week 2: 7 more, comments become scripts

Read every comment. Paste the objections into a note. Generate outlines, rewrite, film. If you have no comments yet, film the three objections you already believe: too simple, no time, I could do this myself. Answer them in 20 seconds.

Week 3: repeat winners

Look at saves and comments, not views. Repeat those shapes with new examples. Kill the clever ones nobody saved. Still one platform. Still \$19.

Week 4: one longer piece, same checkout

One live or one longer walkthrough pointing at the same checkout. If live terrifies you, a 60-second screen-record of the SOP filled in is enough. Then keep posting the five shapes you are keeping. Plan the next 30 only after a stranger has bought or you have 30 honest posts, whichever comes first.

Quality bar

Voice

A voice you would use in a kitchen. If you would not say "smash that" to a friend, do not say it here. AI outlines; you say it. If a line makes you wince when you hear the playback, cut it.

Picture

On-screen text, always, for muted watchers. Face or screen, one style for 30 days. Lighting can be a window. Audio can be the phone mic if you are in a quiet room. Fix captions in CapCut so the \$19 line is spelled right.

Offer

If the last two seconds do not name the file and the price, the video failed the bar even if it performed. Entertainment you are not getting paid for is the original warning. Put the offer on.

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

Count these

Posts published (aim 7 a week, 30 in the window)

Saves and comments, especially objections you can reuse

Profile visits

Link taps

Emails captured or \$19 checkouts from the bio

Which 5 shapes earned the saves

Ignore these

Follower count as a goal. View spikes with no taps. Likes from people who will never buy.

Completions on a video with no offer. How you look. Whether a stranger on the internet said you should try a different platform.

The first-sale definition

A profile visit that becomes an email or a \$19 checkout. That is the metric this path names. If you have 40,000 views and zero taps, the bio or the end card is wrong. Fix those before you film video 41.

Objections you will hear

"The algorithm hates me."

You have not posted 30 times. Post. Then look at saves, not at a theory about the algorithm. Switching platforms when a post dies is a listed mistake.

"I need to be on all five apps."

Five platforms is in the leave-alone line. One platform for 30 days. After a stranger buys, you can remix the five winning shapes onto a second app. Not before.

"Faceless is easier."

Faceless slideshows with no offer are how people hide. If you screen-record the work and speak, that is not a slideshow. If you post silent carousels of quotes, you are not on this path.

"I will buy views to jump-start."

Buying views is in the leave-alone line. You will get tourists and a fake sense of momentum. Organic posts that name a \$19 file convert. Paid views of a no-offer clip do not.

"I do not have anything to sell yet."

Then this is not your first path. Ship a \$19 SOP or playbook this week (Sell an AI playbook, AI templates and SOPs, Niche prompt stacks). Then post. Short-form without a file is a hobby with better lighting.

How this feeds other paths

What you are driving traffic to

Sell an AI playbook, Niche prompt stacks, Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack, AI templates and SOPs — any one \$19-\$47 file. Short-form is the tap. The file is the drink. Your front door can sit in the bio later: a diagnostic, email required, then the file. Not in week 1 if a Stan checkout already works.

What the comments become

Objections become A weekly AI letter. Walkthroughs become Long-form explainers. The winning hook becomes Creator ads with AI scripts when you are ready to pay for traffic — after a stranger has bought organic. Live drops of AI packs can be announced in the same 20-second end card.

What you do not feed yet

A small AI membership, a catalog, a coaching call. Thirty days, one file. Local businesses + AI can use the same clips as proof you can make simple videos for a nearby owner, billed as a service. That is extra, not the 30-day job.

Mistakes that kill this path

The listed ones

Posting with no offer. Switching platforms when a post dies. Using a voice you would not use in a kitchen. Buying followers. Explaining your whole catalog in 20 seconds.

The quiet ones

Waiting for a better microphone. Batching zero videos so you negotiate with yourself every morning. Changing the offer in week 2. Reading the AI outline word for word. Hashtag stuffing instead of a pin comment. Checking views hourly. Starting over on Monday.

The 20-second catalog

If you name three products, they will buy none. One job. One price. One link. Jordan did not mention the other files. You should not either.

Tools and how you actually use them

Capture and edit

Phone. Front camera or screen record. CapCut for captions and a trim. No extra apps in week 1. A window is the light. A quiet room is the mic. If the first second is sharp enough to read on mute, you passed.

One platform for 30 days

TikTok, Instagram, or YouTube Shorts. Pick the one you already open at night. Post from the phone you filmed on. Do not build a desktop pipeline until you have 30 posts.

The link

Stan or Beacons in the bio. One button. The \$19-\$47 file. Test it on cellular, not only wifi. If the link needs a landing page with five choices, you built a menu. Cut it back to one.

Ship checklist

Before you post video 1

- One file live at \$19-\$47
- One platform chosen
- Bio is one line plus the link
- Link tested on your phone
- 20 hooks generated; three you would actually say
- Three videos filmed: mistake, principle, walkthrough
- End card words decided and reused

Every posting day

- On-screen text for mute
- Offer spoken at the end
- Pin comment with the \$19 next step
- Captions fixed in CapCut
- Comments read and saved into a note

After 30

- Keep 5 shapes (saves and comments)
- Kill the rest
- Do not switch platforms
- Ask the first buyer which video they watched

FAQ

Which platform?

The one you already open. TikTok, Instagram, or YouTube Shorts. Not all three. If you do not open any of them, this path will feel like homework. Pick Instagram if you hate TikTok's tone. Pick Shorts if you already lurk on YouTube. Then stay.

Face or screen?

Pick one for 30 days. Face if you can talk. Screen if the product is the SOP or the prompt. Mixing both every other day is how you never get a recognizable shape.

How long is a video?

20 seconds is the default. 15 seconds of teaching, 2 seconds of offer. A week-4 walkthrough can be 60 seconds. Do not start at 3 minutes.

What if I miss a day?

Post two the next day. Do not restart the 30. The clock includes messy weeks. You have a job; batch on the weekend so weekdays are just tap-post.

Do I need CapCut Pro?

No. Captions and a trim. Phone tools are enough if CapCut annoys you. The original tools line is Phone, CapCut, one platform, Stan or Beacons. Stay there.

Can I use AI voice?

You can, and it usually sounds like a press release. This path wants you to say it. Screen-record plus your voice is the backup if you will not show a face.

What if nothing sells after 30 posts?

Check, in order: is the file live, is the price spoken, is the link working, is the bio one offer. Then look at the 5 shapes with saves. Repeat those. Ask two watchers what they thought you sold. If they cannot name the file, your end card failed.

Should I buy a microphone and lights?

Not in the first 30. A quiet room and a window. Spend after a stranger checkout if audio was the complaint.

Can I post the same video on two platforms?

Not as a way to skip the 30 on one. After 30, remix the five winners. During the 30, one room.

Is this the same as Creator ads with AI scripts?

No. This is organic posting to a \$19 file. Creator ads is paid traffic later, with scripts, after you know which shape converts. Do not run ads to a video you posted twice.



PATH 05

A weekly AI letter

A list is the one asset a platform cannot take from you in an afternoon.

19 minute read · 4,212 words

Who this is for

You can write clearly once a week. You want an asset that compounds.

Time to first

2–4 weeks to a real list

Tools

First sale

Fifty honest subscribers and one reply that is not spam.

Cash window

Sells the playbook after trust

Leave this alone

Beehiiv or MailerLite, a one-page diagnostic as the lead magnet, a form.

Daily blasts. Buying a list. Essays nobody asked for.

What the letter is for

The letter is not a blog. It is a weekly appointment. One idea, one story, one ask. That is the whole shape. If you cannot say those three things about an issue before you write it, you do not have an issue yet.

A blog sits on a URL and waits. A letter arrives. The reader did not hunt for you that morning. You showed up in a place they already check: the inbox. That is why a list is the one asset a platform cannot take from you in an afternoon. A handle can vanish. An inbox you earned stays.

One idea, one story, one ask The idea is a single useful claim, small enough to finish in four hundred words. Not “how to use AI.” Something like “the follow-up I send twenty minutes after a call, and the two lines I never skip.” The story is one real moment that makes the idea true: a client who went quiet, a Tuesday you almost skipped, a prompt that failed until you added one constraint. The ask is one action. Reply with a score. Try the prompt. Forward this to the one person who keeps starting from a blank page. Not three actions. One.

AI drafts. You cut. You may let a model outline the issue or tighten a muddy paragraph. You may not let it publish. Cut until it sounds like you on a Tuesday. If you would not say the sentence to a person across a table, it does not go in the letter. The reader can smell a paste. They came for a person who does the job, not for a summary of a summary.

When you sell You sell inside the letter after they have heard from you enough to trust the voice. Email one is the diagnostic and the welcome. Emails 2–6 teach. Email 7 can ask. If you pitch in email one like a late-night ad, they leave. Trust is not a mood. Trust is six useful Tuesdays in a row.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can write clearly once a week and you want an asset that compounds. You do not need a following. You need one job you can talk about without inventing a persona, and the discipline to show up on the same day.

You are a fit if You already explain things in messages, comments, or client notes, and people write back. You can keep a promise that is boring: same day, same length, same person.

You are also a fit if you already have (or will soon have) a \$47 playbook, a template, or a named package. The letter is how those things get sold without shouting.

Skip this path if You cannot keep a weekly date for four weeks. The letter dies from missed Tuesdays, not from a weak logo. Skip it if you want daily growth hacks, if you plan to buy a list, or if you only write when you have a launch. Skip it if you have never finished a result for anyone, including yourself. Teach after you have a scar. Not before.

If you need money this week, run a productized package first, then start the letter with the notes from that job.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you pick a logo: “Every Tuesday I send one useful note to [specific person] about [named job], plus a free one-page diagnostic. After you have a few issues, you can buy the \$47 playbook if you want the full sequence. If not, you still get the letter.”

If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have a letter. You have a mood.

The free thing is the door The lead magnet is a one-page scorecard or a 7-day checklist. It has to be useful even if they never buy. That is the deal you keep. A scorecard that tells them which step to skip this week is a door. A “free” PDF that is only a sales letter is a trap, and they will treat you like one.

Put the form on the same page as your paid offer, but second. Free first is how strangers become a list. The paid button can wait.

What you are not offering You are not offering a community, a course, a daily brief, or “all of AI.” You are offering a weekly appointment and one paid file when trust exists. Keep the sentence short enough to paste into a bio.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done for the first month is not a launch. Done is fifty honest subscribers and one reply that is not spam. Honest means they gave you an email because they wanted the next Tuesday, not because a pop-up lied.

The weekly bar - Same day every week. If you promised Tuesday, it leaves Tuesday. - Same length. Four hundred to seven hundred words. Long enough to teach one thing. Short enough to finish on a phone. - One ask at the end. Count them. If you have three, delete two. - A subject line a human would open. Not “Newsletter #4.”

The money bar Email 7 (or the quieter monthly issue) points to the \$47 playbook without a countdown clock or a fake scarcity line. A sale from a subscriber who has read you is done. A sale from a stranger who never joined the list is a different path. Do not mix them in your head.

If you have the fifty names, the weekly habit, and one real reply, you have a letter. Everything else is decoration.

How the money works

The letter is free. That is not a slogan. It is the business model. You do not charge for the appointment. You charge for the file after the appointment has earned the right.

What you sell, and when The first paid offer inside the letter is the playbook: \$47, theirs to keep. Not a subscription in month one. Not a \$297 cohort. You have no proof yet, and they have six issues of trust, not a year.

Emails 2–6 should not sell. They should make the playbook obvious without naming a cart. When you finally ask, the sentence is calm: the full sequence is \$47, and next Tuesday still arrives either way.

What you never do for money You never sell the list. You never rent it. You never buy someone else's. Deliverability is the business. One rented blast can train the inbox to treat you as junk, and you will not know until Tuesday stops landing.

A sponsorship can wait until you would run the ad even if they paid you nothing. If you would not, skip it.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a brand kit. You need issue one, a form, and a free file that works.

Hours 1–8: write the first issue by hand Pick the reader. Pick the one job. Write issue one without a model in the room. A story you actually lived, one idea, one ask. Then, if you want, run it through AI to tighten — not to inflate. Cut every sentence that sounds like a keynote.

Subject line for issue one: something they can picture. “The 20-minute follow-up I actually send” beats “Welcome to the letter.”

Hours 9–16: the free file and the form Build a one-page scorecard or a 7-day checklist. Seven questions that change the advice, or seven days that a tired person can actually do. Export a clean PDF. Put your name and a reply-to on it.

Open Beehiiv or MailerLite. Create one form. One field besides email is plenty: first name, or the job they do. Not a twelve-field survey. Connect the welcome that delivers the file at once. If the

file arrives tomorrow, you already taught them you are slow.

Hours 17–24: ten humans, not a launch Send issue one to ten people you know. Ask them to reply with the line that was useful. That reply is your subject-line research. Do not ask “did you like it?” Ask for the line. Put the form on the same page as your offer, but second.

By hour 72 you should have a live form, a working welcome, issue one in ten inboxes, and one sentence from a real person you can steal for the next subject line.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. Do them in order. Skipping ahead to “write a better brand” is how letters stay imaginary.

Step 1. Promise one specific weekly note Name the day. Name the length. Name the person it is for. Keep it. Same day, same length. If you cannot keep Tuesday, do not print Tuesday on the form.

Step 2. Name the one reader Write one sentence about one person. Not “entrepreneurs.” A solo bookkeeper who hates the blank follow-up. A tradesperson who wants five posts without sitting on a phone. If two readers appear, you have two letters. Pick one.

Step 3. Build the diagnostic One page. Scorecard or 7-day checklist. Useful if they never buy. If you cannot use it yourself this week, it is not ready.

Step 4. Stand up the form Beehiiv or MailerLite. One form, one welcome, one tag if you must. Test from a second email. Confirm the file arrives and the unsubscribe works.

Step 5. Write issue one by hand Then optionally tighten with a model. Publish only the version that sounds like you.

Step 6. Subject lines that are specific “The 20-minute follow-up I actually send,” not “Newsletter #4.” Steal the useful line from those first ten replies. Specific beats clever. Clever dies in a promotions tab.

Step 7. End with one ask Reply, click, or try the prompt. Not three. The reply is the gold. A click is fine. A prompt they can run in five minutes is better than a survey.

Step 8. Teach for five issues Emails 2–6 are the job, in pieces. One piece per Tuesday. No cart. No “by the way I sell a thing” in paragraph two. You are earning the seventh email.

Step 9. The quieter ask Once a month, a quieter issue that points to the paid file. Email 7 can ask. Calm, priced, easy to ignore.

Step 10. Never buy a list. Never scrape Your deliverability is the business. Fifty names who open beat five thousand who never did.

Step 11. Turn replies into issues When someone writes “I get stuck after the call,” that is next Tuesday. The letter gets easier when you stop inventing topics and start answering mail.

Step 12. Keep the date for twelve weeks before you add anything No daily version. No second letter. Twelve Tuesdays. Then look at what they replied to, and only then consider a second product.

Worked example: Elena’s Tuesday letter

Elena used to coordinate jobs at a small studio. She was good at the twenty minutes after a client call: recap, next step, date. When she went solo, the blank follow-up came back. She wrote the sequence down so she would stop rewriting it. That file sat on her desktop for two months. Then she started a Tuesday letter so the file would have somewhere to live.

The promise Every Tuesday, one note for people who sell work from a kitchen table and freeze after the call. Four hundred to six hundred words. No daily blast, no “week in AI.” She named it after the day.

The door The free file is a one-page scorecard: seven questions about how they follow up, a score, and one next step. “Reply with your score and I will tell you which path to skip.” That line is in the welcome. She put the form above the \$47 button on her page. Free first.

The first four Tuesdays Issue one: the 20-minute follow-up she actually sends, with the two lines she never skips. She wrote it by hand, then asked a model to cut forty words, then put twenty back because the cuts had removed her. She sent it to ten people she had worked with. Four replied. Three quoted the same sentence about not asking “how are you” in sentence one if you already know. That sentence became the subject line of issue two.

Issues two through six taught the rest of the job: the recap template, the prompt that turns messy notes into a recap without sounding like a robot, what to do when they go quiet, how to close a loop on Friday. No pitch.

The ask Issue seven was quieter. She told the story of the desktop file. Then: “If you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday.” Seven people bought in ten days. She had eighty-one subscribers. Not a viral moment. A letter.

Elena did not buy ads. She did not scrape. She asked those first ten, then asked each new subscriber to forward the diagnostic to one person who hates the blank follow-up.

Copy you can paste

Use these as drafts. Swap the job. Keep the calm.

Form headline Seven questions. A score. One next step.
Free even if you never buy. The Tuesday letter comes after.

Welcome (email one) Here is the one-page diagnostic. Reply with your score and I will tell you which path to skip. I write once a week, on Tuesday, about [job]. One idea, one story, one ask. If that is not useful, unsubscribe. I will not be sad, and you will not hear from me again.

Issue close (teaching weeks) If you try this, reply with the line that worked — or the line that died. I read them. See you next Tuesday.

Issue close (the ask) If you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday.

Personal invite (send to ten people) I started a Tuesday letter for [person] who [job]. Issue one is the [specific thing]. If you want it: [form]. If you have two minutes, reply with the line that was useful. That is the whole ask.

Subject lines that behave The 20-minute follow-up I actually send Stop asking “just checking in” The recap I send before I open the next tab A 7-question score, not another pep talk What I cut from last week’s prompt

Bio line One useful Tuesday note about [job].
Free diagnostic at the link. No daily blasts.

Week-by-week

Assume you have a job and evenings. This is four weeks to a real list, not a media company.

Week 1: form plus issue one Day 1–2: write the diagnostic and issue one by hand. Day 3: Beehiiv or MailerLite, form, welcome, test-buy of the free file from a second email. Day 4: send issue one to ten people you know. Day 5–7: collect the useful lines. Do not redesign the header.

Week 2: issue two plus ten personal invites Send issue two on the promised day. Invite ten more humans with the personal copy, not a broadcast. If someone forwards you a kind reply, ask if you can use the line (no last name required).

Week 3: teach one path Issue three is one chapter of the job. No pitch. If you have the \$47 playbook drafted, do not mention the price yet. Mention the problem the playbook solves, in human words.

Week 4: a quiet ask for the paid file If you have sent four useful issues and you have a file that works, you may ask. If the file is not ready, keep teaching. A bad ask costs more than a late one. After week 4, the cadence is the job: same day, one idea, one story, one ask. Once a month, the quieter issue with the \$47 link.

Do not add a Friday bonus letter in month two because you felt guilty about a slow week. Guilt is not a publishing calendar.

The quality bar

A good issue can be read in four minutes and used in twenty. If they cannot use it this week, it was an essay.

The kitchen-table test Read the issue out loud. If you would not say it to one person at a table, cut it. Hype, throat-clearing, and “as you know” go first. Named tools and named steps stay.

The Tuesday test Would this still be true next Tuesday if a model version changed? Teach the job, not the button labels of

one chat window. You can name a tool. Do not marry a menu.

The AI test If you paste the issue back into a blank chat and it could have written the whole thing, you have not written it. Add the scar: what failed, what you still do, the sentence you almost sent. That is the part they cannot download for free.

One typo will not kill you. A voice that sounds like a press release will.

What to count (and what to ignore)

Count a short list. Ignore the rest for the first two months.

Count these - Honest subscribers. Fifty is the first milestone. Not a purchased fifty. - Replies that are not spam. One real reply is worth more than a 60 percent open rate with silence. - Issues sent on the promised day. A 12-for-12 streak beats a viral issue you cannot repeat. - Unsubscribes per issue. A few means people are reading. Zero can mean you are too bland to bother leaving. - Playbook sales from the list after the ask. Note the issue number. That is your sales page, whether you like the design or not.

Ignore these for now Follower count on the platform you used to announce the letter. Daily growth charts. Open-rate panic below a number you saw in a thread. Different tools count opens differently, and image-blocking will lie to you.

If fifty people are on the list, ten open, and two reply, you have a letter.

Objections you will hear (including your own)

“I do not have an audience.” You need ten people who will tell you the useful line. Audience is what the letter builds. It is not a prerequisite. Write issue one,

send it to ten names in your phone, stop waiting for permission from a feed.

“Email is dead.” It is not. It is quiet. Quiet is why it still works. The people who say it is dead are tired of blasts. Do not send blasts. Send a Tuesday.

“I should wait until I have the playbook perfect.” The letter can start with the diagnostic. The \$47 file can land in week 4. Waiting for perfect is how you miss twelve Tuesdays.

“People will copy me.” They might copy the structure. They will not copy the scar. Teach anyway.

“I write too slow.” Good. Slow is a filter. Four hundred honest words beat twelve hundred padded ones. Set a two-hour cap. When the cap hits, cut, do not expand.

“What if nobody replies?” Ask a better ask. “Was this good?” dies. “Reply with the line you would actually send” lives. Also: write to one person. Letters to a crowd get silence. Letters to a name get mail.

What this path feeds

The letter is not a side hobby. It is the pipe.

What it fills It sells the playbook after trust — that is the cash window on purpose. It also sells templates when you mention the filled example you used this week. It throws off service work when someone replies “can you just do this for me?” That reply is a package, not a free consulting hour. Put the price in the reply or send the cheaper file.

Affiliate mentions belong below the reasoning, never above it, and only for tools you still use. The letter can carry that link because the trust already exists. Do not turn Tuesday into a

tool dump.

What it needs It needs a door: a diagnostic and a form. It needs one paid file worth asking for. It does not need a membership, a chat room, or a second newsletter. Those come after the Tuesday habit is boring, which is the goal.

Mistakes that kill the letter

Writing for a crowd Writing for search engines instead of one person. The inbox is not Google. A keyword in the subject that no human would say is how you train them to skim.

Letting AI publish unedited. The first draft from a model is a pile of true-sounding sentences. Your job is to make it specific, short, and slightly uncomfortable, the way a real Tuesday is.

Breaking the Tuesday promise Changing the promise every week. Tuesday is follow-up, then Friday is branding, then you skip a week for a “personal update.” That is not a letter. That is a mood board with a send button.

Sending only when you have a launch. Then you are not a letter. You are a store that opens four times a year and wonders why the door sticks.

Daily blasts. Buying a list. Essays nobody asked for. Those three are how small senders become noise. Do not. A 40-field form, a welcome that is only a pitch, and hiding the unsubscribe all show up later as a deliverability problem you will blame on the tool.

Tools (keep this small)

Beehiiv or MailerLite. Pick one. Do not split the list. A one-page diagnostic as the lead magnet. A form. That is the stack.

Why these and not a maze You need a place that sends, tracks unsubscribes, and delivers a file. You do not need a customer-data platform, a

popup that follows people around, or five landing-page builders. One page with the form second and the paid button third is enough.

How to use AI here Draft and tighten. Not send. Not invent subscriber stories. Not write fake testimonials. If you use a model to outline issue two, you still rewrite every paragraph in the voice you would use at a table.

What to leave on the shelf Daily sending tools. Scrapers. Anything that promises you a list by Friday. The list you did not earn will not open.

Checklist

Print this. Tick it.

Before you send issue one - One reader, written in one sentence - One promised day and a length you can keep - Diagnostic: one-page scorecard or 7-day checklist, useful if they never buy - Beehiiv or MailerLite account, one form, welcome that delivers the file at once - Test from a second email: file arrives, unsubscribe works - Issue one written by hand, then tightened, then read out loud - Subject line a human would open - One ask at the end - Form on the same page as the offer, but second

The first month - Ten people you know received issue one - You collected the useful lines - Issues 2–6 teach; no cart in paragraph one - Once, a quieter issue that can point to the \$47 playbook - No list bought, no scrape, no daily extra

You may ask for money when - The free file works without you in the room - You have kept the day - You can say the price in one calm sentence

FAQ

How long should each issue be? Four hundred to seven hundred words. If you need two thousand, you have two issues. Split them. Tired people finish short letters.

Beehiiv or MailerLite — which one? Either. Pick the one you will actually log into. Switching later is a tax. Features you will not use are not a reason.

Can I send on Sunday if I promised Tuesday? No. Send Tuesday, even if it is shorter. If you must move the day, say so once, then keep the new day. Random is how they stop opening.

What if I have nothing to sell yet? Run the letter on the diagnostic for a month. Teach. Build the \$47 playbook from the replies. The list is still the asset. The cart can wait four weeks. It should not wait four years.

Should I add a podcast / YouTube / daily notes? Not until twelve Tuesdays have left on time. Extra channels are how letters starve.

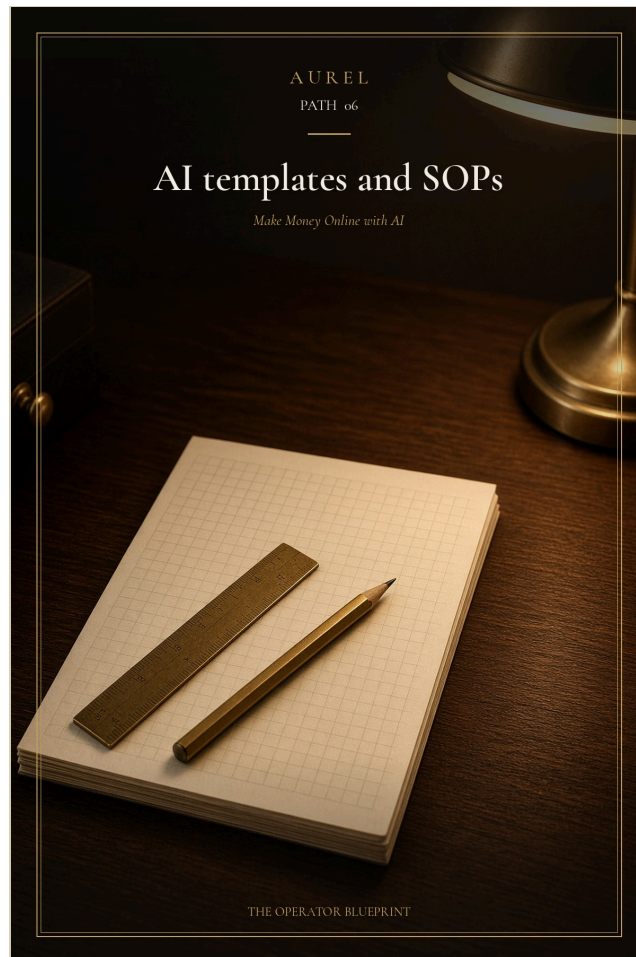
Is fifty subscribers too small to ask for \$47? No. Elena asked at eighty-one and sold seven. Fifty honest names who have read you will outbuy five thousand quiet ones. Ask calmly. Do not apologize for the price.

What do I do with a mean reply? Unsubscribe them if they want out. If it is a real critique of the work, steal the useful part and ignore the heat. Do not write a Tuesday about your feelings unless that is the job you promised.

Can I use their reply in the next issue? Ask. “Can I use this line, no name?” Most people say yes. A few will want a first name. Do not invent a testimonial.

When do I buy ads to the form? After the welcome works, the diagnostic is useful, and you have at least four issues in the can.

What if I miss a week because life happened? Send a short note: “I missed Tuesday. Here is a short one. Back next week.” Then be back. Two misses in a row is a new habit.



PATH 06

AI templates and SOPs

A filled example sells. An empty grid is homework.

18 minute read · 4,006 words

Who this is for

You already run a repeatable process: intake, content calendar, invoice, weekly review.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

A \$19 template that saves someone an afternoon.

Cash window

\$12–\$29, or \$47 for a bundle of three

Leave this alone

Notion, Google Sheets, Canva, the prompts that generate the filled version.

Empty aesthetic planners. Fifty messy files.

What you are selling

The file is the product. The prompt that fills it is the leverage. Together they let a buyer go from zero to a working system in ten minutes. That is the promise. If it takes an hour of setup, you built software, not a template.

A template in this path is not a pretty empty grid. It is a working example of a job you already do — intake, content calendar, invoice, weekly review — plus the block at the top that rebuilds a filled version from a few inputs. The buyer should be able to duplicate, paste, and move. They should not need a course to sit down.

Why the filled example is the product Show a filled example. A blank Notion dashboard photographs well and converts poorly. People buy the picture of work already done. They do not buy the homework of naming columns. If your listing image is a lavender empty table with cute icons, you are competing with every aesthetic planner on earth, and you will lose on taste.

What this is not It is not an “OS.” It is not a second brain. It is not fifty nested pages. Those words hide a checklist. Call it what it does on a Tuesday: the weekly content calendar, the intake that does not lose notes, the invoice tracker you actually open. If you cannot say the Tuesday problem in one line, you do not have a product yet. You have a file dump.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already run a repeatable process. You do not need to be a Notion consultant. You need a job you have done more than three times, in a tool you can duplicate without breaking.

You are a fit if You have a calendar, a sheet, or a form you reuse. Other people have asked “can I have that?” You can screenshot a filled week without leaking a client. You are willing to write one prompt that takes a few inputs and returns the filled table, not a poem about productivity.

Skip this path if You only have a blank aesthetic you liked on Pinterest. Empty planners are a crowded street, and you will spend a month on icons. Skip it if your process only lives in your head and has never survived a second week. Skip it if you want to ship fifty messy files and call it a pack. One clean file beats a zip of leftovers.

If you have never kept a calendar for yourself, do not sell one. Use it for two weeks. Then sell the version that has scars: the column you deleted, the status you actually use, the prompt that stopped making twelve posts you would never publish.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this on a sticky note: “A filled [job] template plus the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes, for [person] who [Tuesday problem]. \$19. Duplicate, paste, go.”

Examples that work: a filled weekly content calendar for a one-person shop that never knows what to post. An intake database for a freelancer who loses notes in chat. An invoice tracker for a tradesperson who forgets to send the second bill. The job is in the title. The prompt is in the file. The price is on the button.

The bundle, later A bundle of three related files at \$29 outsells one lonely file at \$12 if they clearly belong together. Calendar plus intake plus weekly review is a week. Calendar plus a mood board plus a habit tracker is a drawer. Related means they share a Tuesday. Unrelated means you are hoping they like your taste.

A \$47 bundle of three is allowed when each file is used, filled, and documented. Do not jump to \$47 because three sounds premium. Jump when a buyer would spend an afternoon without them.

The ten-minute promise If a reasonably tired person cannot get a usable filled week in ten minutes with your how-to open, you overbuilt. Delete tabs until the promise is true.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done is a \$19 template that saves someone an afternoon. Not a library. Not a mobile app. A file they can duplicate today.

The file bar - One Tuesday problem on the cover and in the title -
 A filled example, not an empty grid, in the first screenshot - The AI prompt as a block at the top: inputs in, filled table out - Personal data stripped. Fake names are fine. Real client emails are not -
 A one-page how-to with screenshots. No video required for v1 -
 Works on a phone well enough to read, even if they edit on a laptop

The money bar Checkout works. They get the file. A stranger who is not you can follow the how-to without sending you a voice note. That is done. A three-file bundle at \$29 is a second done, after the first file has been used by someone else.

How to price without guessing

First file: \$19. That is the default. \$12 if the job is tiny (one sheet, ten rows). \$29 if the file is clearly a week of work and the prompt is tested. Do not start at \$79. You have no reviews and a duplicate button.

Why \$19 is the honest first price It is small enough that a tired person will try it to save an afternoon. It is large enough that you will not feel used when they email a question. If you are ashamed of \$19, you either overbuilt or you do not believe the afternoon is real. Cut the file, or use it yourself for another week.

The bundle math One lonely file at \$12 looks cheap and unfinished. Three related files at \$29 look like a week. Chris does this on purpose (see the example): the calendar at \$19, then the three-file bundle at \$29 so the calendar buyer has a next step that is not “buy a course.” A \$47 bundle of three is the later price, when you have proof and a how-to that has been yelled at.

What you do not price You do not charge extra for “lifetime updates” you will not ship. You do not add a \$9 monthly for a template. If they need you every month, that is a service or a membership, not this path.

The first 72 hours

You are not inventing a system from a blank page. You are cleaning the one you already use.

Day 1: duplicate and strip Open the template you already live in. Duplicate it. Strip personal data. Rename the sample person to something obviously fake. Fill one real-looking week so the screenshot has texture: statuses, dates, a note that sounds like work, not “lorem.” Delete every tab you have not opened in fourteen days. Forty tabs is how buyers bounce.

Day 2: the prompt and the how-to Write the prompt that regenerates a filled sample from a few inputs: business, audience, offer, days they can post, voice in one line. Put that prompt in a block at the top of the file. Run it. Paste the output into the filled example. Fix the prompt until the table is usable, not until it is clever.

Write one page of how-to. Screenshots of: duplicate, paste inputs, run prompt, paste results, what “done” looks like. No video required for v1. Export. Screenshot the filled version, not the empty grid.

Day 3: listing and \$19 Price \$19. Title: “Filled [job] template + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes.” Put it on your site. Etsy if the search

terms are obvious (content calendar, invoice tracker, client intake). Buy it yourself from a second email. If the file does not arrive, nothing else matters. Then send ten messages to people who have the Tuesday problem.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. The file comes from a job you already do. Do not reverse that.

Step 1. Name the Tuesday problem “I never know what to post.” “I lose intake notes.” “I forget to invoice.” One sentence. If you need a paragraph, you have two products. Split them.

Step 2. Start from the file you already use Duplicate. Do not rebuild in a new tool because a thread said it was nicer. The scars are in the current file.

Step 3. Build only the columns or pages that solve that Delete the rest. A content calendar needs: date, channel, hook, body, asset, status, link. It does not need a vision board, a reading list, or a sleep tracker.

Step 4. Fill one honest week Use fake names. Keep the texture of real work. This filled week is your listing image and your quality bar.

Step 5. Put the AI prompt at the top Inputs in, filled table out. Include constraints: length, tone, “do not invent offers I did not type.” Run it twice. If the second run is unusable, the prompt is the product to fix, not the colors.

Step 6. One-page how-to with screenshots Duplicate, paste, run, paste, done. Mobile note: which parts are painful on a phone. No video required for v1.

Step 7. Strip, export, name the file like a human “Weekly-content-calendar-filled.html” or a Notion share the buyer owns after duplicate. Not “FINAL_v7_USE_THIS.”

Step 8. Listing on your site. Etsy if the search terms are obvious Title matches the offer sentence. First image is the filled example. Price \$19.

Step 9. Test-buy. Then ten asks Different browser. Confirm they get access. Message ten people who have the Tuesday problem. Not a blast to a group you lurk in.

Step 10. Fix what the first buyer trips on Usually: permissions, a locked database, a prompt that assumes a tool they do not have. Write that into the how-to. Do not add a tab.

Step 11. Week 2: a three-file bundle Only if the files share a Tuesday. \$29. The first file can stay at \$19 for people who only need the calendar.

Step 12. Do not design forty tabs When you want to add a dashboard, go use the file for a week instead. New tabs are how templates become homework again.

Worked example: Chris and the filled calendar

Chris runs a one-person design practice. Every Sunday he used to stare at a blank week and then post nothing until Wednesday. He built a Notion calendar so he would stop staring. Six columns. One view for the week. A status he actually updates. After two months it was ugly and used, which is the only aesthetic that sells.

The \$19 file He duplicated the calendar. He renamed his clients to “River Bakery” and “Lane Tutoring.” He filled one week: five posts, two stories, one email, statuses in plain words (draft, need photo, scheduled). At the top he wrote a prompt:

Paste: what you sell, who it is for, the one offer this month, days you can post, how you sound in one sentence. Return: a seven-day table with date, channel, hook, body under 80 words, asset needed, status set to draft. Do not invent a second offer. Do not sound like a billboard.

He ran it on his own inputs. He edited two hooks that were cute and useless. He put that filled week in the first screenshot. Title: “Filled weekly content-calendar (Notion) + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes.” \$19. How-to: one page, five screenshots. No video.

The first sales He sent it to eight people who had complained about posting. Three bought in a week. One asked where to put intake notes. That question is how the bundle starts. It is not a reason to add a tab to the calendar.

The \$29 three-file bundle Week 2 he cleaned two other files he already used: a client intake (so notes stop dying in chat) and a Friday weekly review (what shipped, what slipped, what to put in next week’s prompt). Same treatment: filled example, prompt at the top, one-page how-to. Bundle of three at \$29. The calendar stayed available alone at \$19. People who only wanted posts could stay small. People who wanted the week bought the bundle.

Chris did not call it an OS. He did not add a CRM. He did not film a twenty-minute walkthrough for v1. He sold the picture of a week already done, and the prompt that rebuilds it.

Copy you can paste

Swap the job. Keep the filled promise.

Listing title Filled [job] template + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes.

Listing first line You get a filled week, not an empty grid.

Duplicate the Notion (or sheet). Paste a few inputs. Run the prompt. Paste the table. About ten minutes. \$19.

Post under a screenshot of the filled example This is last week’s calendar, names changed. Empty templates are homework. This one is already working. \$19, link in bio. The prompt that rebuilds it sits at the top of the file.

DM I use this every Sunday so I stop staring at a blank week.
 Filled [job] template plus the prompt that rebuilds it. \$19. If
 that saves you an afternoon: [link]. If not, no need to reply.

Bundle line Three files that share a Tuesday: weekly calendar, intake, Friday
 review. \$29. Each one has a filled example and the prompt that rebuilds it.

What not to write “Aesthetic Notion dashboard for CEOs.”
 “Ultimate content OS.” “200+ templates.” Those lines sell a vibe to
 people who will not open the file. You are selling an afternoon back.

Week-by-week

You can do the first sale inside ten days if the file already exists. Do not use week one to learn a
 new tool.

Days 1–2: clean the file you already use Duplicate. Strip. Fill one week. Write the
 prompt. Run it. Fix it. Draft the one-page how-to. Screenshot the filled version.

Day 3: listing \$title, \$19, filled screenshot first, test-buy, ten
 asks. Etsy only if someone would search the job by name.

Days 4–7: silence is data If nobody buys, ask two of the ten what was unclear.
 Usually the title is vague or the screenshot is empty. Fix those. Do not add a tab.

Week 2: a three-file bundle Only related files. \$29. Keep the single at \$19. Do
 not design forty tabs. Do not start a fourth file because bundling felt good.

Weeks 3–4 Use your own file in public: one post that shows this
 week’s filled row (blur what you must). Answer the two questions
 buyers actually ask. Update the how-to. That is the whole month.

The quality bar

A stranger should go from purchase to a filled week in ten minutes without you. That is the bar. Pretty is optional. Clear is not.

The filled-week test Hand the how-to to someone who has not seen the file. Time them. If they need you at minute four, the how-to is missing a screenshot. If they need you at minute twenty because of a nested relation, you built software. Flatten it.

The mobile test Open the file on a phone. Can they read the week? Can they see the prompt? Editing on a phone can be ugly. Reading should not be. Forgetting mobile is how you lose the people who buy at 10 p.m. on a couch.

The prompt test Run the prompt on two different businesses. If both outputs look like the same billboard, add constraints: offer they typed, words they use, length. The prompt is part of the product. A cute template with a lazy prompt is an empty grid with extra steps.

Naming Call it a checklist or a calendar if that is what it is. Calling it an OS when it is a checklist trains buyers to expect a product you did not make, then to leave a review that says so.

What to count

Count a short list for the first twenty sales.

Count these - Sales of the \$19 file. First sale from someone who is not you is the milestone. - Refunds and “I can’t open this” notes. Those are how-to bugs, not personality flaws. - Time-to-filled-week from the one person you watch. Aim under ten minutes. - Bundle attach: how many \$19 buyers take the \$29 three-file set. If none do, the extra files are not related, or you never said they share a

Tuesday. - Which screenshot they linger on, if your host shows it. It should be the filled example.

Ignore these for now Likes on a template aesthetic post. Number of tabs as a flex. A competitor with 4.8 stars and two hundred files. You are not in a volume contest. You are in an afternoon-saving contest.

If you have three sales and zero open tickets, you are fine. If you have thirty views and zero sales, the screenshot is empty or the title hides the job. Fix the listing before you rebuild the file.

Objections you will hear

“Notion templates are everywhere and cheap.” Empty ones are. Filled ones with a prompt that rebuilds the week are not everywhere. Compete on the Tuesday problem and the example, not on pastel.

“People will just copy the structure.” They will. The prompt, the filled week, and the how-to still save an afternoon. You are selling time, not a secret column name.

“I should record a course first.” No. One-page how-to. Screenshots. No video required for VI. A course is a different path and a longer delay. If they cannot sit down without a forty-minute video, the file is too clever.

“\$19 feels too low.” Good. Sell ten. Then offer the \$29 bundle. Then, with proof, a \$47 set of three that is actually used. Pride is not a price.

“What if they want it in a different tool?” Pick Notion or Google Sheets or Canva — the one you already use. A second version is a second product. Mention the tool in the title so they do not buy the wrong one.

“I do not have three files.” Then sell one at \$19. The bundle is week 2, not a requirement for week 1. A single honest file beats a padded zip.

What this path feeds

A template is a thin product that throws off thicker ones.

What it fills The letter can show this week’s filled row and link the \$19 file. The playbook can include the template as the working file at the back. People who write “can you just fill this for me?” are asking for a productized package, not a free hour. Send the price or send the file. Do not hop on a call that becomes the job.

What it needs It needs a Tuesday problem you have already solved in a tool you control. It does not need a membership to “get all templates.” Fifty messy files is the thing to leave alone. One file that works, then a bundle of three that belong together.

Mistakes that stall this path

Aesthetic, tabs, and homework Competing only on aesthetic. Taste is not a Tuesday problem. A filled ugly calendar will outsell an empty beautiful one.

Shipping 40 tabs. Each tab is a place to get lost. Delete until the how-to fits on one page.

Forgetting mobile. If the week cannot be read on a phone, a lot of your buyers will bounce after they pay, which is the worst bounce.

No example. An empty grid is homework. People do not buy homework when they are already tired.

Naming and the zip of leftovers Calling it an “OS” when it is a checklist. You will attract buyers who want a company, and they will

tell you your checklist is incomplete. They are right about the naming.

Also: fifty messy files in a zip. A prompt that generates fluff. Listing photos of mockups with no real rows. Hiding the tool name so both Notion people and sheet people are annoyed. Locking the database so duplicate does nothing. Those are how \$19 turns into a refund.

Tools (the ones you already use)

Notion, Google Sheets, Canva, and the prompts that generate the filled version. Pick the tool the job already lives in.

Notion Good for calendars, intakes, and reviews with a few views. Bad when you nest five relations and call it simple. Duplicate must work. Permissions must not block the buyer.

Google Sheets Good for invoices, trackers, and anything that wants a sum. Put the prompt in row 1 as a note, or on a tab named HOW-TO so it cannot be missed. Filled example on the first tab.

Canva Good when the deliverable is a thing they will post or print: a carousel, a one-pager, a simple invoice. Still show a filled example. An empty brand kit is another aesthetic trap.

The prompt Lives in the file. Inputs in, filled table out. Tested on two businesses. This is not a separate course. It is a block at the top.

Leave empty aesthetic planners and fifty messy files on the shelf. You already know they do not save an afternoon.

Checklist

Tick this before you raise the price.

File - Tuesday problem in one line - Duplicated from a file you actually use - Personal data stripped - One filled week with fake names and real texture - Extra tabs deleted - Prompt at the top: inputs, output format, constraints - Prompt run twice on different inputs - One-page how-to with screenshots - Readable on a phone

Listing - Title: Filled [job] template + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes - First image is the filled example, not the empty grid - Tool named (Notion, Sheets, or Canva) - Price \$19 (or \$12 if truly tiny) - Test-buy from a second email - Ten personal asks

Week 2 (optional) - Two more related files, same treatment - Bundle \$29 (or \$47 when each file is proven) - Single file still for sale

FAQ

Do I need to be a Notion expert? No. You need a file you already use. If you cannot duplicate it without breaking, simplify until you can. Expertise is not the product. The afternoon saved is.

Can I sell on Etsy only? Sell on your site first so you own the buyer. Etsy if the search terms are obvious: content calendar, invoice tracker, client intake. Title like a search, not like a brand poem.

Should I include a video? Not for v1. One-page how-to. Screenshots. If ten buyers ask the same question, add one short clip of that step. Do not film a course to avoid writing a page.

What if my process lives in three tools? Sell the one that hurts on Tuesday. Mention the others in the how-to as optional. A three-tool setup is how ten minutes becomes an hour.

Is \$29 too cheap for three files? Not if they share a Tuesday and each has a filled example. Chris's bundle is \$29 on purpose. \$47 is later, with proof. Cheap is fifty messy files. Related and filled is the value.

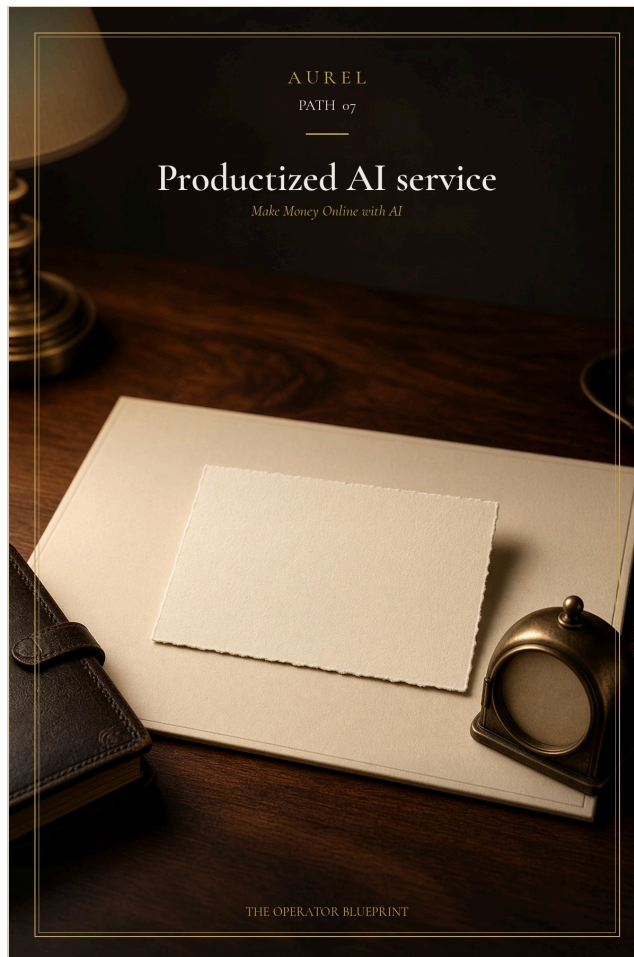
Can I use AI to build the template itself? You can draft columns. You still have to live in the file for a week. A model will give you twenty tabs. You need six.

What license do they get? Personal use, duplicate for their work, no resale of the template as a template. Say that in one paragraph on the how-to. You are not launching a legal department.

Someone wants custom columns. That is a service. Quote a package or say no. Do not turn \$19 into an unpaid rebuild.

The buyer says the prompt is generic. It is. Fix it with their inputs as required fields and a constraint list. Update the file. Send them the new prompt. That update is worth more than a new tab.

When do I make a second product? After the first file has a stranger sale and a how-to that no longer gets the same question. Then a related file, then a \$29 bundle. Not a 50-file vault.



PATH 07

Productized AI service

Do not sell hours. Sell a named package with a date on it.

17 minute read · 3,672 words

Who this is for

You can get a result for someone else in a known number of days, using AI for draft and you for quality.

Time to first

3–14 days with outreach

Tools

First sale

One paid package with a written scope.

Cash window

\$300–\$1,500 first packages

Leave this alone

Calendly, Stripe invoice or deposit link, a one-page agreement.

A menu of 12 services. Unlimited revisions. Custom everything.

Why this prints cash faster than a file

A service is slower to scale and faster to cash. If you need money this month, this path beats a playbook. You will still take notes. Those notes become the file you sell later.

Do not sell hours. Sell a named package with a date on it. Hours train people to haggle your Tuesday. A package trains them to say yes or no.

What a package is The package has a name, a deliverable, a timeline, a price, and a definition of done. “I’ll help with your AI” is not a package. “12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600” is. You can hold the second one in your hand. You can put it on a calendar. You can take a deposit against it.

Where AI sits AI drafts. You edit. They never see the raw model output. Quality is your name, not the model’s. If they wanted the raw window, they would already have it. They are paying for a result that does not sound like a press release, delivered by a date.

What this is not It is not a retainer with vague “AI support.” It is not a menu of twelve services. It is not unlimited revisions. It is not custom everything. Those are how a \$600 job becomes a \$600 relationship that eats your month.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can get a result for someone else in a known number of days, using AI for draft and you for quality. You need one job you have finished more than twice. You need the spine to take a deposit before you open a chat.

You are a fit if People already ask you to “just look at this.” You can name what “done” looks like without a two-hour discovery call. You can keep a 7-day or 14-day date. You are willing to write a one-page agreement that fits on a phone.

Skip this path if You freeze when someone asks what it costs. You want to be available for any AI problem. You cannot say no to a sixth round of “quick tweaks.” You have never shipped the result for yourself. Do not sell a week of posts if you have never posted a week.

If you only want to sell files and never talk to a buyer, use the playbook or template path. This path is faster cash because a human is in the loop. That human is you. Plan for that.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you design a logo: “[Name of package]: [deliverable] in [days] for [price]. You get files, not a login to my brain. One revision window. Deposit holds the seat.”

Sam’s sentence is the model: 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. You can swap the deliverable. You cannot swap the specificity. If you cannot fit the offer on one line, you have two packages. Split them, then pick one.

Who it is for, in the same breath Name the buyer next to the deliverable. “For a one-person shop that needs a week of posts and a page that matches, without living in a chat window.” If the buyer is “anyone using AI,” you will spend intake explaining what you do.

What is in, what is not In: the 12 posts, the one landing draft, one revision, a 15-minute walkthrough, files in a folder they own. Not in: a strategy offsite, a brand workshop, managing their accounts, a second landing page, unlimited voice notes. Write the “not in” list. Buyers relax when they see the walls.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done is one paid package with a written scope. Not a maybe. Not a “we’ll figure it out on a call.”
Money in, scope on a page, date on a calendar.

The job bar - Deliverable they can open without you (a folder they own)
- Timeline you kept, or you told them before the date slipped - One revision window, used or expired - A 15-minute walkthrough, not a second project hiding in a call - They never saw the raw model output

The business bar Deposit arrived before you started. The one-page agreement was sent. You asked for a referral while they were happy. You wrote the SOP so the second job is faster. If you skip the SOP, you sold a job. You did not build a path.

Price, deposit, and the first-seat discount

First packages live at \$300–\$1,500. Under \$300 you will attract people who want a miracle and a friend. Over \$1,500 on job one, you will invent a process during a job that is too expensive to fumble. Sam’s \$600 for a 7-day content-and-landing package sits in the honest middle: real money, finishable week.

How to pick the number Estimate the hours if you were slow, including edits. If it is ten hours and you cannot do it in a week, the package is too big. Cut the deliverable, not the sleep. Then pick a round number you can say out loud without coughing: \$600, \$800, \$1,200. Do not use \$597. You are not a storefront banner.

Deposit Take a deposit before you open a chat window. Half is clean. The rest on delivery, before the revision window if you like, or after the walkthrough. Stripe invoice or a deposit link. If they need to “just hop on a call first,” the call is the job. Charge for a paid consult or send the cheaper file instead.

The first-seat discount Offer one discounted first seat if you need a case, then never discount it again without a reason you can say out loud. “First seat, \$400, I can use the result as a named example” is a reason. “You seem nice” is not. After that seat, full price.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a portfolio site. You need one page, ten asks, and a way to take money.

Hours 1–6: write the package on one page Who it is for. What is in. What is not. Timeline. Price. What they must provide (voice notes, old posts, offer, deadline, three examples they like). How many revisions (one is enough). Deposit. Where the files will live. Put your name and a start date like “next Monday if the deposit is in by Friday.”

Hours 7–24: the rails Calendly for a 15-minute kickoff or walkthrough — not a free hour. Stripe invoice or deposit link. A one-page agreement that repeats the package page in slightly drier words. Test the payment link with a dollar if you need to know it works.

Hours 25–72: ten people who already trust you Send the package to ten people who already trust you. Not a cold list. People who have asked you for help, hired you adjacent, or complained about the exact job. One discounted first seat if you need a case. When they say yes, take the deposit before you open a chat window. Then intake. Then you start.

If nobody says yes in 72 hours, you still have a page. Keep asking. Three to fourteen days with outreach is the window, not three hours of hoping.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. One package all the way through. If you have two, you have none.

Step 1. One package Name, deliverable, days, price. Write it so a tired person can forward it. If you add a second package this week, you will explain both and sell neither.

Step 2. Intake: problem, budget, ability to implement If they have no problem you can name, no budget for \$300–\$1,500, or no ability to post what you make, stop. Send them the cheaper file instead. A buyer who cannot implement will blame the posts.

Step 3. Deposit, then chat Invoice or deposit link first. Kickoff after. Working before the deposit is how “quick questions” become the whole job, unpaid.

Step 4. Kickoff form Assets, voice, deadline, examples they like, words they refuse, the offer the posts must serve. A form beats a 45-minute call that you have to transcribe.

Step 5. You run AI internally Draft in a tool they do not sit in. Edit until it sounds like them, not like a model. They never see the raw output. If a line is wrong, it is your line.

Step 6. Midpoint check, short A screenshot or three sample posts on day 3, not a new scope. If they want a different product, that is a different package after this one.

Step 7. Delivery in a folder they own Google Drive, Notion, a zip — they keep it if you disappear. No hostage login.

Step 8. A 15-minute walkthrough Show them where things live and what to post first. Then stop. The walkthrough is not a workshop.

Step 9. One revision window Written dates. “One round, 48 hours after delivery.” After that, a new package or a polite no.

Step 10. Ask for the referral while they are happy The day of the walkthrough, not a month later. One sentence. One ask.

Step 11. Write the SOP What you asked for, which prompts you used, where you edited, how long it actually took. The second job should be faster. If it is not, you did not write the SOP. You remembered vibes.

Step 12. Full price, no discount The first seat may have been cheaper. This one is not, unless you have a reason you can say out loud. Book the next seat before you invent package two.

Worked example: Sam's \$600 week

Sam writes for small service businesses on the side of a day job. People kept asking for “help with AI content.” That sentence made Sam tired. Sam named a package instead: 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. Files in a folder. One revision. Deposit holds the seat.

The one-pager Who: a one-person shop that already knows what they sell and needs a week of posts plus a page that does not sound like a brochure. In: 12 posts (mix of short updates and two longer notes), one landing draft (headline, sections, FAQ, closing ask), one revision, 15-minute walkthrough. Not in: posting for them, a logo, a second offer, strategy calls. They must provide: offer, three examples they like, words they hate, any photos they already have, a deadline if a launch is real. Timeline: 7 days from deposit. Price: \$600. Deposit: \$300. Revision: one round, 48 hours after delivery.

The first seat Sam sent the page to ten people who had asked for help. One owner of a tutoring practice said yes at \$450 as the case-study seat, with permission to describe the result without student names. Deposit first. Kickoff form the same day. Sam drafted in a private chat, edited every post, and sent three samples on day 3. The owner changed one promise that was too strong.

Sam fixed the rest to match. Day 7: folder, walkthrough, invoice for the balance. One revision on two posts. Done.

After Sam wrote a two-page SOP: form questions, the prompt stack, the edit pass, the folder structure. Next job was \$600, no discount. A referral from the tutor paid for week three. Sam still takes notes for a playbook. The package prints cash this month. The file can wait.

Copy you can paste

Say the package. Then stop talking.

One-pager headline 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days. You get files, not a login to my brain.

Ask (to ten people who already trust you) I have one seat this week for [package] at [price]. Deposit holds it. Here is what is in, what is not, and the date: [link]. If it is not useful, ignore this.

First-seat version I am taking one discounted first seat at [lower price] so I can use the result as a named example (you can say no to the name). Same scope, same week. After this, it is [full price].

After they say yes Sending the deposit link now. Kickoff form follows when it clears. I start on the date in the one-pager, not before.

Referral ask If someone you know needs [package] this month, send them the page. I have [one] seat left in [week]. I will treat them like I treated you.

What not to write “Let’s hop on a quick call and I’ll see how I can help.” That call becomes the job. “Unlimited revisions until you love it.” That is a hostage situation with extra steps.

Week-by-week

This is a 3–14 day path if you already know the job. Treat week one as a job, not a brand launch.

Day 1: package page Write the one-pager. Price, deposit, in/out, revision rule. Calendly, Stripe invoice or deposit link, one-page agreement. Test the link.

Days 2–4: ten asks Personal messages. One discounted first seat only if you truly need a case. Do not post a menu. Do not add a second package because the first ten were quiet.

Days 5–7: deliver the first job Deposit, form, draft internally, edit, midpoint sample, folder, 15-minute walkthrough, one revision window. They never see raw model output.

Week 2: SOP Write what you actually did. Time it. Cut anything that did not earn its minutes. Ask for the referral.

Week 3: full price, no discount Same package. Same days. Better SOP. If you want a second product, make it the playbook from the notes, not a second service that splits your calendar.

The quality bar

They should be able to use the files the day you hand them over, without you in the room after the walkthrough. That is the bar.

The raw-output test If you would be embarrassed to put your name under a paragraph, it does not ship. Models draft. You cut hype, check facts they gave you, and match their examples. A landing draft that could belong to any business is not done.

The date test 7 days means 7 days from deposit, not from the fifth follow-up email. If you cannot keep the date, the package is too big. Cut posts, not honesty.

The revision test One round. Written. If you need three rounds to make it good, your midpoint check is missing or you skipped the form. Do not buy peace with extra rounds. You will teach the next buyer that the wall is fake.

The folder test They own it. A login you control is not delivery. If the host dies, they still have the words.

What to count

Count jobs, not vibes.

Count these - Paid packages with written scope. First one is the milestone.
- Days from ask to deposit. If this is over two weeks, your page is vague or you are asking strangers. - Hours you actually spent versus the SOP. If job two is not faster, the SOP is a diary, not a process. - Revision use. If every job uses the round to change the offer, intake is broken. - Referrals asked vs referrals received. Asking once, on the happy day, is the whole system.

Ignore these for now A public “AI agency” identity.

Hour charts. A second service line. Testimonials you wrote for them. Count cash collected and dates kept.

A good first month is one or two \$600-class jobs delivered on time, not twelve half-sold conversations.

Objections you will hear

“Can we hop on a call first?” You can do a 15-minute Calendly after they have the one-pager, or you can send the cheaper file. A free hour is the job. Do not donate it.

“I need a custom thing.” Custom everything is on the leave-alone list. If their job is 80 percent your package, sell the package. If it is 20 percent, say no or quote a different dated package later — not this week.

“\$600 is a lot for something AI can do.” AI can draft. They are paying for 12 posts and a landing draft that match their offer, in 7 days, with your name on the quality. If they want the window, they already have it. Stay kind. Do not argue economics. Point at the date and the files.

“Can you just do hours?” No. Hours have no done. Offer the package or the file.

“Unlimited revisions until I’m happy.” One is enough. Happiness with no wall is a project without a date. Write the window. Mean it.

“I do not have examples or an offer yet.” Then they cannot implement. Send a cheaper diagnostic or playbook. Do not invent their business inside a \$600 week.

What this path feeds

This path is the cash pipe. The notes are the product pipe.

What it fills Every job becomes a playbook chapter, a template, or a letter issue. Sam’s 12-post week is a filled calendar someone else might buy as a \$19 file later. Referrals fill the next seats. People who cannot afford \$600 still need a door: send the cheaper file instead of shrinking the package.

What it needs A named package, a deposit link, a spine. It does not need a menu of 12 services. It does not need a team in month one. When

the SOP is real and you are full, raise the price inside \$300–\$1,500 or add a week of wait, before you hire a stranger to talk to your buyers.

Mistakes that eat the week

Work before money, and no walls Working before the deposit. Then you are a friend with a skill, and friends do not get a date on a calendar.

Unlimited revisions. Each round teaches them the first delivery was a suggestion.

Letting them “just hop on a call” that becomes the whole job. Calendly is for kickoff and walkthrough, 15 minutes, after money or after the one-pager. Not for free design-by-conversation.

Raw output and a menu of twelve Delivering unedited AI text. They can smell it. Your name is on it. The model does not refund them.

A menu of 12 services. Custom everything. Starting two packages because you were afraid the first one was too narrow. Narrow is how you keep the date.

Also: disappearing into Slack so the job never ends. Hosting files in a place they cannot export. Discounting seat two because seat one felt awkward. Skipping the referral ask. Skipping the SOP. Those turn a path into a string of tired one-offs.

Tools (keep them boring)

Calendly, Stripe invoice or deposit link, a one-page agreement. That is enough to take money and a date.

Calendly 15-minute kickoff or walkthrough. Not a 60-minute “discovery.” Put the package link in the invite. If they need longer, they need a different product.

Stripe invoice or deposit link Deposit before work.

Balance before or at delivery. Do not take payment in a chat app that will not help you when a charge is disputed.

One-page agreement Repeats the one-pager: in, out, date, price, deposit, revision window, where files live, what they must provide. You are not playing lawyer. You are writing the same sentences in a form they can screenshot.

AI Internal. Draft only. You edit. No shared chat with the client as the deliverable.

Leave retainers, agency CRMs, and a stack of proposal software on the shelf until you have delivered the same package three times.

Checklist

Tick this before you start job two.

Package page - One package, one line: deliverable, days, price
- Who it is for - What is in / what is not - What they must provide - One revision, with a clock - Deposit amount and what it holds - Definition of done (folder they own, walkthrough)

Rails - Calendly 15 minutes - Stripe invoice or deposit link, tested - One-page agreement - Kickoff form

First job - Ten asks to people who already trust you - One discounted first seat only if you need a case - Deposit before chat - AI internally; they never see raw output - Delivery on the date - Referral ask while they are happy - SOP written the same week - Next seat at full price

FAQ

Can I sell two packages if they are related? Not in week one. If you have two, you have none. Deliver the same one three times. Then, maybe, a smaller file for people who fail intake.

What if they want me to post for them too? That is a different dated package, or a no. Do not slide posting into the \$600 week for free. It has no done.

Do I need Calendly if we already chat? Yes, or something with a hard 15-minute wall. Chat has no wall.

How do I handle a bad fit after they pay? Refund the unused work, keep the deposit if you already started and the agreement says so, and stop. Do not work angry to “make it right” with extra scope.

Can I use their job as a case? Ask on the form. Default to fake names. Sam’s tutor said yes to a nameless description. That is enough.

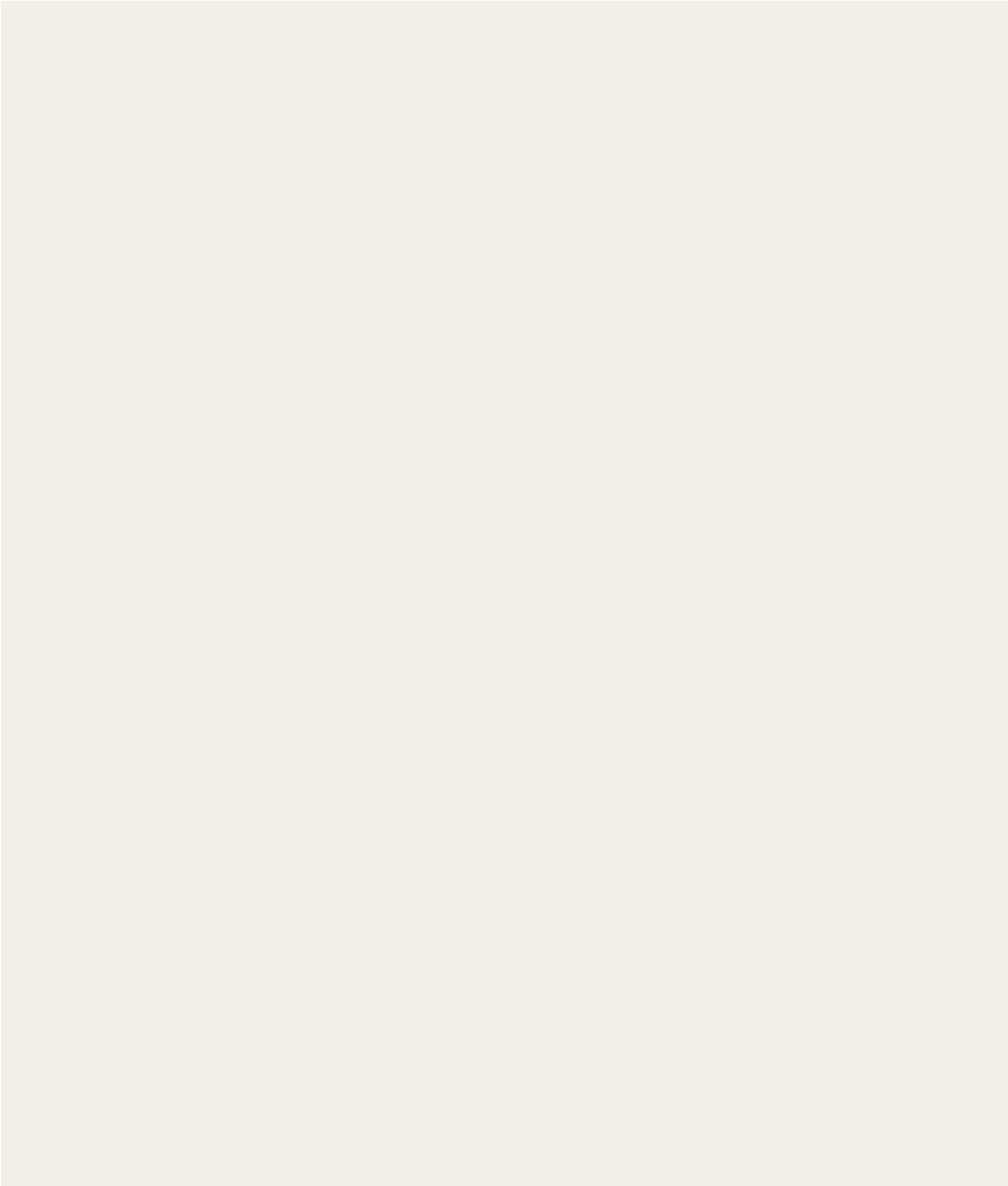
What if I miss the 7-day date? Tell them before the date. Cut scope with their written OK, or finish and own it. Silent delay is how you pay in reputation.

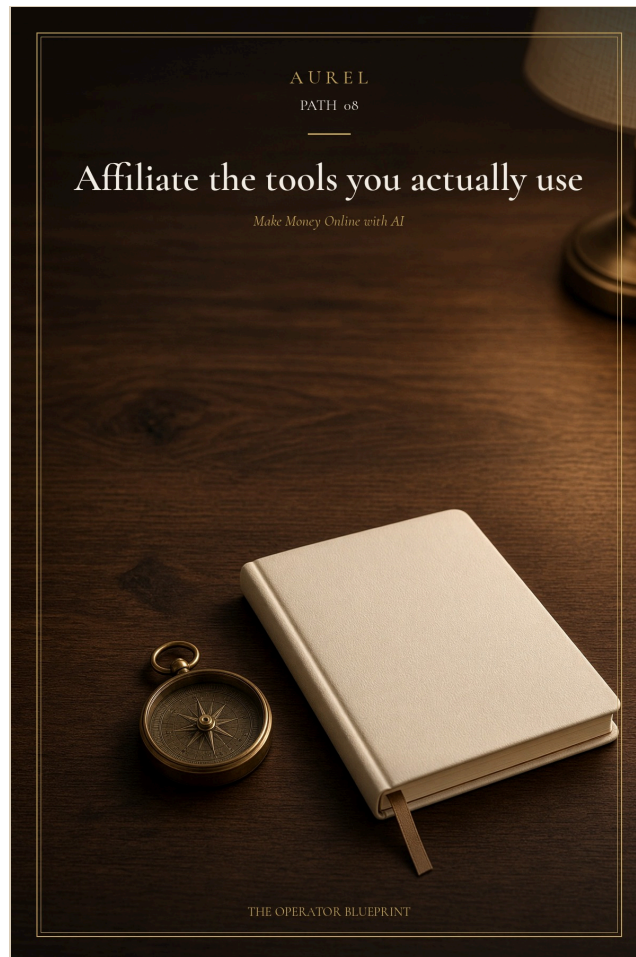
Is \$300 too low? It can be a first-seat price. As a habit it attracts people who want a friend. Move toward \$600–\$1,500 as soon as the SOP is real.

Should I hire someone to draft? Not until you have an SOP and you are full at full price. Hiring on job one is how quality becomes a rumor.

They want unlimited Slack access. No. Folder, form, one revision window, 15-minute walkthrough. Access without a date is hours with extra typing.

When do I turn this into a playbook? When you have notes from two jobs. The package still sells. The file is extra cash from people who will never hire you. Do not pause the package to write the book unless you are full.





PATH 08

Affiliate the tools you actually use

The review must stand if the link is removed. That is the whole ethic, and the whole conversion trick.

17 minute read · 3,644 words

Who this is for

You already recommend models, hosts, editors, or shops. You can write why, not just drop a URL.

Time to first

14–45 days (cookie + trust lag)

Tools

First sale

One commission from a review a real person used.

Cash window

Varies; treat as a sidecar, not the engine

Leave this alone

Official partner programs, a simple page or newsletter, honest disclosure.

Twenty links in a thread. Tools you have never opened.

How this pays without rotting your name

Affiliate is monetization, not a traffic plan. If nobody reads you, the link does nothing. Short-form and the weekly letter bring the people. This path takes a cut when they buy a tool you would keep using if the commission died.

The review must stand if the link is removed. That is the whole ethic, and the whole conversion trick. Write as if tomorrow a lawyer strips every URL. What remains should still help a tired person decide. If what remains is empty cheer, you wrote an ad. Ads from strangers do not convert, and they do not age well next to your name.

Why honest beats a glowing list Write what broke. What you still use. Who should skip it. That piece outsells a glowing list because tired people can smell a list. They have been burned by “best 50” pages that were updated never and used never. One page, one tool, your stack, a date on it — that is the product.

What this is not It is not a coupon blog. It is not twenty links in a thread. It is not a tool you opened once on a free weekend. It is a sidecar on work you already do: a letter, a playbook, a package. Treat commissions as extra, not as the engine. If the engine is affiliate, you will start recommending whatever pays this month, and your name will follow the payout.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already recommend models, hosts, editors, or shops, and you can write why, not just drop a URL. You need a real stack. You need a place to publish one page or one issue. You need the patience for cookie lag.

You are a fit if You pay for a tool with your own money. You have told a friend, in plain words, why you kept it. You are willing to put a disclosure at the top that you would want from that friend. You already have (or are building) a letter or a simple page where a review can live for a year.

Skip this path if You do not use anything you would recommend with the link ripped out. You want cash this week — cookies take 14–45 days, and some programs pay later than that. You like roundups of tools you have never opened. You will not update a page when the price changes. A dated lie is worse than no page.

If you have no readers yet, start the letter or the front door first. Affiliate does not create attention. It rides it.

The offer, named in one sentence

You are not selling the tool. You are publishing a review a real person can use, with a link underneath for the ones who decide to buy. The sentence: “I use [tool] for [job]. Here is who it is for, how long setup took, what I tried, what failed, and who should not buy. If you purchase through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way.”

One tool, one page Do not build a “best 50 AI tools” page. That is a farm. One honest page per tool you love. If you use two things (a model and a host), that is two pages, written months apart if you need the time, each with its own disclosure and its own date.

What the reader gets even if they never click A decision. Setup time. A failure they can avoid. A skip rule. If they finish the page and choose a competitor, you still did the job. That is how the next review gets believed.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done is one commission from a review a real person used. Not a screenshot of a dashboard full of pending cookies. A human told you they bought because the page named the thing that was stuck, or you saw a conversion you can tie to that URL.

The page bar - Disclosure at the top, in words you would want from a friend - Link below the reasoning, not above it - Who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy - Your own stack. Screenshot your own dashboard if the program allows it. No fake screenshots. - A date. Updated when pricing or the product changes.

The money bar Treat it as a sidecar until the list is real. One commission is done for VI. A farm of fifty unpaid roundups is not a business. It is a hole.

How the money actually shows up

You do not set the product price. The program does. Your job is to pick tools you already use, join official partner programs, and accept that cash is lumpy.

Cookie and trust lag Time to first is 14–45 days because people read, wait, compare, then buy, and the cookie has to still be alive. Some programs pay on a schedule after that. If you need rent on Friday, this is the wrong path for Friday. Run a package. Let this ride along.

What “varies” means A host or a model can pay a cut of a month, a year, or a one-time seat. Do not build a spending plan on a number you saw in someone else’s screenshot. Count commissions after they clear. Until then, it is a maybe.

What you never do for a higher cut You never hide the disclosure. You never pretend you still use a tool you cancelled. You never stuff every paragraph with links. You never invent a claim the program bans (“guaranteed income,” “official partner of the year” when you are not). The extra click is not worth the name.

The first 72 hours

You are not launching a media company. You are joining two programs and writing one review.

Hours 1–8: programs and rules Join two official partner programs for tools you already use. Not four. Not a directory of “high paying.” Two you can screenshot from your own login. Read the trademark rules and the disclosure rules. Note what you may not say. Note whether screenshots of the dashboard are allowed. If a program wants you to hide the relationship, skip it.

Hours 9–24: write the review Structure: who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy. Disclosure at the top. Link below the reasoning, not above it. Date it. Use a failure you actually had — a setup that took three hours, a feature that sounded magic and was not, a price change that annoyed you. Then say why you stayed.

Hours 25–72: publish and tell the people who already asked Put it on a simple page or in the newsletter. Same disclosure you would want from a friend. Share it once with people who asked you about that tool last month. Once. Not a week of reminders. Then wait. Cookies do not clear because you refreshed the dashboard.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. One tool until the page is good.

Step 1. Only tools in your actual stack If you would cancel it when the affiliate account dies, it does not belong on the page. Screenshot your own dashboard if allowed.

Step 2. Join official programs only No third-party link cloaks you do not understand. No “network” that will swap the vendor later. Read the rules.

Step 3. Pick one tool for review one A model you draft with, or a host you send with. Not both in one URL soup.

Step 4. Write the structure on paper before the pitch Who it is for. Setup time. What I tried. What failed. Who should not buy. If a section is empty, you do not know the tool yet. Use it another week.

Step 5. Disclose at the top Quiet honesty converts better than a hidden link. Use the line in the copy section. Do not bury it under a fold of adjectives.

Step 6. Put the link below the reasoning After the skip rule is a good place. Once, maybe twice. Not in every sentence.

Step 7. Date the page Month and year. A dated review is a trust machine. “Updated” without a date is a trick people know.

Step 8. Publish on a simple page or in the letter The letter is allowed to carry the review. The page is allowed to be ugly. Working beats a microsite.

Step 9. Share once where people already asked Last month’s DMs. The group you actually help. Not a spray of “best tool??” comments under strangers.

Step 10. Do not build a best-50 farm One honest page per tool you love. A second tool waits until the first page has been read by someone who is not you.

Step 11. Update when pricing or the product changes A weekend, twice a year, or when they move a button you described. Wrong prices rot faster than wrong adjectives.

Step 12. Treat commissions as a sidecar until the list is real Do not quit a package or pause the letter because a cookie might convert. Keep the engine. Let this ride.

Worked example: Riley's one honest review

Riley drafts client follow-ups in a paid model and sends a Tuesday letter from a paid host. People in the inbox kept asking which model. Riley did not drop a link in a reply. Riley wrote one page.

The disclosure, on top “I use this model for drafts. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way. I would keep paying for it if the program vanished tomorrow. Updated March.”

The review Who it is for: people who write the same kind of client note every week and are tired of restating the voice.
Not for people who need a model to invent a business.

Setup time: forty minutes to a project with instructions, three good examples, and a “never do this” list. Riley said the first evening was messy. That line mattered more than a feature table.

What they tried: recap emails, a landing draft, a joke post. The recap emails were the win. The joke post was embarrassing and got cut. What failed: asking it to “sound more human,” which made it sound like a brochure. The fix was pasting two real emails and saying “match these, do not improve my personality.”

Who should not buy: anyone who will paste the raw output to a client. Riley says that twice. The model drafts. The human sends.

The link sits after the skip rule. One link. No “top 10 models.” No fake dashboard. Riley's own project list, names blurred, because the program allows it.

What happened Riley shared the page once with six people who had asked last month, and once in the Tuesday letter, below a story about the joke post that failed. Two weeks later a commission cleared. A third person wrote to say they skipped the tool, which Riley counts as the page working. Month 2, the host changed a plan name. Riley updated the date and one paragraph. Still one tool. Still not a farm.

Copy you can paste

Keep the disclosure boring. Boring is trustworthy.

Disclosure at the top I use this. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way.

Longer disclosure (if the program wants more) I am a [program] partner. I pay for [tool] with my own money and use it for [job]. Affiliate links may earn me a commission. I do not get paid to hide problems. Last updated [month year].

Page title I use [tool] for [job] — who it is for, what failed, who should skip it.

Share to people who already asked You asked me about [tool] last month. I wrote the page I wanted to send you: setup time, what broke, who should not buy. Disclosure at the top. Link at the bottom if you still want it: [url].

Letter close (after a real story) I drafted this issue in [tool]. If you want the review, it is here. If you want next Tuesday, it still arrives with no click required.

What not to write “Best AI tool of the year!!!” Twenty links in a thread. “I made \$12,000 in a weekend.” Claims the program bans. A disclosure in gray eight-point under a hero button.

Week-by-week

This path is slow on purpose. Plan the wait so you do not sabotage it with a farm.

Week 1: two programs, one review Join two official programs you already use. Read the rules. Write one review with the structure above. Disclosure on top. Link below. Publish. Share once with people who asked.

Week 2: share it where people already asked If you have a letter, one issue can carry the story, then the link. If you do not, the page plus the personal notes is enough. Do not start review two.

Weeks 3–6: do the other paths Cookie and trust lag live here. Keep sending the letter. Keep the package. Check the partner dashboard once a week, not once an hour.

Month 2: update the review Price, product, or your use — if something changed, change the page and the date. If nothing changed, add one paragraph about a new job you actually ran through the tool. Treat commissions as a sidecar until the list is real.

Do not add nineteen more tools because week 4 was quiet. Quiet is normal.

The quality bar

The stripped-link test is the bar. Remove every URL. Read the page. If a careful person could still decide, you are done. If the page collapses into “it is great, click here,” write it again.

The friend test Would you forward this to a friend who asked in good faith, even if they used a different link? If you would be embarrassed, it is an ad.

The failure test If you cannot name something that broke, you have not used it long enough, or you are hiding. Setup time that was worse than the marketing page counts. A feature you turned off counts. “Nothing failed” is a glowing list in one sentence.

The skip test Name who should not buy. Riley’s “do not paste raw output to a client” is a skip rule and a quality rule. A review with no skip is a brochure.

The screenshot test Your dashboard, if allowed. Never a fake. Never someone else's crop with the URL bar missing in a suspicious way. If screenshots are banned, use words.

What to count

Count slow numbers. This path lies if you watch it daily.

Count these - Reviews published that would stand with the link removed. Target: one. - People who already asked, that you actually sent the page to. Six to ten is a real week 1. - Clicks, if the program shows them, without panicking at a quiet day. - Commissions that cleared, not pending. First cleared one is the milestone. - Updates per review per year. Zero updates and a price change on their site means your page is now wrong.

Ignore these for now Other people's disclosed income. Rankings of "best affiliate offers." How many tools you could join. A 50-tool content calendar. If you have clicks and no commissions after 45 days, read the review again. Often the link is above the reasoning (people bounce) or you recommended a plan nobody in your audience needs. Fix the page. Do not add a roundup.

Objections you will hear

"Affiliate is sleazy." Hidden affiliate is sleazy. A disclosure on top and a review that names failure is how people already recommend tools, with a cookie attached. If you are ashamed of the tool, do not join the program.

"I need traffic first." Yes. This is not a traffic plan. Build the letter or the door. Then the page has somewhere to live.

“Programs take too long to approve.” Some do. Use the wait to write the review without the link, then add the URL. Do not apply to twelve programs to soothe the wait.

“What if they buy and the cookie misses?” It happens. The review still did the job. Do not add five tracking scripts to squeeze a maybe. You will look like a farm.

“Can I round up five tools I kind of used?” No. That is the glowing list. One tool you love. Tired people can smell a list.

“The commission is small.” It is a sidecar. Small plus honest plus a list that already trusts you beats large plus a name you cannot reuse.

What this path feeds — and what it needs

Affiliate rides the other paths. It does not replace them.

What it fills A Tuesday issue can tell the story of what failed, then point to the review. A playbook can mention the model you used, with the same disclosure. A package can include “here is the tool I draft in; you do not have to buy it.” The cut is extra. The trust is the asset.

What it needs People. Official programs. One page. A stack you still pay for. It needs you to leave twenty-link threads alone. If the letter dies, this path dies with it. Keep the letter.

Mistakes that rot the name

Fake, cancelled, and stuffed Fake screenshots. They will be caught, and even if they are not, you will know. Recommending a tool

you cancelled. The page becomes a trap for people who trust you.

Stuffing every paragraph with links. That is how readers stop reading, and how some programs warn you.

Forgetting that some programs ban certain claims. Income promises, trademark misuse, “official” language you were not given. Read the rules in week 1, not after a warning.

The farm Twenty links in a thread. Tools you have never opened. A best-50 farm. Hiding the disclosure. Dating the page “updated” without a month. Those are the same mistake: you optimized for a click instead of a decision.

Also: building this before you have a place people already look. A perfect review in a forest is still a forest.

Tools (official, few, used)

Official partner programs, a simple page or newsletter, honest disclosure. That is the stack.

Official partner programs Join from the vendor’s own site. Two to start, both in your actual stack: a model, a host, an editor, a shop you already pay. Read trademark and disclosure rules before you write a headline.

A simple page or newsletter The letter you already send is enough. A single page with a date is enough. You do not need a review site template with 40 comparison tables.

Honest disclosure Plain sentences at the top. Not a legal poem. Not a tiny footnote. The same words you would want from a friend.

Leave link-in-bio mazes of twenty tools, unofficial coupon extensions, and any program that asks you to hide the relationship. If they are shy, you should be too — all the way out the door.

Checklist

Tick this before you add a second tool.

Before you publish - Tool is in your actual stack; you would keep paying without the program - Official partner account, rules read - Disclosure written at the top - Structure complete: who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy - Link below the reasoning - Screenshot is yours, or no screenshot if banned - Date on the page - No banned claims

First 72 hours - One review, not a roundup - Shared once with people who already asked - Letter issue optional, still one link

Ongoing - Update when price or product changes - Commissions counted when they clear - Sidecar, not the engine - Still no best-50 page

FAQ

Can I join a program for a tool I used once? No. Use it until you can fill the failure section without inventing. Once is a first date. A review is a relationship.

Do I have to say “affiliate” in the first line? Say you may earn a cut if they buy through the link, and that the review does not change. That is the honesty. Use the word “affiliate” if the program or the law you are under wants it. Quiet and early beats clever and late.

Newsletter or a page? Either. Riley did a page and mentioned it in the letter. If you only have the letter, the issue can be the review. Keep the disclosure at the top of that issue.

How many links on the page? One primary. A second if there is a cheaper plan you actually think they should consider. Not a forest.

What if the program rejects me? Write the review anyway without a link, or pick the second tool you already use. Rejection is not a prompt to join a shady network.

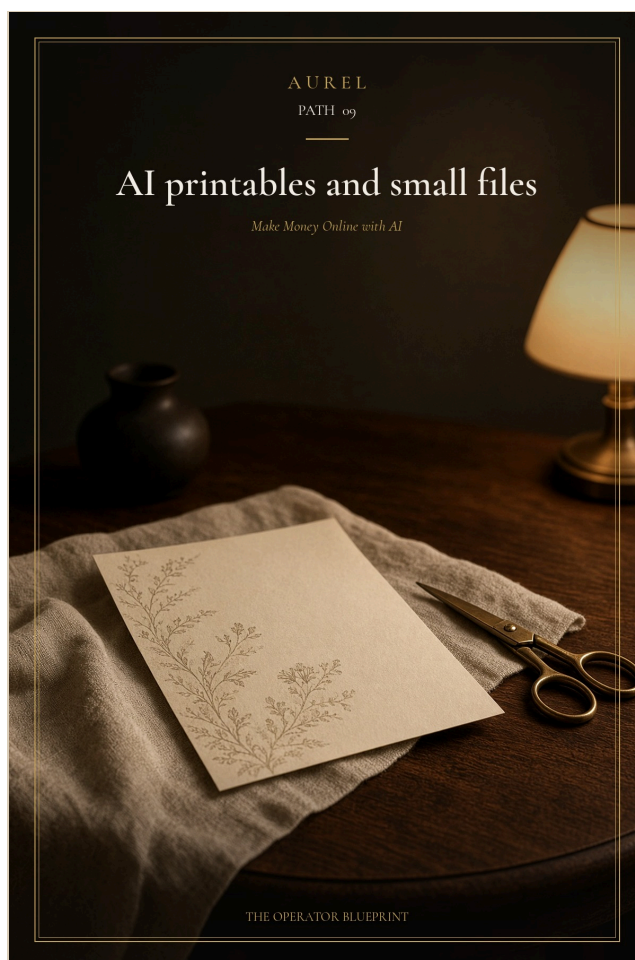
Can I use AI to write the review? You can outline. You still have to add the scar: setup time, what failed, who should skip it. A model will write a glowing list. That is the thing we are not doing.

When do I add a second review? After someone who is not you used the first one, and you have updated it once. Then one more tool from the stack. Still not fifty.

Is this enough to live on? Treat it as a sidecar. Some months will surprise you. Do not schedule rent on a surprise.

What if my audience asks for a tool I hate? Tell them you do not use it. No link. Your skip rule is allowed to be the whole email.

The vendor changed pricing and my page is wrong. Update this week. Change the date. A dated correction builds more trust than a perfect first draft you abandoned.



PATH 09

AI printables and small files

Solve a Tuesday problem. Mood boards are a hobby. Trackers are a product.

18 minute read · 4,068 words

Who this is for

You can design a clean one-page tool: tracker, checklist, wall print, planner page.

Time to first

2–10 days

Tools

First sale

Someone prints the \$9 file.

Cash window

\$7–\$12 single, \$19 bundle

Leave this alone

Canva, a mockup, Stan or Etsy, AI for copy not for stolen art.

Generic aesthetic planners with no job.

What you are selling

A printable is a page someone will actually print, fill, and pin to a wall or drop in a binder. That is the whole product. Not a vibe. Not a mood board. A tool for a Tuesday problem: what to post this week, what to pack, what to check before a client walks in.

Search language is the product title. ‘Weekly content tracker for solo hairstylists’ beats ‘Cute planner 2026’ because the first one names a person and a job. The second one is wallpaper. People searching Etsy or Google at 10pm are not shopping for cute. They are shopping for a page that stops the guessing.

AI can draft the copy on the page: the labels, the tiny how-to in the footer, the listing description. You still design the layout so it prints without eating the margins. The model does not know your printer. You do, after one test page.

Your own site keeps the customer. Etsy rents the aisle. Use the aisle if you have no traffic. Move them to email when you can. The file is cheap. The list is the real asset.

What this is not

This is not a 40-page undated planner with empty circles and a quote about blooming. Those exist by the thousand. They photograph well and convert poorly unless you already have a following that buys your taste.

This is also not a wall print of someone else’s illustration or a trademarked character. Your layout, your words, your simple shapes. If you cannot draw, use type, lines, and a two-color palette. Clean beats illustrated when the buyer is a working stylist, not a Pinterest board.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can sit in Canva for two hours and ship a one-page tool that a stranger can fill without a video. You do not need to be a designer. You need margins, a hierarchy (title, then fields, then a one-line instruction), and the patience to print a test copy on the cheapest paper in the house.

It also fits if you already live near a Tuesday problem. You cut hair. You run a classroom. You pack a kit for a trade. You have watched someone (including you) invent the same list every Sunday night. That list, cleaned up, is the product.

Skip this if

Skip this path if you only want to make pretty pages with no job on them. Generic aesthetic planners with no job are the thing to leave alone. The aisle is full.

Skip it if you cannot print a test. Selling a PDF you have never held is how you ship clipped margins and a furious one-star. Borrow a printer. Use the library. Do not guess.

Skip it if you need \$2,000 this week. A \$9 file can add up. It does not replace a service invoice. Pair this with a paid week of work if rent is the problem.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you open Canva: 'A one-page [job] for [person], printed at home, filled in ten minutes, \$9.' If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have a product. You have a hobby file.

The offer has four parts and none of them are a color palette.

Person: solo hairstylist, not 'creatives.'

Job: weekly content tracker, not 'planner.'

Format: one US Letter PDF, print-ready, with a filled example on page two.

Price: \$9 for the single, \$19 for three related pages.

A sentence you can put on the listing

‘Weekly content tracker for solo hairstylists — one page, print at home, fill it Sunday night, walk into Monday with the posts already chosen. \$9. Bundle with monthly themes and caption starters for \$19.’

That sentence is the product. If the page cannot keep that promise, redesign the page. Do not rewrite the sentence to hide a weak file.

What done looks like

Done is not a Canva link in your drafts. Done is a stranger who can buy, download, print, and fill the page without emailing you.

The done bar

The PDF is US Letter (or A4 if that is your market), 300 dpi, fonts outlined or embedded.

0.25 inch bleed if you ever send it to a print shop. 0.5 inch safe margin so home printers do not eat the last checkbox.

Page one is the blank tool. Page two is the same tool filled with a real example. People buy the filled page. They use the blank one.

A table mockup photo, not a floating PNG on fake marble if you can help it. Phone photo of the printed page next to a mug is enough.

Listing title uses the job and the person. Tags match how they search, not how you brand.

Checkout works. You bought it from a second email. The file arrived. It opened. It printed.

License line on the file and the listing: personal use, or small-business use if you mean that. No reselling the PDF.

If any of those is missing, it is not done. A pretty layout with a clipped margin is a refund.

Pricing that matches a printed page

Cash window: \$7–\$12 for a single page, \$19 for a bundle of three related pages. Stay in that lane until you have reviews and a second niche.

\$9 is the default single. Low enough that a tired stylist does not need a committee. High enough that you are not training people to treat you like a free Canva account. \$7 if the page is truly one checkbox list. \$12 if it includes the filled example plus a short how-to on the same PDF.

The \$19 bundle is the real offer. Three pages that belong together: weekly tracker, monthly theme map, caption-starter sheet. Do not bundle three unrelated aesthetics. Bundle one job, three angles.

What not to do with price

Do not list at \$3 to ‘get reviews.’ You will get the buyers who want \$3 things, and they will review you like a \$3 thing. Do not list a one-page tracker at \$27. That price wants a workshop or a video. You have a page.

Do not run a 70% off launch. A clean \$9 and a clean \$19, stated once, will outsell a fake \$40 slashed to \$9. If you need a reason to email later, add a fourth page to the bundle in month two and raise the bundle to \$24. Grandfather the people who already paid.

On Etsy, fees take a bite. Price so you still clear about \$6 on the single after fees, or skip ads until organic search works. On your own site with Stripe, \$9 is almost all yours. That is why the aisle is temporary.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a shop with 400 listings. You need three related pages, one listing, one bundle, one post.

Hours 1–8

Pick the Tuesday problem and the person. Write the title in search language. Open Canva at US Letter, turn on rulers, set 0.5 inch margins. Build page one as the tool. Labels a tired person can read from two feet away. No 8-point script font.

Ask the model for the on-page labels and an 80-word how-to footer. Rewrite until it sounds like you. Fill page two with a real week. Export PDF.

Hours 9–24

Print it. If it clips, it is not done. Fix margins. Print again. Photograph the filled page on a table. That is the listing image.

Build two sibling pages in the same type and color. Same person, same job family. Export. Make a \$19 zip: three PDFs plus a one-line readme ('Print at 100%, actual size, do not fit to page').

Hours 25–72

List the \$9 single. List the \$19 bundle. Title with the job and the person. Publish. One post showing the filled page, not the empty one. Send the link to ten people who do that job. Do not invent 400 listings. Do not design a logo.

The path, step by step

Step 1. Tuesday problem, one page. Write the person and the job on a sticky note. If it takes two notes, it is two products. Solo hairstylist, weekly content. Not 'all beauty professionals, all planning needs.'

Step 2. Steal the search language, not the art. Type the job into Etsy and Google. Copy the words buyers already use: weekly, tracker, salon, hairstylist, content calendar. Your title is a sentence made of those words. Do not copy another seller's layout.

Step 3. Paper first. Sketch the fields. Date. Posts 1–5. Photo needed? Caption started? Posted? Notes. If you cannot sketch it on a napkin, Canva will not save you.

Step 4. Build for print, not for a screenshot. US Letter or A4. 0.5 inch safe margin. High contrast. One accent color. Checkboxes large enough for a pen. Footer: 'Print at 100%. Personal use.'

Step 5. AI drafts the words. You own the voice. Labels, subtitle, listing bullets. Then read them out loud. If you would not say it to a stylist in a break room, cut it.

Step 6. Fill the example. Write five posts a real solo stylist would actually make this week: before-and-after, a product they use, a booking reminder, a day-in-the-chair, a closed-Sunday note.

Step 7. Print test. Home printer, cheapest paper, actual size. If a checkbox is in the unprintable zone, move it. If gray type vanishes, go black. Repeat until a printed page looks like the screen.

Step 8. License: your layout, your words. Do not sell other people's illustrations. Do not use trademarked characters. Type and lines are enough.

Step 9. Two sibling pages, then stop. Monthly theme map. Caption starters. Same fonts, same margins. That is the \$19 bundle. Do not invent 400 listings in a week.

Step 10. Mockup on a table, not a floating PNG if you can help it. Print the filled page. Photograph it. One extra image: the three pages fanned for the bundle.

Step 11. List and tell ten people. \$9 single, \$19 bundle. Stan, your site, or Etsy if you have no traffic. Title with the job and the person. One post, filled page, price, link.

Step 12. A how-to page on your site that ranks for the job, then sells the file. 'How solo hairstylists plan a week of posts without sitting on their phone for two hours.' Teach the method. Put the \$9 file at the bottom. This page is yours even if Etsy changes the rules.

Worked example: Harper and the hairstylist tracker

Harper cut hair for nine years. Every Sunday she watched other solo stylists in a group chat ask the same thing: what do I post this week. She already had a notebook page she used for herself. That notebook page is the product. She did not need a new personality. She needed margins.

What she shipped

Page 1: Weekly content tracker for solo hairstylists. Seven rows (Sunday plan plus six posting days, because she takes Monday off and wanted that to be allowed). Columns: date, post type (reel, photo, story, nothing), the idea in one line, photo already shot, caption started, posted. Footer: 'Fill this Sunday. Shoot Tuesday. Post from the list. Do not invent at 9pm.'

Page 2: the same grid filled for a real week in her old chair: a color-correction before-and-after, a 'three questions before a bang trim' reel, a product she actually used, a last-minute Thursday opening, a closed-Sunday photo of the empty chair.

Bundle extras: a monthly theme map (education, proof, offer, personality) and 20 caption starters in the voice of a solo stylist. AI wrote a first pass. She rewrote 14 of the 20 because they sounded like a corporate salon.

She listed the tracker at \$9. Bundle at \$19. Canva, kitchen table mockup, Etsy for the aisle, a Stan link on a one-page site.

What happened

Day 1–2: layout and print tests. The first export ate the last column. She moved it. Day 3: listings live. Day 4: she posted the filled page in two stylist groups she already belonged to. Day 6: first stranger sale, \$9. Day 11: a bundle. End of week 3: 14 singles and 6 bundles. About \$240 before fees. Not rent. Proof.

She did not make 400 listings. In week 3 she wrote a how-to: ‘A Sunday-night content hour for one-chair salons.’ That post still sends two or three sales a week. The title did the work.

Copy you can paste

Listing title

Weekly content tracker for solo hairstylists — printable one-page planner (Sunday fill-in)

Listing first line

Print it. Fill it Sunday. Walk into Monday with the week’s posts already chosen. \$9.

Listing bullets

- One US Letter PDF, print at home at 100%

- Built for one-chair stylists, not agencies

- Columns for idea, photo, caption, posted

- Includes a filled example so you are not staring at empty boxes

- Personal use. Print as many copies as you need for your own chair

Bundle title

Hairstylist content kit: weekly tracker + monthly themes + 20 caption starters — \$19

Post (filled page, not a mood)

I got tired of inventing Instagram in the chair between clients. This is the one-pager I fill on Sunday. \$9. Bundle with themes and captions is \$19. Link in bio. If you do not need it, ignore this.

DM to ten people who do the job

I made a one-page weekly content tracker for solo stylists. Instant PDF, \$9. I use the filled example on page two. If that would save you a Sunday: [link]. If not, no need to reply.

Etsy tags (pick 13)

hairstylist planner, salon content calendar, weekly content tracker, instagram planner printable, hair stylist marketing, reel planner, one page tracker, sunday planning, small salon, booth renter, content checklist, social media for hair, printable tracker

Week-by-week

Week 1: three pages live. Day 1–2, the tracker and the print test. Day 3, two sibling pages. Day 4, listings and mockup. Day 5–7, ten DMs and one public post of the filled page. Do not start a second niche.

Week 2: the \$19 bundle if you listed only the single in week 1. Same files, one zip, one new listing. Answer every question in under a day. If someone cannot print it, the problem is your export until proven otherwise.

Week 3: one how-to post aimed at the Tuesday problem. Teach the Sunday hour. Ten sentences and a photo of the filled page. Link once.

Week 4: seasonal only if the niche is seasonal. A stylist tracker is not seasonal. A holiday salon hours sign is. Add one seasonal sibling if it belongs. Do not invent 400 listings. Update the

original if a buyer tripped on a label.

After week 4, pick a second person with the same shape: weekly tracker for solo house cleaners, or for one-person bakeries. Same grid, new language. That is a catalog. That is not a new business.

The quality bar

Print is unforgiving. A screen hides a 9-point font and a 0.1 inch margin. A cheap inkjet does not.

Specs that keep you out of one-star land

300 dpi PDF. Not a compressed PNG pretending to be a PDF.

Black (or near-black) for all fill-in lines. Light gray disappears on paper.

Checkboxes at least 0.25 inch. Pens are thicker than cursors.

No text in the outer 0.5 inch. Home printers crop. 'Fit to page' shrinks your grid and people blame you.

Fonts you can embed. Script fonts for labels are a hobby. The job is readable at arm's length.

For home print, full-bleed color blocks will come back with a white frame. Design for that frame or warn them.

The filled page is the quality

An empty grid is homework. A filled grid is a demonstration. If you are embarrassed to fill it with a real week, the tool is too complicated or you do not know the job. Simplify until a real week fits.

License quality: your layout, your words. Keep a folder of font licenses. If you cannot point to the license in 30 seconds, do not sell the file.

What to measure

Vanity is listing views. Money is conversion and refunds.

Sales: singles vs bundles. If you sell 10 singles and 0 bundles, the bundle is unclear, not unwanted. Fix the title and the table photo of all three pages.

Conversion: shop views to orders. On Etsy, under 1% means the thumbnail or the title is wrong. On your own site, count checkout starts.

Time to first sale after publish. Under 10 days is normal if you actually told ten people. At day 14 with zero sales and zero messages, the job in the title is mush.

Print complaints. One 'it clipped' is a revision. Three is a pattern. Fix the file and email the new PDF.

Email captures. If the Etsy sale never becomes an email, you rented the customer. Add a one-line 'want the next page? tap here' in the PDF footer.

Ignore follower counts and anyone telling you to post three Reels a day before you have a file that prints. The file is the unit. Measure the file.

Objections you will hear

'Etsy is saturated.' Saturated with cute undated planners. Not saturated with 'weekly content tracker for solo hairstylists.' If the first title is generic, that is your saturation, not the market.

'People will just screenshot it.' Some will. Price \$9, not \$90, and stop policing the ocean. The buyer who will pay is buying convenience and a clean grid.

'I am not a designer.' Good. Designers over-decorate trackers. You need margins, type, and a filled example. Canva plus a print test is the skill.

'Should I make it a Google Sheet instead?' That is a different path. A printable is for people who want paper next to the chair. If your buyer lives in a phone, sell a sheet. Do not merge them into one confusing zip on day one.

'Can I use AI images on the cover?' A phone photo of a real printed page still converts better. Use the model for labels and listing copy. Not for stolen art, and not for a fake marble flat-lay.

'I need 400 listings to rank.' You need one file that matches a search, then a handful of siblings. Shops with huge catalogs still win on the specific titles, not the pile.

What this path feeds next

Printables are a front door, not a dead end.

The how-to page that sells the \$9 file is a long-form asset. The same Sunday-hour lesson becomes a short video with the filled page on camera. People who buy the tracker are a list. The list can hear about a \$19 playbook, a \$47 template, or a \$9 membership that adds a new page each month.

If you are near real shops, the tracker is a sample in your bag. A salon owner who likes the page is a lead for a productized week: posts plus a landing draft. Do not pitch that on day one. Deliver the file. Then ask.

Notes from buyers — ‘I needed a column for who is covering the chair’ — become version 1.1 and also become chapters in a longer guide. The cheap file teaches you the language. Keep the catalog small enough that you can still name every file in one breath.

Mistakes that kill this path

Low-resolution files. A pretty Canva design exported as a fuzzy PNG, renamed .pdf. It will look fine on a phone and shameful on paper.

Selling trademarked characters. Famous cartoons, lyrics, league logos, a salon’s wordmark. You will sell a few and then lose the shop. Your layout, your words.

Empty pages. A grid with no filled example is homework. Mood boards are a hobby. Trackers are a product.

Ignoring print bleed and margins. If it clips, it is not done. ‘Fit to page’ is not a design strategy.

Inventing 400 listings in a week. Three related pages. Then a how-to. Then a second person.

Competing only on aesthetic. Pale beige with a bow vs pale beige with a different bow. The title with the job wins.

Hiding the price. Putting ‘DM for info’ on a \$9 PDF. State \$9. State \$19. Let them buy while the tea is still hot.

Tools

Canva. US Letter or A4 custom size. Download as PDF Print, 300 dpi. You do not need Illustrator for a tracker.

A mockup. A real table and a phone beat a \$12 mockup pack on day one. If you buy a pack later, pick one that looks like a kitchen, not a showroom.

Stan or Etsy. Etsy if you have no traffic and the search terms are obvious. Stan or a Stripe payment link on your own page if you can send ten people. Use the aisle. Keep the customer.

AI for copy, not for stolen art. Labels, listing, caption starters. Then rewrite. Do not generate ‘in the style of’ a living illustrator.

A home printer or a library printer. Non-negotiable. Plus cheap paper, a black pen, and a phone for the filled-page photo.

A simple folder. v1, v1.1, licenses, listing copy. Name files like a person searching: Weekly-Content-Tracker-Solo-Hairstylist.pdf — not FinalFinal3.pdf.

Checklist

Person and Tuesday problem written in one line

Title in search language, not a cute brand name

One-page tool in Canva with 0.5 inch safe margin

Filled example on page two with a real week

Print test at 100%, actual size, no clipping

Two sibling pages for the \$19 bundle

License: your layout, your words, no trademarked characters

Table photo of the printed, filled page

\$9 single listed, \$19 bundle listed, price visible

Test-buy from a second email, file opens, file prints

Ten messages to people who do the job

One public post of the filled page, not the empty grid

Footer with personal-use line and an email you will answer

How-to page started, even as a draft, aimed at the same job

FAQ

Do I start on Etsy or on my own site?

If nobody knows you, Etsy is the aisle. List the \$9 and the \$19, and put the same files on a Stan or Stripe page. After the first twenty sales, invite them off Etsy with a 'next page is on my list' line inside the PDF.

US Letter or A4?

Sell the size your person prints. US-heavy jobs: Letter first, A4 as a second file in the same listing if you can keep the grid honest. Do not stretch Letter to A4. Rebuild the margin.

Can I sell a fillable PDF they type in?

Yes, as a later version. V1 is print. Fillable fields break on half the phones people open Etsy on. If you add fillable, keep a print version in the zip.

How many listings before I quit?

One job, three pages, two listings (single and bundle), ten asks, one how-to post. Give that 21 days. If nothing moved, the job in the title is wrong or you never showed the filled page.

What about commercial licenses for other sellers?

Not on day one. Personal use or 'print for your own chair' is enough. A commercial license is a different product at a different price. Skip it until someone asks twice.

Is a wall print a printable in this path?

Yes if it does a job: a salon opening-hours sign, a ‘what to do before color’ checklist a client can photograph. No if it is a quote in script. Job first.

Should I watermark the preview?

Watermark the listing mockup, not the paid file. A giant diagonal name across the product PDF is how you get refunds. Show the filled page in photos.

What do I do when a buyer wants a custom version?

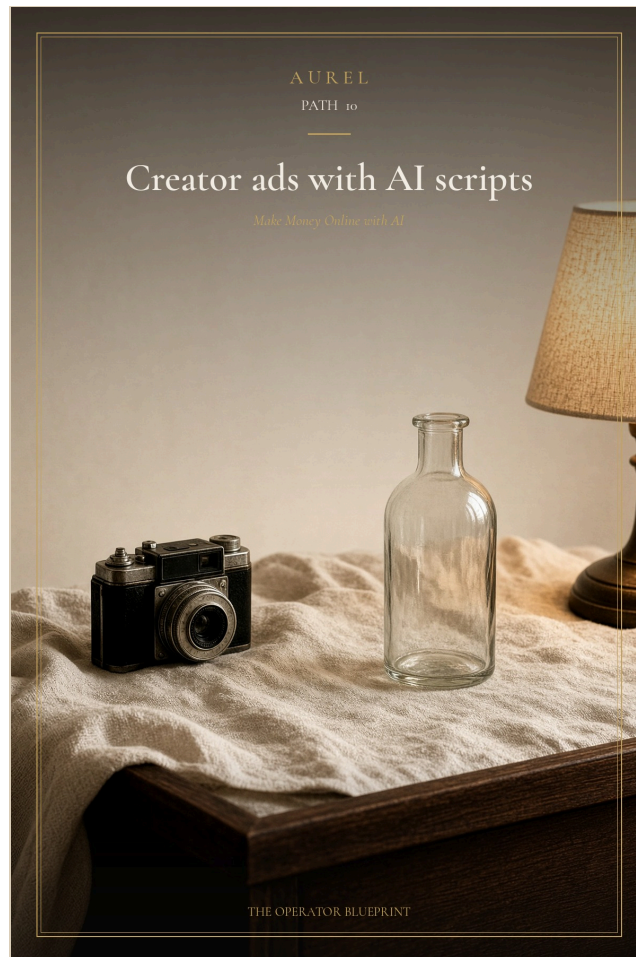
One custom at a clear fee (\$40–\$80 for a one-page tweak) or a polite no. If three people ask for the same extra column, that is v1.1 for everyone.

Can I use Canva Pro photos in a file I sell?

Read the current Canva license for printables you resell. When unsure, use your photo of the printed page for marketing and keep the product itself type-and-line.

How do I handle refunds?

Refund the \$9 without a speech if the file failed them. Ask for a print photo if they said it clipped — you need that to fix v1.1. Then fix the file for everyone. Arguing over \$9 costs more than \$9.



PATH 10

Creator ads with AI scripts

Brands need simple product videos. You do not need to be famous. You need to be clear.

19 minute read · 4,173 words

Who this is for

You are comfortable on camera. You can hold a product and talk.

Time to first

7–21 days

Tools

First sale

One paid brief for two videos.

Cash window

\$150–\$800 for a first two-video pack

Leave this alone

Phone, CapCut, a rate card, AI for script outlines only. Working for exposure. Promising virality.

What you are selling

UGC-style ads are not influencer fame. They are short product videos a brand can run as ads or organic posts. Demo, list, stitch, talking-head. Fifteen to thirty seconds. Vertical. You on camera, product in hand, a sentence a person would actually say in a store aisle.

The buyer is a small brand that cannot hire a studio and does not want another polished TV spot. They want a video that looks like a customer. You are that customer, on purpose, with a script you can say without blinking at a teleprompter.

AI drafts the script outline. You throw away anything you would not say out loud to a friend while chopping onions. If the model writes ‘this revolutionary garlic press will transform your weeknight ritual,’ that line dies. ‘I used to smash garlic with a knife and a prayer. This thing takes four seconds’ stays.

You do not need to be famous. You need to be clear. A sample ad for a product already on your shelf is your portfolio. Two samples beat a nine-page media kit with follower screenshots. Brands who pay \$400 for two videos are not buying your audience. They are buying files they can load into Ads Manager this week.

What this is not

This is not a promise that the ad will go viral. You cannot promise that. Anyone who asks you to guarantee ROAS on day one is asking you to lie or to become their media buyer. You are the creator of the asset. Media buying is a second package, later, if you even want it.

This is not working for exposure, free product, or ‘we will tag you.’ Free product is not a brief. A paid pack is a brief. If you want the product, buy it and film a sample. Then send the invoice path, not the barter path.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you are comfortable on camera. Not ‘love being an influencer.’ Comfortable. You can hold a product, talk for twenty seconds, and not apologize to the lens. A kitchen, a window, a phone is enough. You do not need a ring light army.

It also fits if you already buy in a niche: kitchen tools, skincare you actually use, hardware in the garage, a software login you open every morning. The niche is the drawer you already have. Samples from that drawer are honest. Samples from a niche you are faking will sound like a press release.

Skip this if

Skip it if you hate being on camera and were hoping the model would generate a face. Faceless slideshow ads exist. They are a different product. This path is you, a product, a sentence.

Skip it if you want to wait for a marketplace to send you brands. Those platforms take a cut and train you to bid against people who work for \$50. You will email five brands you already use.

Skip it if you will promise virality to close the deal. Sell the files, the deadline, and one revision. Not a lottery ticket.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this on the rate card before you film: ‘Two product videos, one revision, seven days, \$400. Vertical files you can run. Samples on this page.’

That is the whole offer. Not a menu of 12 packages. Not a 20-video retainer. Two videos. One pack. A date.

The four parts

Deliverable: two 15–30 second vertical videos (9:16), captions burned in, raw clips optional if you want to upsell later.

Process: they send the product facts and claims they can actually make. You script, shoot, edit. They get one round of notes. You deliver files, not a login to your brain.

Timeline: seven days from product-in-hand (or from the day they ship it to you) to files in a folder.

Price: \$400 for the first two-video pack in kitchen tools. The cash window for a first pack anywhere in this path is \$150–\$800. Start where you can say the number without flinching, then raise.

If you cannot name the niche in the sentence — ‘two kitchen-tool product videos’ — you do not have an offer yet. ‘I make UGC’ is a category. Categories do not get replies.

What done looks like

Done is a paid brief, not a sample sitting in your camera roll. The first sale is one brand saying yes and paying a deposit for two videos.

The done bar for a pack

Two finished vertical files, 15–30 seconds, captions a muted viewer can follow.

A 3-second hook that names the job (‘I stopped mincing garlic with a knife’).

No medical claims, no fake urgency you know is false, no ‘doctors hate this’ garbage the brand cannot defend.

One revision round, written, with a 48-hour window. After that, new work is a new invoice.

Files named like an adult: Brand-Product-A-hook1.mp4, Brand-Product-B-demo.mp4.

Delivered in a folder they own.

Deposit taken before you shoot. Balance on delivery. You are not a bank.

Done for the business, week one, is smaller: two sample ads live on a page with the \$400 pack spelled out, five emails sent. If those five are not sent, you do not have a business. You have homework.

Pricing the two-video pack

Cash window: \$150–\$800 for a first two-video pack. Alex's kitchen-tool pack sits at \$400. That number is high enough to filter hobby brands who want free content, and low enough that a six-person company can expense it without a board meeting.

How to pick your number

\$150–\$250 if you have zero samples and need a first paid case. Say it is a founder rate for the first two brands, then it becomes \$400. Write the date you will stop discounting.

\$400 is the default once two samples exist. Two videos, one revision, seven days. Rush in 72 hours: add \$150. Extra revision: \$75. Extra video in the same shoot: \$150. Write those three additions on the rate card so they do not become a conversation.

\$600–\$800 when you have three paid brands in the same niche and a folder of ads that ran. Do not jump there on day one. You have no proof yet.

What you never do

You never work for exposure. You never take 'we will send you the product and a coupon code' as payment. You never promise a CPM, a ROAS, or a view count. You sell files. If they want you to run the ads too, that is a second package with a second price, and you should not sell it until you have delivered the files once.

Deposit 50% to hold the week. Balance on delivery, before the revision window starts if you want leverage, or after the one revision if you want to be easier to hire. Pick one. Put it on the page.

The first 72 hours

Film two sample ads. Edit. Put them on a simple page with a package: two videos, one revision, a deadline, a price. Send the page to five small brands you already use. Do not wait to be discovered on a marketplace.

Hours 1–8

Pick the niche from your own shelf. Kitchen tools if that is your drawer. Take two products you already own. Write three hook options each. Speak them into a voice memo. Keep the ones you would say in a store. Throw out the ones that sound like a banner ad.

Hours 9–24

Shoot by a window. Phone vertical. Product in frame in the first two seconds. One take that is good enough. Then a second angle: demo the tool actually working. Edit in CapCut: captions, a light crop, 20 seconds, no trending audio you do not have the rights to. Export.

Hours 25–72

A one-page site or a Notion page: two embedded samples, the rate card line, a deposit link, an email. Send five notes to brands you already buy from. ‘I made two kitchen-tool videos as samples. I can do two for [product] in seven days for \$400, one revision. Page: [link].’ That is the 72 hours. No media kit. No waiting.

The path, step by step

Step 1. Rate card before more gear. Starter pack: two videos, one revision, seven days, \$400. Rush fee. Extra revision. Extra video. Put it on one page. If you cannot say the number out loud, the number is wrong or you are not ready to send email.

Step 2. Niche you already buy in. Kitchen tools, software, skincare, hardware. One. Stay there until you have repeat clients. A sample from your own shelf is honest. A sample from a niche you Googled this morning will sound like it.

Step 3. Two sample ads, not a PDF about your ‘media kit.’ Film a demo and a talking-head for products you own. Brands hire from video. They do not hire from a bio.

Step 4. Brief intake. A form, not a 40-minute ‘discovery call’ that becomes free consulting. Product facts. Three claims they can legally make. Claims you will not make. Two example ads they like (not ‘make it viral’). Ship-to address if they are sending the product. Deadline.

Step 5. Script in your mouth. AI outline: hook, problem, demo, proof, ask. Then rewrite until you can say it while walking across the kitchen. Record a voice memo. If you stumble, the line is too long.

Step 6. Shoot. Window light. Phone at eye height. Product in the first two seconds. Do the job on camera — press the garlic, peel the orange, click the software. Talking about the product without showing it is a lecture.

Step 7. Edit. CapCut is enough. Captions. Cut the breath you took before the sentence. End on the product name and the one action ('link in bio' is their problem; your file can end on the product). Keep a 15-second and a 25-second cut if it is easy.

Step 8. Deliver vertical files they can run. 9:16, under 100 MB if you can help it, no watermark, no your-logo end card unless they paid for a brand frame. You are not their media buyer unless that is a second package.

Step 9. One revision window. Written notes, 48 hours, one round. 'Make it pop' is not a note. 'Swap the first line for the one about the dishwasher' is a note. After the window, new invoice.

Step 10. Ask for the next SKU and one referral. While they are happy. 'If the juicer has a sibling product, I can shoot it in the same setup for \$150 extra next week.' Then: 'Who else in kitchen tools should see the samples?'

Step 11. Stay in one niche. The second brand is easier when you can say 'I already shot a press, a peeler, and a juicer.' Crossing into dental ads because someone asked is how you restart from zero.

Step 12. Raise or productize. After three paid packs, \$500. After a folder of work, a monthly 'four videos, first Friday' retainer. Not before you have delivered once without drama.

Worked example: Alex and the \$400 kitchen-tool pack

Alex cooks most nights in a small apartment kitchen. No studio. A window over the sink. A drawer of tools bought over a few years. That drawer is the niche. Alex did not pick kitchen tools because of a trend report. Alex picked them because the garlic press was already there.

The two samples

Sample 1, garlic press: 18 seconds. Hook: ‘I used to mince garlic with a knife and it made the whole board smell for days.’ Demo: clove in, squeeze, peel the leftover skin, rinse. Last line: ‘Four seconds, and the board stays clean.’ No music fight. Captions on.

Sample 2, silicone spatula: 22 seconds. Hook: ‘If your spatula melts on the pan, that is not a personality, that is a bad tool.’ Demo: scramble, scrape, hold it against the edge. Last line: ‘This one does not smell like burnt rubber. I checked.’

Both shot in one evening. Edited the next morning in CapCut. On a one-page site with this line: ‘Two product videos, one revision, seven days. \$400. Samples on this page.’ Deposit link under the sentence.

The five emails

Alex listed five small kitchen brands already in the cupboard — not Amazon house brands, not All-Clad. A citrus juicer company with 12,000 Instagram followers. A board-scraper shop. A mill seller. Two spatula companies. The email was six lines, the page link, and a still from the garlic-press ad. No media kit.

Day 9: the juicer brand replied. They had a new hand juicer. They wanted two ads: one demo, one ‘why I switched from a cheap press.’ They asked if Alex could ‘also run the ads and get us views.’ Alex said no to the media buying, yes to the \$400 pack, 50% deposit. Product arrived on day 12.

The paid brief

Script outline from the model. Alex cut three fake-urgency lines and one claim about ‘clinically proven juice yield’ the brand could not stand behind. Shot on Saturday. Delivered Monday. One revision: they wanted the sink less messy in the background. Alex reshot the last six seconds. Balance paid. Total elapsed from first email to files: 16 days. Time to first paid brief: inside the 7–21 day window.

Alex did not become famous. Two more kitchen brands hired in the next six weeks because the juicer owner forwarded the page. Same pack. Same \$400. Same niche.

Copy you can paste

Rate card line

Two product videos, one revision, seven days. \$400. Samples on this page.

Add-ons, same card

72-hour rush: +\$150

Extra revision round: +\$75

Extra video in the same shoot: +\$150

Raw clips folder: +\$50

Email to a brand you already buy from

Hi [name] — I already use [product]. I make short product videos brands can run as ads. Two samples here: [link]. I can do two videos for [their product] in seven days, one revision, \$400. 50% to hold the week. If the timing is wrong, ignore this.

Page headline

Kitchen-tool product videos. You get files, not a follower pitch.

Brief questions (send as a form)

Product name and the URL

Three facts that are true

Any claim I must not make

Two ads you like (links)

Where to ship the product, or a date I can film what I have

Deadline, if it is not ‘seven days from in-hand’

Delivery note

Files are in this folder. Two vertical mp4s, captions on. One revision window, 48 hours, written notes. After that I am glad to do another round as a \$75 add-on.

Week-by-week

Week 1: two samples. Day 1, pick the niche and the two products on your shelf. Day 2, shoot. Day 3, edit and put them on a page with the \$400 pack. Days 4–7, five emails to brands you already buy. Do not build a marketplace profile instead of sending the five.

Week 2: follow-up and a sixth brand if needed. One follow-up, four days later, one line: ‘Looping this to the top in case it got buried. Samples still here: [link].’ If someone says ‘maybe next quarter,’ ask if they have a sibling SKU now. Do not wait.

Week 3: deliver the first paid brief. Deposit, intake, script in your mouth, shoot, edit, files. One revision. Ask for the next SKU and one name. Do not start a skincare sample ‘while you wait.’

Week 4: stay in the niche. Second pack at the same \$400, or founder-rate closed. Write down what broke in the first shoot (audio, messy sink, a claim you had to cut) and make it a checklist. Four videos in your folder is a portfolio. Forty half-finished ideas is not.

The quality bar

Clear beats cinematic. A stable phone, a window, and a sentence you would say in a store will outperform a shaky dolly shot with a script you cannot pronounce.

Picture and sound

Product in the first two seconds. If they have to wait for the brand, they swipe.

Face or hands, plus the tool doing the job. Talking-head with the product off-screen is a podcast.

Audio you can hear on a phone speaker. A \$20 lav or a quiet room. The dishwasher is off.

Captions. Most people watch muted. If the caption is the whole script in three giant lines, it is unreadable. One short line at a time.

Claims

You do not make medical claims. You do not make ‘this will change your life in 7 days’ claims you know are false. You do not invent a statistic. If the brand sends a claim you would not repeat to a friend, you send it back. The ad is their legal problem and your name on camera. Both matter.

Human

If you would not say it in a store aisle, it does not go in the video. AI outlines. You speak. A little mess in a real kitchen is trust. A fake marble island with a product still in the Amazon tape is not.

What to measure

You are selling packs, not views. Measure the business you control.

Emails sent this week. Five is the floor in week 1. Zero emails means zero briefs, no matter how good the garlic press ad is.

Replies and yeses. A 20–40% reply rate on warm brands you already buy from is normal. Cold marketplace bids will be worse. Stay warm until you have cases.

Days from yes to files. Target seven from product-in-hand. If it is 18, your revision process or your shoot block is sloppy.

Revision count. One is the package. Two means your brief missed the claims list. Three means you are training them to use you as an art department.

Repeat rate. The goal is a second SKU from the same brand, not a new niche. One repeat in the first five clients is a real business.

Do not let a brand make your metric ‘how the ad performed.’ You did not buy the traffic. You made the file. If they insist, you can ask them to send you a screenshot later for your page — as a favor, not as a warranty.

Objections you will hear

‘Can you do it for product only?’ No. Working for exposure is the thing to leave alone. You can buy the product and film a sample. That is marketing. Their product in the mail is not a salary.

‘We need this to go viral.’ You cannot promise that. You can promise two clear videos in seven days. If they need a virality clause, they need a different vendor, or they need to run paid ads, which is their job.

‘We already have a UGC platform.’ Good. Those platforms are full of \$50 videos. Your page is two samples in their exact niche and a human email. Some brands still want that. If they do not, next email.

‘Can we hop on a call?’ Maybe a 15-minute walkthrough after the deposit. A 40-minute ‘let us explore’ call before money is the job. Send the brief form first.

‘Our last creator made medical claims and we got flagged.’ Put the claims-you-will-not-make box on the intake. Write it: ‘I will not say anything you cannot stand behind.’

‘\$400 seems high for two TikToks.’ They are not TikToks. They are product videos a brand can run. Two samples are on the page. If \$400 is wrong for them, \$150 for exposure is wrong for you.

What this path feeds next

A finished pack is a case. Cases feed a \$19 playbook and a skill pack of the outlines you actually used. Do not sell those until you have delivered paid work.

The same niche becomes a retainer: four videos a month, first Friday, one price. Local brands in your town who sell kitchen tools will hire you faster than a national name. Walk in with the two samples on your phone.

What this does not feed: a personal brand built on promising you can make anything viral. Keep the page boring and specific. Kitchen-tool product videos. Files in seven days.

Mistakes that kill this path

Medical claims. Fake urgency you know is false. ‘Clinically proven’ on a garlic press. You will get a brand flagged and you will not get the second SKU.

Unlimited rounds. One revision is a package. Open-ended ‘until we love it’ is a second job you forgot to price.

Waiting for a platform to send you brands. Marketplaces train you to race to \$75. Five emails to brands you already use is the channel.

Working for exposure. Free product is not a brief. A tag is not a deposit.

Reading the AI script like a hostage. If you cannot say it in the kitchen, it does not go in the ad.

Promising virality. You do not control distribution. Sell the files.

Building a 12-item menu before two samples exist. Two videos, one price, one niche. Then a rate card add-on. Then a retainer. In that order.

Tools

Phone. Vertical. Clean the lens. 4K if it will still export a reasonable file; 1080p is fine for ads. You do not need a cinema camera for a spatula.

CapCut. Captions, cuts, export. Stay off music you cannot license. Silence plus the room plus your voice is legal and human.

A rate card. One page. Pack, rush, extra revision, extra video. Not a Figma palace.

AI for script outlines only. Hook, demo beats, a list of claims to avoid. Then your mouth. Then the throw-away pass.

A simple page. Carrd, Notion, Stan, a Google Doc with two unlisted YouTube or Vimeo embeds. Deposit via Stripe. Email you actually check.

A cheap lav or a quiet room. Optional tripod. Window. That is the studio.

Leave the marketplace apps alone until five organic emails have had a chance. Leave the ring-light shopping cart alone until a brand has paid.

Checklist

- Niche picked from a drawer you already have
- Two sample ads shot and edited, 15–30 seconds, captions on
- Rate card: two videos, one revision, seven days, \$400
- Rush, extra revision, extra video written as add-ons
- One-page with samples, price, deposit link
- Brief form: facts, claims you will not make, examples they like
- Five emails to brands you already buy
- One follow-up four days later
- Deposit before you shoot
- Script said out loud, AI lines you would not say are gone
- Vertical files delivered, named, no watermark
- One revision window, 48 hours, written notes
- Ask for the next SKU and one referral
- No virality promise anywhere on the page

FAQ

Do I need followers?

No. Brands paying \$400 for two videos are buying files they can run. Followers are a bonus if you have them. They are not the product. Two samples in the niche beat 40,000 followers in a different niche.

Should I join a UGC marketplace?

You can later. Do not wait on one. Those platforms are useful when you already have a pack and a rate. They are a trap when they are your only channel and the bids start at \$50. Five emails first.

Who pays for the product?

For samples, you do. You already own it. For a paid brief, they ship it or you invoice a product budget. Do not buy \$200 of inventory on a maybe. Deposit first, then shipping.

How long should each video be?

15–30 seconds for v1. Some ad placements want 6 seconds later. You can cut a 6-second hook from a 20-second file if you shot a clean first line. Do not deliver a 90-second story and call it an ad.

What if I freeze on camera?

Talk to the product, not the lens, for the first sample. Demo-heavy videos hide a shy face. You still need to be willing to be seen. If you cannot, this is the wrong path.

Can I use AI to generate the spokesperson?

Not for this path. Brands hiring UGC want a person. AI is for outlines. You are the mouth.

What about music?

Skip it unless the brand sends a track they own. Trending audio can get an ad pulled. Voice, captions, the sound of the tool — enough.

Do I need an LLC and a contract?

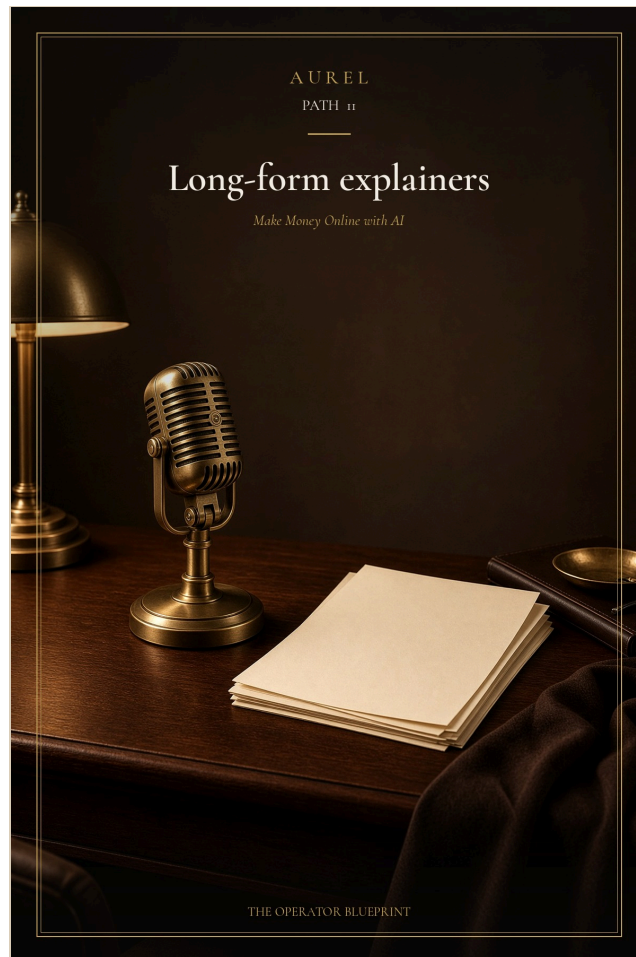
A one-page agreement is enough for pack one: deliverable, timeline, price, revision, claims, who owns the files (they do, on payment). Deposit via Stripe. The agreement cannot wait.

How do I handle a brand that wants 10 videos this week?

That is a different package. Quote it: 10 videos, two revision rounds, 14 days, \$1,600, 50% deposit. Do not say yes at \$400. Do not say yes at all if you cannot shoot that volume without wrecking the seven-day promise to someone else.

What if the first five emails go nowhere?

Send five more in the same niche. Change the subject line to the product you already use. Check that the page loads on a phone. Do not switch to skincare on day eight. The niche is the asset. The emails are the work.



PATH 11

Long-form explainers

Eight honest minutes on the question they already type. Soft ask at the end.

17 minute read · 3,798 words

Who this is for

You can explain a job without rushing. You can sit still for a recording.

Time to first

30–60 days of one video a week

Tools

First sale

A video that produces a click to your offer.

Cash window

Supports the \$19–\$47 file

Leave this alone

YouTube, a cheap mic, a doc outline, AI for research notes you will verify.

Daily uploads with no point. Copying someone else's series.

What you are selling

Short-form borrows attention. Long-form can keep it. A video that fully answers a search question earns the right to mention your playbook at the end. That is the path: eight honest minutes on the question they already type, a soft ask at the last 45 seconds, one link in the description.

You are not selling the video. YouTube's ad money on a new channel is a rounding error. You are selling the click to a \$19–\$47 file that does the job the video just taught. The video is the proof. The file is the cash window.

Thumbnails and titles are the product the algorithm and the human both see. The video keeps the promise those two things made. If the title says 'how to plan a week of posts for a one-person cleaning company' and the video is a 14-minute origin story about your brand, you lied. They leave. You do not get the click. You do not get the \$19.

AI is useful for the outline and the counter-arguments ('what would a skeptic say at minute four'). You verify every fact. You tell the story. If the model invented a statistic, it does not go in the video. A made-up number on camera is how you teach people not to trust the file either.

What this is not

This is not a daily vlog. This is not a second channel 'for fun.' This is not copying someone else's series frame for frame. One video a week, one question, one offer. Boring on purpose. Boring ships.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can explain a job without rushing. You can sit still for a recording. You already have, or can finish this month, a \$19–\$47 file that the video can point at. Without the file, long-form is a hobby with a microphone.

It also fits if you have patience measured in weeks, not hours. Time to first is 30–60 days of one video a week. Search is slow. A video that answers a real question can send clicks for years. It will not send them on Tuesday because you posted on Monday.

Skip this if

Skip it if you cannot sit through eight minutes of your own voice. Record a test. If you hate it so much you will not publish, pick short-form or a written how-to. The camera is not mandatory for a living. It is mandatory for this path.

Skip it if you want daily uploads with no point. Daily with no offer is a second job that pays in comments. Skip it if you planned to copy someone else's series because theirs has views. Their series is their scar tissue. Yours has to be a job you can teach.

Skip it if you need cash this week. Use a service path. Come back to long-form when the \$19 file exists and you can spare one recording block a week.

The offer, named in one sentence

The on-camera offer is one sentence, same every video: 'If you want the one-page version plus the prompts, the \$19 playbook is in the description.' Soft. Once. After you have actually taught the job.

The real offer is the file. The video is a free, complete answer to one search question. You do not withhold the steps to force the click. You teach the whole small job. The file is for people who want the checklist, the prompts, and the 10-day sequence without rewinding you.

Write this before you outline video one

'I answer [search question] in eight minutes for [person], then I point at [file] for \$19.' Example: 'I answer how a one-person bookkeeper closes the month in Claude, then I point at the \$19 month-end playbook.'

If you cannot name the search question, you do not have a video. If you cannot name the file, you are building a channel with no cash register. Do both on paper before you buy a light.

What done looks like

Done for a single video: a stranger can search the question, click your title, stay past 20 seconds, finish the job you promised, and see one clear next step. Chapters in the description. Tools listed. The offer once. An end screen with one link, not eight.

Done for the path: four videos in four weeks, same offer, titles written like searches. Then ten videos, and you double down on the three that earned saves or comments. A click that bought the \$19 file is the first sale. Views without a click are a nice crowd. They are not the first sale.

The done bar on the file side

The playbook must exist and the link must work on a phone. Test it. If the description link is a Linktree with twelve buttons, you do not have a soft ask. You have a junk drawer. One link. The \$19 file.

What the video is allowed to sell

Cash window: this path supports the \$19–\$47 file. It is not a \$2,000 course funnel in month one. The video teaches a small job. The file is the job written down with templates.

\$19 is the default ask at the end of an eight-minute explainer. \$47 if the file includes the prompts, a filled example, and a 14-day plan. Do not pitch a \$297 cohort from video three. You have no series yet. They have no reason.

YouTube ad revenue is a sidecar, not the plan. Do not wait for 1,000 subscribers to ‘monetize.’ You monetize from video one with the link. The platform’s ads are gravy if they ever arrive.

What you do not sell in the video

You do not sell a second channel, a merch line, or a vague ‘work with me.’ You do not stack five affiliate links under an eight-minute tutorial. One offer. If an affiliate tool is truly used on screen, disclose it and keep it below the playbook link. The playbook is the reason you sat down.

The first 72 hours

Search the question your buyer already types. Outline eight minutes. Record even if the lighting is boring. Publish. End with one link. Write the title like a search, not a brand campaign. Make a thumbnail that reads at phone size.

Hours 1–8

Open YouTube and Google. Type the job. Read the titles that already rank. Write five questions in their words, not yours. Pick one you can answer without a week of research. Outline: result in 20 seconds, three steps, one mistake, one recap, the \$19 ask.

Ask the model for counter-arguments and a chapter list. Verify anything that looks like a fact. Delete invented numbers.

Hours 9–24

Cheap mic. Face the window. Notes on the desk, not a teleprompter novel. Record the eight minutes in one or two takes. You are allowed to be boring. You are not allowed to be false.

Hours 25–72

Edit only what you must: dead air, the cough, the 40-second ramble. Thumbnail: five words, readable on a phone, your face or the result, not a collage. Title = the search question. Description = chapters, tools, one link. Publish. Do not start a second video until this one is live.

The path, step by step

Step 1. One video a week beats five abandoned channels. Put the recording block on the calendar like a shift. Same day, same length. If you miss a week, you record two the next. You do not open a second channel to ‘reset.’

Step 2. Title is the search question. ‘How to close month-end in Claude as a solo bookkeeper’ beats ‘AI Tips That Will Change Your Practice.’ You are not a brand campaign. You are an answer.

Step 3. First 20 seconds: the result they get by staying. ‘By the end of this you will have a close checklist you can run tomorrow, including the prompt that asks for missing numbers instead of inventing them.’ Then start. No 90-second bio.

Step 4. Teach the whole small job. Do not tease a part two for a job that fits in one video. If it does not fit in eight to twelve minutes, the job is two videos with two titles, not a cliffhanger.

Step 5. Outline on a doc, not in your head. Chapters: promise, step 1, step 2, step 3, the mistake, recap, ask. AI can draft this. You reorder it so a tired person can follow.

Step 6. Verify every fact. If the model invented a statistic, it does not go in the video. If you have not run the prompt on screen, you do not claim it works.

Step 7. Record like a person at a table. Cheap mic, sit still, talk. Reading a script like a hostage is a mistake this path does not survive. Notes are fine. A novel is not.

Step 8. Thumbnail that reads at phone size. Five words. High contrast. One idea. If you cannot read it with the phone at arm’s length, it is decoration.

Step 9. Description: chapters, tools, the offer. Timestamps. The \$19 link once, near the top and again at the end. Tools you actually used.

Step 10. End screen is one link. Not a grid of eight old videos and a subscribe animation that eats the ask. One button, the playbook.

Step 11. After ten videos, double down on the three that earned saves or comments. Repeat those shapes. Same structure, new question. Kill the formats that died in silence.

Step 12. Do not start a second channel. And do not start a second offer. Four weeks, one file. Then another four. Search compounds on a name, not on a network of empty accounts.

Worked example: Morgan and the \$19 playbook at the end

Morgan is a solo bookkeeper who already sold a \$19 playbook: a month-end close sequence for one-person bookkeepers using Claude, with the prompts and a checklist. Sales were friends-

and-friends. Search was not sending anyone. Morgan could explain the job without rushing and could sit still for a recording. That is the whole qualification.

The weekly machine

One video a week, eight to ten minutes, cheap mic, kitchen table, window on the left. Every video ended on the same sentence: ‘If you want the checklist and the prompts in one file, the \$19 playbook is in the description.’ No countdown. No fake scarcity.

Video 1 title: ‘How to close month-end in Claude without it inventing numbers.’ Thumbnail: ‘STOP fake totals’ in four words plus Morgan’s face. First 20 seconds: what ‘done’ looks like — a close checklist with gaps flagged, not filled with guesses. Then the three-step job. Soft ask at 8:10.

Video 2: ‘What to paste into Claude when the client’s receipts are a mess.’ Video 3: ‘The month-end prompt that asks one question at a time.’ Video 4: ‘Why your AI close keeps drifting off the trial balance.’ Each one a search question. Each one a complete small job. None of them a trailer for a course.

What happened

Week 1: 90 views, two description clicks, zero sales. Morgan did not start a second channel.

Week 2: a comment from a bookkeeper who argued about GST. That argument became video 4.

Week 5: 400 views on video 1 from search, 11 clicks, two \$19 sales. First stranger sale from a video: day 36. Inside the 30–60 day window.

By video 10, three titles had earned comments and watch time: the inventing-numbers video, the receipts video, and the trial-balance video. Morgan repeated those shapes for the next month instead of inventing a travel vlog. The playbook did not change. The titles did the work. Daily uploads never entered the chat.

Copy you can paste

Title formulas (search, not campaign)

How to [job] in [tool] without [pain they already have]

What to paste into [tool] when [messy input]

Why your [result] keeps [failure], and the fix in 8 minutes

First 20 seconds

By the end of this you will have [named artifact] you can use [timeframe]. I will show the three steps, the one mistake I still see, and then a file if you want the checklist. If you only want the video, that is enough. Stay for the steps.

Soft ask at the end

If you want the one-page version plus the prompts, the \$19 playbook is the first link in the description. It is the same sequence I just walked through, written down so you do not have to rewind me. If the video was enough, good. Use it.

Description block

0:00 What 'done' looks like

0:40 Step 1

3:00 Step 2

5:20 The mistake

7:10 Recap

8:00 The \$19 file

Playbook: [one link]

Tools on screen: [names]

I use [tool]. If I mention an affiliate later it will be disclosed. Today the only ask is the file.

Thumbnail text (five words or fewer)

STOP invented numbers

Paste the messy receipts

One question at a time

Week-by-week

Week 1. Pick the question. Outline eight minutes. Record even if the lighting is boring. Publish. End with one link. Do not record four videos ‘to batch a month’ before you have seen whether you will actually upload.

Week 2. Same offer, new search question in the same job family. Read the comments from video 1. One of them is the outline. Follow up on video 1 in the community tab with a single line and the same link. Once.

Week 3. Third video. Improve the thumbnail on video 1 if the click-through is sad (under 2% after impressions exist). Do not rewrite the whole channel name.

Week 4. Fourth video. You now have a month. Look at comments and average view duration, not vanity views. Repeat the shape that earned the most saves or comments next week.

Then: one video a week for four more weeks. After ten, double down on the three that earned a response. Do not start a second channel. Do not add a second file until the first one is the only link you are willing to say out loud.

The quality bar

Honest minutes beat produced minutes. A kitchen table, a cheap mic, and a kept promise will outlast a studio intro you cannot sustain every week.

Picture and sound

Sit still. Face a window. Mic within a foot of your mouth. If the fridge is loud, unplug it for ten minutes. You do not need four-camera switching. You need words a tired bookkeeper can follow.

The promise

Title, thumbnail, and first 20 seconds agree. The video pays them off. Clickbait the video cannot pay off is the fastest way to train YouTube and humans to skip you.

Facts

You verify. The model drafts an outline and lists counter-arguments. If a number did not come from you, a primary source, or a screen you can show, it stays out. Saying ‘I do not know that number’ on camera is quality. Inventing one is not.

The ask

Soft, once, after the job is taught. Hard sells at minute one, or a missing ask at minute eight, both fail. Teach. Then point.

What to measure

A video that produces a click to your offer is the first sale unit. Views are the weather.

Click-through on the title and thumbnail. If impressions exist and CTR is under 2%, the search language is weak or the thumbnail is wallpaper.

Average view duration vs length. If they leave at 25 seconds, the first 20 seconds did not name a result. If they stay and bounce at the ask, the ask is too hard or the file is unclear.

Description clicks. YouTube Studio shows them. Zero clicks and a thousand views means the offer is invisible or untrusted.

\$19 sales attributed to the week a video went up. Crude, good enough. UTM on the link if you can.

Comments that argue with the method. Those are video outlines. Count them. Answer them on camera, not in a 40-reply thread.

Do not measure daily upload streaks. This path is one a week. A streak of empty videos is the thing to leave alone.

Objections you will hear

‘Long-form is dead. Only Shorts work.’ Shorts borrow attention. They can send people here. They are not a replacement for eight minutes that answer a search question. Search still pays

the file. Shorts without an offer pay in noise.

‘I need better gear first.’ You need a cheap mic and a question. Lighting can be a window. Gear shopping is a delay costume.

‘I should post every day to feed the algorithm.’ Daily uploads with no point are the leave-alone. One honest video a week, done, beats seven sketches you are ashamed of.

‘What if someone copies my series?’ They might copy the titles. They cannot copy the way you close a month or plan a week. Teach the whole job anyway. The file still has the prompts.

‘I do not have a playbook yet.’ Then this path is early. Write the \$19 file first, or in the same 72 hours as video 1. A channel with no register is a diary.

‘My voice sounds weird.’ Everyone thinks that. Sit still. Talk. Publish video one. You will hate it. Video four is less painful. Giving up at video three is the mistake this path is famous for.

What this path feeds next

The ten videos are a library. Three of them become Shorts with the same offer. The comments become newsletter issues. The outlines become chapters in a \$47 version of the file.

A video that ranks is a front door you do not have to stand in. People will still arrive in six months. That is why you do not delete video one because it only got 90 views in week one.

If a local owner comments, that is a lead for a productized week. If a brand asks you to make product videos, that is a different path — do not pivot the channel into UGC ads. Keep the explainers. Sell the other pack from a different page.

What this feeds badly: five more channels. One name. One file. One weekly block. Let the rest of the suite take the overflow.

Mistakes that kill this path

Clickbait the video cannot pay off. A title about a complete job and a video that is a teaser. They will not buy the \$19 file from someone who already cheated the eight minutes.

Reading a script like a hostage. Notes, not a novel. If you cannot say it to a person across a table, do not say it to a lens.

No offer. A beautiful explainer with nowhere to go. Soft ask, one link.

Giving up at video three. Time to first is 30–60 days of one a week. Video three is still the hallway.

Daily uploads with no point. Copying someone else's series. Starting a second channel because the first one 'feels tainted.' Inventing a statistic because the model sounded confident.

Teasing part two for a job that fits in one video. Teach the job. If there is a bigger job, it gets its own search title next week.

Tools

YouTube. One channel. Search titles. Studio for CTR, duration, description clicks. Do not spread the same eight minutes across four platforms in week 1. You can upload the file elsewhere later.

A cheap mic. A wired lav or a simple USB mic. Phone mics in a quiet room can work for video one. Echoey kitchens cannot.

A doc outline. Google Doc or paper. Chapters with timestamps after you edit. AI for research notes you will verify, for counter-arguments, for a title list. Not for facts you cannot show.

The \$19–\$47 file and a working link. Stan, Stripe, your site. Test on a phone. One link.

A window and a chair. Optional cheap light. Optional screen recording if the job is a tool. CapCut or the YouTube editor for cuts. You do not need a studio subscription to explain month-end.

Checklist

\$19–\$47 file exists and the link works on a phone

One search question written in the buyer's words

Eight-minute outline: result, three steps, mistake, recap, ask

AI notes verified, invented statistics deleted

First 20 seconds names the result of staying

Recorded at a table, cheap mic, sit still

Title = the search question

Thumbnail reads at phone size, five words or fewer

Description: chapters, tools, one offer link

End screen is one link

Published. Not sitting in drafts

One video a week on the calendar

After ten, three winners marked to repeat

No second channel, no daily empty uploads

FAQ

How long should the video be?

Eight honest minutes is the default. Twelve if the job needs a screen recording. Twenty only if you are actually teaching twenty minutes of work, not stalling. People searching a how-to will stay if you pay off the title. They will not stay for a tour of your setup.

Do I need to show my face?

It helps trust. It is not required if the job is a screen and your voice is clear. A talking head at a table is the simplest version of this path. Pick one and keep it for ten videos.

Can I batch a month in a day?

You can record two on a good day. Do not batch eight before you have uploaded one. You will learn from comments. Batching a dead format is efficient waste.

Shorts as well?

After you have four long videos. Cut a 30-second piece from the mistake section. Same offer in the pinned comment. Do not replace the weekly explainer with only Shorts. Search lives on the long one.

What if I have no playbook?

Write it this week, even ugly. The video can sell a simple PDF: checklist plus prompts. That is enough for \$19. Do not build a 12-week course to justify sitting down.

Should I tell a long origin story?

No. First 20 seconds are the result. Origin can be one sentence. They typed a question. Answer it.

How do I pick the next title?

Search plus comments. The question people ask under video 1 is video 2. The failure they confess is video 3. After ten, repeat the three that earned a response.

What about copyright music and clips?

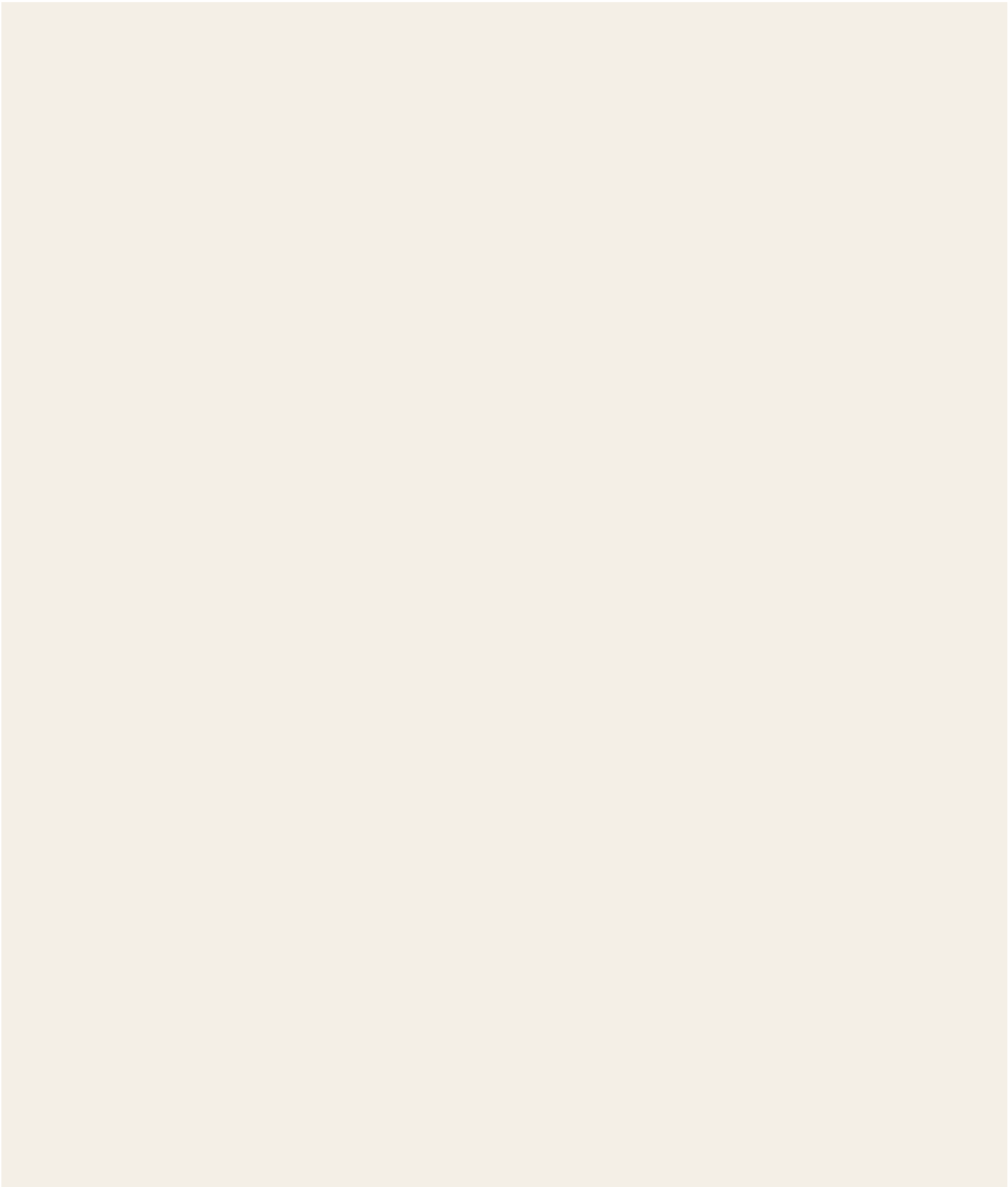
Skip them. Your voice, your screen, your cheap mic. A stolen track can kill the video that was about to rank.

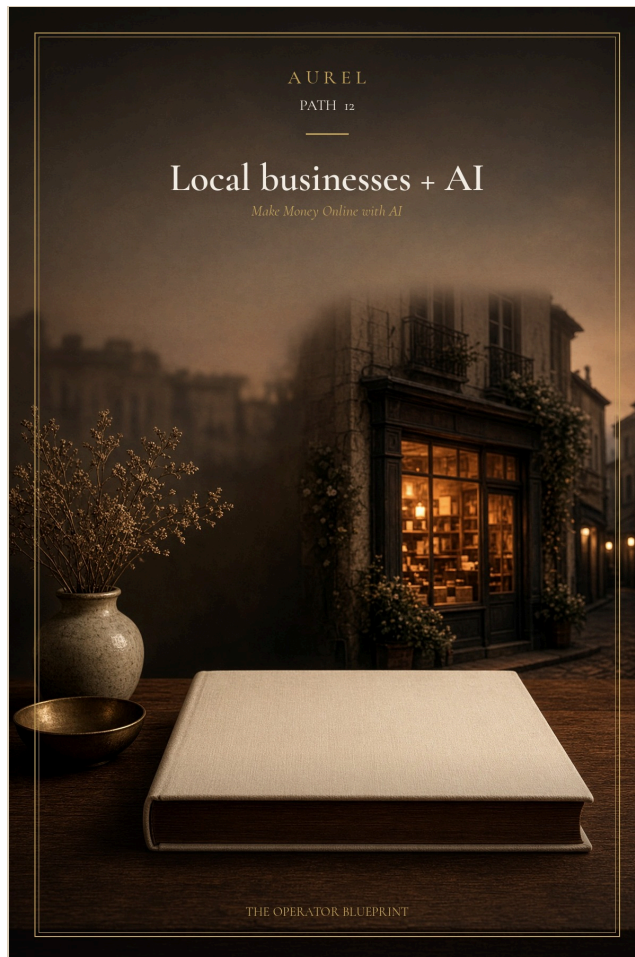
When do I change the offer?

When the \$19 file has buyers who ask for the next layer. Then a \$47 version, same channel, same weekly video, new link. Not a new channel. Not five files in the description.

I published three videos and nothing happened. Now what?

That is the hallway. Time to first is 30–60 days of one a week. Check titles against real searches. Check that the link works. Record video four on the same job. Giving up at video three is how this path dies, not how the algorithm ‘rejects’ you.





PATH 12

Local businesses + AI

Nearby owners still need pages, replies, and simple videos. Cash while digital compounds.

18 minute read · 3,870 words

Who this is for

You live near businesses that still get customers from Google, word of mouth, or a dusty site.

First sale

One local yes and a deposit.

Time to first

3–14 days of walking and writing

Cash window

\$400–\$2,000 packages

Tools

Leave this alone

A one-page PDF of the package, Stripe or e-transfer, City-wide ‘we do all AI’ agencies.
your phone.

What you are selling

A named week of work for a nearby owner. Not a 12-month ‘AI transformation.’ Not a city-wide agency. A package with a date on it: an AI-drafted page plus five posts, delivered by Friday. You edit every draft before they see it. You are the quality, not the model.

Nearby owners still need pages, replies, and simple videos. They get customers from Google, word of mouth, or a dusty site that still says ‘opening soon’ from 2019. They do not need your philosophy about large language models. They need a page that tells a human what the gym costs and five posts that do not sound like a robot moved to town.

You walk in or email with a one-page PDF. Price so one yes covers the week. Cash while digital compounds: this path pays now. The notes from the job become a playbook you can sell later to people not in your town. Do not reverse that order. Do not build the playbook instead of walking.

What this is not

This is not ‘we do all AI’ for every shop from the highway to the river. That sentence makes you look like a vendor who will vanish. One trade at a time. One package. One week. The first yes is allowed to be a small job. A 12-month retainer is a conversation after they have Friday’s files in hand.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you live near businesses that still get customers from Google, word of mouth, or a dusty site. You can walk into a gym or a cleaner’s office without melting. You can write a clear page in English a tired owner will recognize as their shop, not as a template from a different city.

You do not need to be a marketer of record. You need a package, a printer or a phone PDF, and the nerve to follow up the next day. Introverts can email. The work is the same: ten names, five asks, one follow-up.

Skip this if

Skip it if you want to be a city-wide ‘we do all AI’ agency. That is the thing to leave alone. You will spend a month on a pitch deck and zero days on a hallway.

Skip it if you cannot tell the owner no when they ask you to invent a claim they cannot legally make. Dentists, gyms, and cleaners all have lines. You will not be the person who writes ‘guaranteed 20 lb loss’ or ‘hospital-grade kill of every pathogen’ because the model sounded confident.

Skip it if you need to hide behind DMs with strangers in other countries this week. This path is local on purpose. The bus fare is part of the method.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write it on the PDF in a font they can read without glasses: ‘Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800.’

That is Taylor’s pack. Yours can be the same shape at a different number inside the \$400–\$2,000 window. The shape is the product: a named week, a page, five posts (or five videos), a Friday, a deposit.

What is in

One page: home or services, written from their facts, edited by you, in a doc or CMS they already use.

Five posts: captions plus a photo brief, or five simple videos from your phone if that is the pack you named.

One round of notes, 24 hours, written.

A 15-minute walkthrough on Friday so they know which button to press.

What is not in

Ads spend. A new logo. A 12-month content calendar. A new website platform unless they already asked and you priced it as a different job. You do not sell a retainer until you have

delivered once.

What done looks like

Done for the path: one local yes and a deposit. Not a maybe. Not ‘send me something.’ Money in, date on the calendar.

Done for the week: Friday files they can use without you in the room. The page is in their voice, with their hours, their price range if they allow it, their real service list. The five posts are scheduled or sitting in a folder with the image brief. You did not paste raw model output. You cut the claims they cannot make.

The done bar

Deposit received before you draft.

Kickoff: 20 minutes or a form. Facts, photos they can send, phrases they hate, examples of posts they do not hate.

Drafts they never see until you have edited.

Friday delivery in a folder they own, plus the walkthrough.

A referral ask the same day: ‘Who else on this street should hear this?’

If you ghost after the posts go up, it is not done. It is a one-star story the next owner will hear at the coffee shop.

Price so one yes covers the week

Cash window: \$400–\$2,000 packages. Taylor’s ‘page plus five posts this week’ sits at \$800. That number should cover your hours, your walking, and the fact that you cannot sell Friday twice.

\$400–\$500 is a founder pack if you need the first case and you will write that on the PDF as a first-seat price with a date it expires. \$800 is the default once you have one sample page made from public info. \$1,200–\$2,000 when the page is a full services rewrite plus five videos, or when the owner has two locations.

Deposit

50% to start, 50% Friday before the walkthrough, or 50/50 with the balance on delivery. E-transfer, Stripe, whatever they already use. Do not start a draft on a handshake. Local does not mean casual about money. Local means you might see them at the grocery store, which is why a clean PDF and a clean invoice matter more, not less.

Do not discount to ‘win the street.’ One \$800 yes is the week. Two \$300 maybes is a mess. Do not sell a 12-month retainer at a mystery rate until they have seen Friday once. A retainer, later, can be \$1,200 a month for four posts a week. That is a different PDF. After.

The first 72 hours

Write the one-pager. List ten businesses. Visit or email five. Follow up the next day. The first yes is allowed to be a small job.

Hours 1–8

One trade. Taylor starts with cleaners, then walks gyms with the same pack. You start with one. Learn ten phrases they use: ‘booth,’ ‘membership freeze,’ ‘move-out clean,’ ‘drop-in.’ Write the PDF: headline, what is in, Friday, \$800, deposit, your phone, two sentences of proof if you have any (a sample page from public info counts).

Build one sample from a real local site that is dusty. Rewrite their home section in a doc. Watermark SAMPLE. You will show it, then offer to do theirs properly with their facts.

Hours 9–48

List ten. Visit or email five. Walk-in: ‘I am not selling a 12-month thing. One page, five posts, this week, \$800. PDF is one page. Can I leave it with you?’ Email: six lines, the PDF, the sample, a Friday date you can actually hit.

Hours 49–72

Follow up the next day. In person or one line: ‘I can still start this week if the deposit lands today. Friday files either way.’ Do not add a second package. Do not redesign the PDF. Walk the next five

if the first five were silent.

The path, step by step

Step 1. One trade. Learn their language. Cleaners, gyms, dentists, trades. Read five of their Google reviews. The words customers use are the words on the page. ‘They actually showed up’ is a better headline than ‘synergized cleaning solutions.’

Step 2. The named week on one PDF. Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800. Print ten copies. Phone PDF for the ones who will not take paper.

Step 3. A sample made from public info. Their dusty site, rewritten in a doc, SAMPLE across it. Then: ‘I can do yours properly with your facts.’ Do not pretend you already work there.

Step 4. Ten names, five visits or emails. Hallway, front desk, or the contact form they ignore. You are not a city-wide blast. You are a person on this street.

Step 5. Follow up the next day. One time, clearly. Owners are busy, not coy. If they say no, ask who else on the block would want Friday files. If they say later, put a date.

Step 6. Deposit. Kickoff. Money, then a 20-minute fact pull: hours, services, prices they will print, photos, phrases to ban, claims they must not make. Write the bans down.

Step 7. Draft with the model. Edit like you live here. AI can draft. They never see the raw pass. Cut fake urgency. Cut medical or chemical claims. Put the real cross-street in the copy. Put the real parking note.

Step 8. Deliver Friday. Folder they own. Page in a format they can paste. Five posts with the photo brief. Fifteen-minute walkthrough. Balance paid.

Step 9. Ask for a referral to the next owner on the same street. Same day. ‘If this saved you a headache, who else should I walk to before I go home?’

Step 10. Do not ghost. A text on Monday: ‘Any post you want swapped?’ One check-in. Then stop hovering. You are not their staff.

Step 11. Notes from the job become a playbook. The phrases, the claims you refused, the kickoff questions. That file can sell to cleaners in other towns. Later. After cash this week.

Step 12. Only then, a second week or a retainer. Same pack for the gym two doors down, or a monthly at a written rate. Not a 12-month contract sold on day one. Not a new trade on the other side of the city until this street has seen you deliver.

Worked example: Taylor walking gyms and cleaners

Taylor lives in a town where the highway gyms have new paint and the independent ones have a Facebook page last updated for a New Year promo. The cleaners are busier than they look. Taylor is not an agency. Taylor has a phone, a one-page PDF, and a week to fill.

The pack

‘Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800.’ In: one services or home page, five posts (caption plus what to photograph), one round of notes. Out: ads, logos, a new website builder. Sample attached: a rewrite of a cleaner’s public home page, SAMPLE watermark, with the fake claims stripped.

Taylor printed twelve PDFs at the library. Listed ten cleaners and eight gyms. Day 1 was the PDF. Days 2–4 were walking. Cleaners in the morning (owners actually in). Gyms at 10:30, between classes, not at 5pm.

The first yes

A two-van cleaning company. The owner had been meaning to ‘fix the site’ for a year. The sample looked like her shop instead of a national franchise. She asked if Taylor could also promise ‘hospital-grade’ in the copy. Taylor said no: ‘I will not write a claim you cannot stand behind. I will write that you are bonded, that move-outs take a day, and that you text an ETA. \$800. 50% today.’ E-transfer on the van hood. Kickoff in the office: 18 minutes, a list of services, three photos from her camera roll, a ban list.

Taylor drafted that night. Edited the next morning — the model had added ‘eco-certified’ which they were not. Five posts: a before-and-after (with permission), a move-out checklist, a ‘what we

will not do' post that built trust, a hiring post for a third van, a Friday availability. Delivered Thursday night, walkthrough Friday. Asked for a referral before leaving. The owner named a gym two streets over whose manager also cleaned for her once.

What happened

Elapsed from first print to deposit: 6 days. Inside 3–14. Taylor walked the gym the same Friday with the cleaner as the intro, not as a secret. Second pack, same \$800, gym language swapped in ('drop-in,' 'freeze,' 'no contract shame'). Did not sell a 12-month retainer. Did not open a city-wide AI shop. Notes went into a doc that later became a \$19 playbook for cleaners in other towns. The week's cash was the \$800. The playbook was the compound.

Copy you can paste

One-pager headline

Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800.

One-pager body

You get a services page written from your facts, plus five posts you can publish this week. I draft with AI. I edit every line before you see it. You get one round of notes. You do not get a 12-month contract, a new logo, or claims you cannot stand behind.

50% to start. Files Friday. Walkthrough Friday. Balance on delivery.

Walk-in line

I am not selling a 12-month thing. One page, five posts, this week, \$800. The PDF is one page. Can I leave it with you?

Email

Hi [name] — I rewrote a sample from your public page (attached, marked sample). I can do yours properly with your facts this week: one page, five posts, \$800, deposit today, files Friday. If the

timing is wrong, ignore this. If a neighbor should see it, tell me who.

Kickoff questions

Hours, service list, anything you will not do

Prices that are allowed on a page

Claims I must not make

Three photos I can use

Phrases you hate

Where the page actually lives (WordPress, Squarespace, Facebook only)

Friday ask

If this saved you a headache, who else on this street should I walk to before I go home?

Week-by-week

Day 1: PDF. Sample page from public info. Ten names. Price on the paper.

Days 2–4: ten visits (or five visits and five emails). Follow up the next day. Do not redesign the offer.

Week 2: deliver and ask the next owner on the same street. Deposit, kickoff, draft, edit, Friday files. Referral the same day. If the first yes was a cleaner, the second walk is a gym or the next cleaner, not a dentist in another town.

Week 3: same pack, full price if you discounted. Write the SOP: kickoff questions, ban list, delivery folder template. A Monday check-in text, then you stop hovering.

Week 4: notes into a playbook draft for people not in your town, or a monthly PDF for the owner who already has Friday files. Do not sell the retainer to a stranger who has not seen you deliver. Do not hire two subcontractors and call yourself an agency.

The quality bar

You are the quality, not the model. If they can tell a chatbot wrote the page, you undercharged their trust and overcharged their Friday.

Edit like you live here

Real hours. Real cross-street. Real parking. Real name of the owner if they want it. No ‘revolutionizing the wellness space.’ No stock photo of a city that is not this one.

Claims

Gyms: no guaranteed body fat numbers. Cleaners: no medical kill-claims unless they have the certificate in a drawer and want it cited. Dentists (if you ever go there): you are not their clinical copywriter. When unsure, cut the line. Write what they do, when they do it, what it costs, how to book.

Delivery

A folder they own. File names a human can read. Posts in the order of the week. Photo briefs that a person with a phone can shoot in ten minutes (‘van in the driveway, 3pm light, no logo overlay’). A walkthrough. Then space.

Ghosting after the posts go up is a quality failure. So is dumping five raw AI captions into their Messenger at 11pm Thursday.

What to measure

The first sale is one local yes and a deposit. Measure movement toward that, then toward Friday.

Names on the list vs visits or emails this week. Ten and five is the 72-hour bar.

Follow-ups sent the next day. Zero follow-ups is how nice PDFs die on a counter.

Days from first walk to deposit. 3–14 is the window. At day 15 with no yes, the PDF is mush or you only visited friends.

Hours from kickoff to Friday files. If it took 18 hours of drafting, your edit pass is too precious or the kickoff missed the facts.

Referral asked, referral given. One name from a happy Friday is worth ten cold gyms.

Claims you refused. Log them. That log is how you stay out of trouble and how the playbook later teaches.

Do not measure 'brand awareness on the street.' Do not measure likes on their posts as your scorecard unless they paid you to run ads, which they did not.

Objections you will hear

'My nephew does Facebook.' Good. This is one page and five posts this week, then you are gone. Nephew can keep the page. You are not replacing their family. You are clearing a backlog.

'Can you just show me a free sample on our account?' No. Doing the work free as a trial is a mistake this path does not survive. The SAMPLE rewrite from public info is the sample. Deposit starts theirs.

'We need to go viral.' You are not promising that. You are promising Friday files. If they want ads, that is a different pack and a different number.

'\$800 is a lot.' One yes covers the week. A cheap website someone never finished already cost them more. If \$800 is wrong, \$400 founder-rate with an expiry date is allowed once. \$0 is not a price.

'Put that we are the best in the city / hospital-grade / guaranteed results.' No. You will not make claims the owner cannot legally make. Offer three true lines instead.

'Can you start and we will pay Friday if we like it?' No. Deposit today. Files Friday. Like-it is what the revision round is for, not what payroll is for.

What this path feeds next

Cash this week is the point. Compound is the notes.

The kickoff questions and the claims you refused become a \$19 playbook for cleaners or gym owners you will never drive to. The five-post structure becomes a template you can sell. A local yes who is happy is a case study (with permission, real name, real town).

The same street becomes a retainer after one delivered week. The same pack becomes five videos instead of five captions if they have a phone and a doorway. Do not turn it into a city-wide agency. The next path is a product, not a headcount.

If you also make printables, the cleaner's 'move-out checklist' can be a \$9 page. If you also do long-form, 'how independent gyms explain drop-ins' is a video. Feed those after Friday, not instead of walking.

Mistakes that kill this path

Doing the work free as a 'trial.' They now have your Friday. You have a maybe.

Making claims the owner cannot legally make. You will both wear that copy.

Ghosting after the posts go up. The coffee-shop review writes itself.

Selling a 12-month retainer before you have delivered once. You do not know their approval speed. They do not know your Friday.

City-wide 'we do all AI' positioning. One trade, one pack, one street.

Starting the draft before the deposit. Starting a second trade in another town while five local names sit unvisited.

Letting them see raw model output. Your name is on the walk-in. The model does not walk in.

Tools

A one-page PDF of the package. Headline, in/out, Friday, \$800, deposit, phone. Printed and on your phone.

Stripe or e-transfer. Whatever the owner already trusts. Invoice with the week's date on it.

Your phone. Camera for samples, maps for the ten names, email, a notes app for the ban list. Five videos, if that is the pack, are also the phone.

A doc for drafts. You write. They receive a clean file, not a chat log.

The model, privately. Drafts only. Never a login you share with the owner as the product.

You do not need a CRM in week one. A list of ten in a notebook is a CRM. You do not need a team. You need shoes that can do four visits in an afternoon.

Checklist

One trade chosen, ten phrases learned from reviews

One-pager PDF: page plus five posts this week, \$800, deposit today, files Friday

Sample rewrite from public info, marked SAMPLE

Ten names on a list

Five visits or emails

Follow-up the next day

Deposit before any draft

Kickoff facts and a written ban list for claims

AI draft edited by you; they never see the raw pass

Friday folder, walkthrough, balance

Referral ask: next owner on the same street

Monday check-in text, then no ghosting and no hovering

Notes saved for a later playbook

No 12-month retainer sold before one delivered week

FAQ

Gyms or cleaners first?

One trade first. Taylor walked cleaners in the morning because owners were on site, then used a referral into a gym. If you have a membership or a mop, start where you already know the words. Same PDF shape. Different nouns.

What if they have no website, only Facebook?

The 'page' is a Facebook services post or a Google Business profile rewrite. Name it on the PDF so they are not expecting a custom domain. Still \$800 if the work is the same. If it is truly smaller, \$400 and still a Friday.

Do I need insurance or an LLC?

A one-page agreement: deliverable, date, price, claims, who owns the copy (they do, on payment). Deposit. Local rules on business licenses vary. Do not let paperwork delay the first five visits. Do not skip the agreement.

Can I do this by email only?

Yes if you will actually send five and follow up. Walking still wins in small towns. Mix it. The path is 'visit or email,' not 'wait to be discovered.'

What about dentists and medical trades?

Same pack, tighter ban list. You do not write clinical promises. If you are not willing to cut lines, skip that trade.

How do I handle an owner who wants endless rewrites?

One round, 24 hours, written notes. Then \$150 for another round. Put it on the PDF. Unlimited is how Friday never comes.

Should I hire someone to walk for me?

No. Not until you have delivered three Fridays. The walk is how you learn the language. A hired body with your PDF is the agency you were told to leave alone.

Can the five posts be videos?

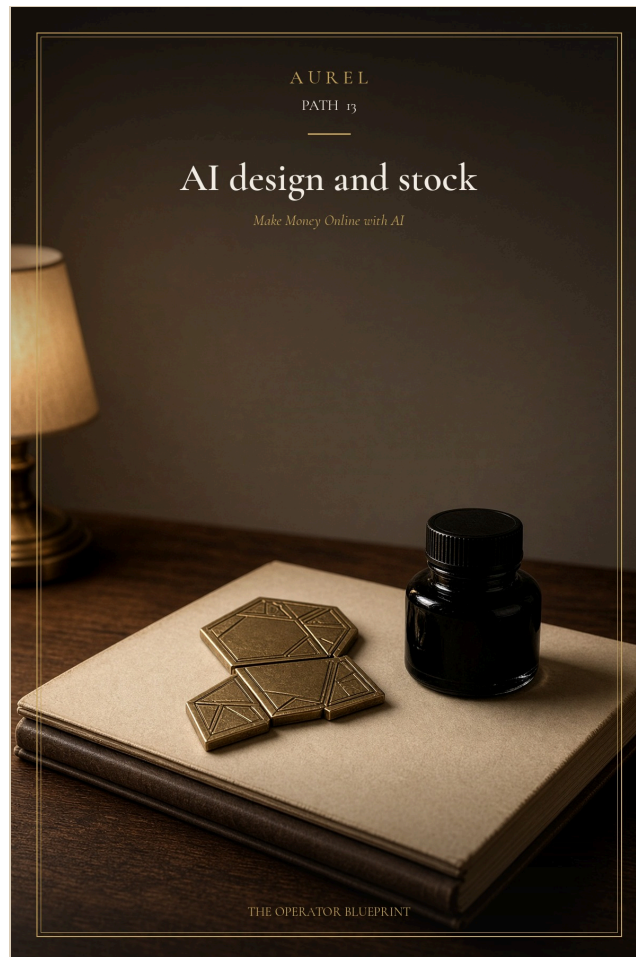
Yes if the PDF says so. Five simple phone videos, same \$800 or \$1,200 if you are also on camera. Do not surprise them with captions when they expected video, or the reverse.

What if the first ten say no?

Follow up once. Ask for a name. Walk the next ten in the same trade. Change the sample, not the whole business. Day 14 with zero deposits means the ask is fuzzy or you never mentioned the price on the paper.

When do I sell the playbook?

After one paid week, when the notes are real. The playbook is for owners you will not drive to. It does not replace the walk this month. Cash while digital compounds — in that order.



PATH 13

AI design and stock

A library, not a lottery ticket. One style, many variations.

16 minute read · 3,489 words

Who this is for

You can produce a coherent set of icons, patterns, or simple graphics.

Time to first

30–90 days to meaningful payout

Tools

First sale

A first payout, however small, that proves the account works.

Cash window

Slow then compounding

Leave this alone

Your design tool, one marketplace, a license you actually read.

One upload and waiting. Unlicensed copies. Raw unedited dumps if the marketplace forbids them.

What this actually is

A stock library is a catalog you add to on a schedule. Not a lottery ticket. Not a shop you open once. One style. Many variations. Buyers search for a job — line icons for a budgeting app, a seamless pattern for packaging, a simple pack for a slide deck — and they pick the set that already looks like it belongs together.

You are selling files a stranger can drop into a project this afternoon. Consistent line weight. A palette that does not fight itself. Names that match how people search. A cinematic hero image that took six hours will sit unsold. Sets that look like a product get downloaded.

AI is a draft engine, not a dump chute. Some marketplaces restrict raw model output. Even when they allow it, buyers can smell unedited generations: warped type, patterns that do not tile, icons on three different grids. Clean, vectorize, or redraw until the file is yours and the set looks like one person made it on purpose.

The money is slow, then compounding. Month one is an account and a handful of sets. Month three is a small payout that proves the pipes work. Month six is a library that earns on a Tuesday you did not open the laptop. If you need rent this month, this is the wrong path. If you can give it ninety minutes a week for a season, it starts to behave like a quiet second till.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can hold a visual language for more than one evening: 2px stroke on a 24px grid, floral patterns that share one leaf, three colors and rounded corners. You do not need a degree. You need a finish standard — cousins, not strangers from different apps.

It also fits if you are patient with search. Nobody is waiting for your drop. Buyers type a job months from now and your set is sitting there. That is the bet.

Skip this if

Skip it if you need cash in fourteen days, if your plan is one upload and a refresh of the dashboard, or if you will not read a contributor license. Skip it if you only enjoy generating novelty and go cold when the work is cleaning nodes, checking a tile seam, or writing the same keyword list again.

If you already sell printables, this is a cousin. Printables solve a Tuesday problem on paper. Stock solves a file problem inside someone else's project. You are stocking their drawer, not teaching them.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you open a canvas: **[number] [style] [asset type] for [the job], commercial use, consistent grid.** If you cannot fill those brackets, you have a mood board, not a set.

Offers that search

24 outline icons for personal-finance apps, 24px grid, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG.

12 seamless bakery patterns for packaging, 12-inch tile, 300 dpi.

16 simple food illustrations for meal-prep decks, three-color palette, transparent PNG.

'Cute stickers pack vol. 4' is a mood. 'Line icons for a habit tracker UI' is a search. People type the job.

What you are not offering

Not a brand identity. Not a custom mascot. Not a course. A folder that drops into Figma, Canva, or Illustrator and behaves. One style across the catalog is the advantage: pack two in the same stroke is an easy second download. Scattershot styles read as noise.

What done looks like

Done for the first 72 hours is not a payout. It is one marketplace account submitted, one coherent set of **8–12 files** live or in review, search-shaped titles, and a **90-minute weekly block** on the calendar with a name.

Done for the season is a first payout, however small. Twelve dollars proves the account and the pipeline. It does not prove a business. The habit does.

A set is done when

Every file shares line weight, corner radius, and palette. Two files side by side should look like one author.

Names are boring: icon-budget-wallet.svg, not FinalFINAL2.

SVG plus a PNG preview at the size they ask for, usually 1000px or 2000px.

Patterns tile. A 4-up test with no seam.

Nothing trademarked, no photoreal people you cannot license, no characters you do not own.

Review queues are not your pause button. The weekly block still happens.

Pricing and the cash window

On Adobe Stock and similar libraries you do not set the price. You earn a royalty per download. Volume, metadata, and a style that keeps getting picked are the job. On Creative Market, Etsy, Gumroad, and your own site, you set the number.

If you set the price

Small set, 8–12 icons or 4 patterns: **\$8–\$14**.

Working set, 20–40 icons or 8–12 patterns: **\$19–\$29**.

Mega pack that is truly one system, 80–120 files: **\$39–\$49**. Do not glue three unrelated dumps together.

A \$9 set a junior designer can expense without a meeting beats a \$79 ‘studio system’ with no proof. Bundles of three related packs at **\$29–\$39** outsell a lonely \$12 file if they belong together.

The honest cash window

Do not expect month-one rent. **30–90 days to a meaningful payout**. Meaningful at first is \$20–\$80. Weekly uploads and a kill window on dead sets: month four through six can look like \$150–

\$400 in a decent month. That is not a promise. That is what a coherent library tends to do when the keywords match jobs. A beautiful set named ‘My Art 3’ earns zero at every price.

The first 72 hours

The 72 hours is the account and the first set. Not a shop with forty listings.

Hours 1–3: pick the shelf

Pick **one** marketplace. Creative Market or Etsy if you want to set the price. Adobe Stock if you want search you do not have to find. Read the contributor license and the generative-AI rules end to end. Note whether raw output is forbidden, must be labeled, or must be redrawn. If you will not read the license, stop. You are about to upload a liability.

Hours 4–8: one style, ten variations

Choose a job. Write three style rules: stroke, grid, palette. Make **8–12 files**, not 80. If you use a model, generate extra, then redraw or vectorize the keepers. Export SVG plus PNG. Tile-test any pattern.

Day 2–3: titles, upload, calendar

Title like a search: ‘24 line icons for personal finance apps — wallet, budget, chart.’ Keywords are nouns the buyer types. Upload. Fill every field. Do not refresh the review page. Put a 90-minute weekly block on the same day. Name it ‘upload block.’ Start the sibling set in the same stroke. Then close the laptop.

One marketplace, license read

8–12 files, one style, three written rules

Search-shaped title and keywords

Weekly block on the calendar

The path, step by step

Step 1. One style. Ten variations. Write the three rules before you draw: line weight, grid, palette. Ten files that obey them beat thirty that wander.

Step 2. Name the job of the asset. Who is dropping this into what? A founder making a budget app. A baker mocking up a jam label. The job decides the content. Do not start with ‘things I like to generate.’

Step 3. Pick one marketplace and read the license. One. Four sites in month one means four profiles and zero compounding. Read AI clauses, exclusivity, and how they want files labeled.

Step 4. Make the file yours. Clean, vectorize, or redraw. No trademarks, no celebrity faces, no photoreal people you cannot license. Disclose AI when they ask.

Step 5. File hygiene. Same artboard. Same export. Names a stranger can sort. SVG plus PNG for icons; source tile plus JPEG or PNG for patterns. Zip it the way the listing promises.

Step 6. Keywords that match the job. 20–40 terms a buyer would type. ‘Budget app icon,’ not ‘aesthetic.’ Front-load the title with the job and the style.

Step 7. Upload a small coherent set. Eight to twelve files. Live is better than complete. Do not wait for a ‘real shop.’

Step 8. Weekly upload block. Ninety minutes, same day. Finish or start one set, export, title, upload. Sit the block even if last week is still in review.

Step 9. Read what already sells, then fill a gap. Sort by best-selling. Notice jobs that are thin in your style. Fill the gap. Do not trace the winner.

Step 10. Kill sets that do not move after a fair window. 60–90 days with views and no downloads is a signal. Unpublish. Double the theme that moved.

Step 11. Build a family, not a flea market. Pack 2 and pack 3 are siblings of pack 1. Buyers come back for the matching stroke.

Step 12. Review monthly, not hourly. One date a month: payout, top three, bottom three, next three jobs. Daily checking eats the upload block.

A worked example: Quinn's weekly icon set

Quinn is not a studio. Quinn has Figma, a Saturday morning, and three rules on a sticky: outline icons, 24px grid, 2px stroke, no fills except a 4px dot for 'on' states.

Week 1, Quinn picks Creative Market, reads the contributor terms including the generative-AI section, and does not dump raw output. A model helps list subjects (wallet, piggy bank, receipt, chart). Quinn draws ten icons on the grid. Title: '24px outline icons for personal finance apps — 10 files, SVG + PNG.' Price: \$12. Keywords from what already ranks: budget app, fintech, wallet icon, expense tracker UI.

Nothing sells in week 1. Quinn does not refresh earnings. Saturday week 2: ten more finance icons, listing updated to 20 files, still \$12. Week 3: a sibling set, e-commerce, same stroke, new listing, \$12.

Week 6: a \$14 payout. Two finance downloads, one e-commerce. Not rent. Proof the account and the files work. Week 8, one dashboard look: finance 140 views / 4 downloads; e-commerce 90 / 2; a 'cute 3D coins' experiment 200 views / 0. Quinn unpublishes the coins. The next four Saturdays double the outline family: wellness, calendar, small-clinic, and a 40-icon finance mega pack at \$29.

Month 4: eight coherent listings, one style. A buyer who grabbed finance comes back for the clinic pack because the stroke matches. Monthly payout \$190. Quinn still does not check the dashboard on weekdays.

What Quinn refused: trademarked bank logos, photoreal hands, four marketplaces at once, and skipping Saturday because 'nothing is selling yet.' The habit was the product until the library caught up.

Copy you can paste

Listing title

24px outline icons for personal finance apps — 20 SVG + PNG files, 2px stroke

12 seamless bakery patterns for packaging — 12-inch tile, 300 dpi, commercial use

Listing description

[Asset] for [job]. [N] files in one style: [stroke / grid / palette]. Formats: [SVG, PNG]. Commercial use for [what you allow]. Not included: custom colors, app files, or a font. Pair with [sibling pack] if you need the same stroke for [related job].

Keyword seed (finance)

budget app icon, fintech UI, outline wallet, expense tracker, savings goal, invoice icon, 24px line icon, bank card outline, SVG icons, transparent PNG

Post when a set goes live

I needed a wallet icon that did not look like a different app from the chart icon. So I drew a 20-file outline set on a 24px grid and put it on [marketplace]. \$12. Same stroke on every file.

Reply under a ‘where do you get icons’ thread

I got tired of mixing three packs in one screen. I make outline sets on one grid and upload weekly. Link in profile — finance, e-commerce, and clinic so far.

Week-by-week

Week 1. Account plus first set. License read. 8–12 files. Search title. Weekly block on the calendar. Do not build a landing page.

Week 2. Second tray, same style, same job or a sibling. Still do not check payouts more than once.

Week 3. Third set. The three style rules should feel boring. Boring is the point. One-line catalog promise: ‘Outline icons, 24px, 2px stroke.’

Week 4. First monthly review. If the account is still in review, do not panic-open a second marketplace. Produce into a local folder so week 5 is an upload.

Weeks 5–8. One block every week. At week 8, look at views and downloads. Unpublish the all-views-no-takes set. Double the one that moved: more files, a \$29 mega pack, or a matching pattern in the same palette.

Weeks 9–12. Stay in the family. Three more sibling jobs. If a payout landed, put the number in a note, not a ‘passive income’ thread. Every week after: same day, same 90 minutes. Seasonal variants of a set that already sells (tax-season finance in January). Do not skip the block three weeks in a row. Libraries rot in silence.

Quality bar

Hold two files at arm’s length. If a stranger would not guess they belong together, the set is not done. Coherence is the bar. Clean vectors are the floor.

Floor

Clean nodes. No stray points from a bad auto-trace. Strokes consistent.

One grid. A 24px set does not include a 22px rebel.

Patterns tile at 2x2 and 4x4, dark background and light.

Contrast works at 16px. If the wallet is a blob, simplify.

Exports match the listing. If you promised SVG + PNG, both are in the zip.

Rights

You can point to why you may sell this. No logos, no team marks, no ‘inspired by’ characters, no photoreal faces without a release. AI labeling is honest when they ask. A table mockup is nice. A cinematic shop film is not required. Time belongs in the files.

What to measure

Measure a library, not a feeling.

Sets live. If this is not rising most weeks, you have a hobby folder.

Views per set. Title and thumb are findable.

Downloads per set. The score that matters after 60–90 days.

Conversion. Downloads / views. 4% where 1% is common: double it. 0.1% with lots of views: kill it.

Earnings per 90-minute block. \$40 after four blocks vs \$0 — the math is done talking.

Payout events. First payout date, then monthly total. Not daily.

Family share. How many of your last six sets share the three style rules. Under 4, you are drifting into a flea market.

Fair window: **60–90 days** before you kill a set that had a real chance. Do not kill on day 9. Do not keep a dead theme for a year because you liked making it.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

‘The market is flooded with AI art.’ Flooded with dumps. Not flooded with coherent 24px outline sets for clinic software. You compete with files that match one job and one grid.

‘Stock does not pay.’ Single uploads do not. Libraries pay slowly. Need \$3,000 this month? Take a service path. Feed a catalog weekly and it is a second till.

‘They will reject AI work.’ Some will. Read the license in hour one and redraw. Label when they ask. Do not argue with a terms page.

‘I am not a designer.’ Then this path is only yours if you will learn a grid and a finish standard. Generating 80 images is not the skill. Making 12 files that look related is.

‘I should be on five marketplaces.’ After a payout on one. Not before. Five empty shops is five places to refresh.

‘Someone will steal the files.’ Watermark previews. Sell a clean zip a serious buyer wants. Theft is not why most accounts earn zero. Silence is.

What feeds this path

This path eats jobs, not mood boards.

Inside the marketplace. Best-sellers in your category. Search suggest. Gaps: demand with few coherent sets in a simple style. Seasonal calendar: tax, back-to-school, holidays, wedding.

Outside. App Store screenshots in a niche you know. Slide decks people present. Packaging on a shelf. The question is always: what file is missing from this person's project?

From your week. If you drew the same wallet icon three times for freelance, that is a set. If a client asked for 'simple food icons that are not clip art,' that is a listing title.

What does not feed it. Other people's generation showcases. Trend accounts that change aesthetic every Friday. Keep a note titled 'jobs I can draw on a Saturday.' Twelve jobs is a quarter of a catalog. Two moods and no jobs is a Pinterest account.

Mistakes

One upload and waiting. The catalog cannot compound on a single listing. Refreshing payouts instead of sitting the weekly block means you already quit.

Unlicensed copies and trademarked logos. Bank marks, teams, cartoon characters, celebrity likeness. This is how accounts get banned.

Raw unedited dumps. Warped type, broken hands, patterns that do not tile, five styles in one folder. Buyers refund. Platforms penalize.

Photoreal people you do not have rights to. Generated faces still carry risk. A simple graphic path does not need them.

Expecting a viral set to replace a business. One pack will not. A family of packs, uploaded weekly, might pay a bill.

New style every Saturday. You feel creative. The catalog feels random. Pick the three rules and get bored on purpose.

Keyword stuffing and poetic titles. Name the job, the style, the count, the format. Checking payouts daily is a hobby that eats the next tray.

Tools

One design tool you already open. Figma, Illustrator, Inkscape, or Affinity. If you only generate, add a vector tool this week. Buyers want files that scale.

One marketplace. Creative Market, Etsy, Adobe Stock, or the library whose license you read. Add a second after a payout.

The license, saved, highlighted. AI section, exclusivity, disclosure, prohibited content.

A keyword sheet. Listing, title, 20–40 keywords, date uploaded, date of last review.

Export presets. SVG and PNG at their preview size. A tile test board if you make patterns.

Optional: a vectorizer you control, a small mockup of an app screen or a jam jar, a calendar reminder named ‘upload block.’ Not optional: the license, and a finish standard you can say in one breath. You do not need a new computer to ship ten outline icons.

Checklist

Before you upload

Three style rules written and obeyed by every file.

8–12 files that share a job, not a vibe.

License and AI rules checked. No trademarks, no unlicensed people.

Vectors cleaned. Patterns tiled. Small-size test passed.

Names searchable. Zip matches the listing. Title has job, style, count, format. 20–40 keywords.

Every weekly block

Sit the 90 minutes even if last week is still in review.

Same style family unless you are killing a theme.

Upload or make real progress. Do not open the payout page.

Monthly

Count sets live and downloads. Kill after 60–90 days if it had a chance and did not move.

Double the winner. One number in a note: monthly payout. Then close it.

FAQ

How long until a payout?

Plan on 30–90 days after the first set is actually live. Review queues can eat two weeks. A first payout of \$8–\$20 is a working pipe, not a verdict on talent.

Can I use a model?

As a sketch tool if the marketplace allows it and the file still meets their rules. Many want disclosure. Some restrict raw output. Read this week's terms. Redraw so the grid, the nodes, and the rights are yours.

Which marketplace first?

The one whose buyer you can picture. Designers who pay \$12–\$29: Creative Market or Etsy. Huge search, tiny per-download pay: Adobe Stock. One shelf until a payout.

How many files in a first set?

8–12. Enough to look like a product. You can grow a listing later or ship a mega pack when two small sets have sold.

Do I need to be exclusive?

Not at the start. Exclusivity is a later trade: sometimes a higher royalty for not selling the same files elsewhere. Do not sign that away on day one.

What if my account is rejected?

Fix the reason they named. Produce into a local folder so you have something to upload when you are approved. Do not open four more accounts in a panic.

Is this passive income?

No. Delayed income. Work is front-loaded into weekly blocks. Sales can arrive on a Tuesday you spent elsewhere. Stop feeding the library and it fades.

Own site or marketplace?

Marketplace is the aisle. Own site is a good second home after strangers already buy. Do not build the aisle before you have a product.

What do I do with a set that will not sell?

After 60–90 days with views and no downloads, unpublish. If it had no views, rewrite title and thumb once before you kill it.

Can I mix icons, patterns, and photos?

Not at first. One asset type, one style, many jobs. Quinn's outline family is easier to grow than a shop that sells neon 3D, watercolor florals, and laptop photos.



PATH 14

A small AI membership

The vault must stay useful if they never attend a call.

17 minute read · 3,701 words

Who this is for

You can show up monthly with updated workflows after the one-time product has sold.

First sale

Three members who stay past month one.

Time to first

After you have buyers

Cash window

\$9-\$19/month

Tools

Leave this alone

Stripe subscriptions or Stan, a simple member page. A \$99/month room with nothing inside. Launching this before the one-time product has sold.

What this actually is

A small membership is a vault that stays useful if they never attend a call. That sentence is the whole design. Updates. New templates. A monthly workflow when the models change. Not your personality, unless you can keep that promise on a tired Thursday in February.

Members already bought the one-time file — the playbook, the prompt stack, the template pack — and the tools moved. A setting changed. A prompt that used to work got mushy. The membership is the living layer on top of a product that already earned trust.

This is a second product. It is not a way to avoid finishing the first one. A \$99 room with a Discord and a promise is a leak. A \$9 vault with three real files and a cancel button that works is a quiet till.

Cancel anytime. Earn the next month. Those two rules keep you honest. Live is optional garnish. The vault is the meal. Price sits in a band a person can keep without a meeting with themselves: **\$9–\$19 a month.**

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already have buyers of a one-time file and you can name, in one sentence, what those buyers still need after they finish the PDF. It fits if you already update your own workflows when the tools move, and writing that down would take a morning, not a new personality.

It also fits if you can stand a monthly rhythm: a dated note, a new file, a short list of what changed. If you vanish for eight weeks, you should already have decided how you refund the unused month.

Skip this if

Skip it if the one-time product has not sold. Skip it if you want a membership so you do not have to ship a finished file. Skip it if the only offer is 'community' and a chat that goes quiet at 4pm. Skip it if they must attend a call for the thing to be worth \$9. They will not attend. They will still want the file.

Skip the \$99 version until people already stay at \$9. High price does not create value. It creates refunds and a room you dread. If people already email 'did this still work after the model update,' you are holding the membership in your inbox.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this on a card: **\$9 a month for the updates the [book / stack / template] does not get.**

New workflow when the tools change. Cancel anytime. If you cannot say what the updates are, you do not have an offer.

What members get that the file does not

The dated workflow for this month's model behavior — what broke, what you changed, the prompt or SOP that replaces last quarter's version.

New templates or checklists that did not exist when they bought the file.

A short archive they can search on a Sunday, not a chat scroll.

Optional: a monthly office-hours slot if you can keep it when you are tired. If you cannot, do not list it.

What they do not get

Not a second brain on Slack. Not custom work inside the \$9. Not you hiding the one-time product so the only door is a subscription. The file stays for sale. People who only want the file should still be able to buy it and leave.

Checkout line: \$9/month for updates the book does not get. Three files in the vault on day one. Cancel anytime. If I vanish, you get the unused month back.

What done looks like

Done for launch is not a hundred members. Done is:

The one-time file has sold to real buyers.

You wrote what members get that the book does not.

Three items are in the vault before anyone is charged. Not ‘coming soon.’

Price is **\$9–\$19**. Checkout works. Cancel is one or two clicks, not a guilt form.

You invited existing buyers first, with a true sentence.

Done for the first season is **three members who stay past month one**. Ten people who cancel on day 28 means the vault was a teaser. Three people still there on day 45 means you earned the second month.

A month is done when the note went out: what changed in the tools, what file you added, where it lives. If you hosted a call, a recording or the written version is in the vault within 48 hours. If you did not host a call, the vault still got the file. The call was never the product.

Pricing and the cash window

\$9–\$19 a month. \$9 is the default. \$19 is for a vault that already has a back catalog — six months of workflows, not three PDFs and a smile.

A person who already paid \$19–\$47 for your file can keep \$9 without a story. \$29 starts to feel like another product they have to justify. \$99 is a different business: more support, more presence, more ways to fail them. Do not collect \$99 for a Discord you check twice a week.

Annual can wait. If you offer it, **10 months for the price of 12** is plenty — \$90 for the year at the \$9 level. Do not discount monthly to ‘fill seats.’ There are no seats. There is a vault.

Three members at \$9 is \$27 a month. That is a signal, not rent. Ten is \$90. Thirty is \$270, which starts to pay for the morning you spend on the note. The cash window opens **after you have buyers**. Charge on the same date. Send the update in the same week. If you cannot support more people, cap it. Scarcity should be your calendar, not a fake ‘3 spots left’ on a folder.

The first 72 hours

Do not spend 72 hours touring community platforms. Spend it on the vault and the sentence.

Hours 1–3: the gap list

Open the one-time file. List what it cannot do after a model change. List questions buyers already asked. Circle three items you can finish this week: a revised prompt, a new checklist, a one-page ‘what broke in [month]’ workflow. Those three are the vault.

Hours 4–8: the page and the price

One member page. What they get. What they do not. Price \$9. Cancel anytime. Refund the unused month if you vanish — write that down. Stripe or Stan. Buy it from a second email. Cancel it. If cancel takes a support ticket, you built a trap.

Day 2–3: files and invites

Name files like jobs: ‘2026-08-workflow-client-follow-up,’ not ‘Update!!’. A two-line index: file, date, job. Then write to people who already paid. Not a public launch. Ten invites beat a hundred strangers. The book stays as it is; this is the living layer; \$9; cancel anytime; here are the three files.

Gap list from the file and from real questions

\$9, working cancel, self-test

Three vault items with job-shaped names

Invites to existing buyers only

The path, step by step

Step 1. Sell the one-time file first. Membership is a second product for people who already trust you. If path 1 has not sold, go back.

Step 2. Write what members get that the book does not. Dated workflows, new templates, the monthly note. If the paragraph is about your energy or your ‘space,’ start again with files.

Step 3. Vault first, calls optional. Build the folder as if nobody will ever attend a Zoom. If you add a call later, the recap lands in the vault within two days.

Step 4. Three items in the vault before the door opens. Not a roadmap. Not a welcome video promising the roadmap. Three files they can use tonight.

Step 5. Price \$9–\$19 and make cancel easy. Test it yourself. Write the vanish/refund rule on the page so you are stuck with your own standard.

Step 6. Invite existing buyers first. Ten personal notes. Public launch only after three people have stayed, or at least paid without asking ‘wait, what is this.’

Step 7. A monthly note with two headings. What changed in the tools. What file you added. Date it. Under a page. Miss it twice and you are running a ghost charge.

Step 8. Answer in the vault, not in private exception. A good question becomes a file everyone gets. Custom work belongs in a paid project, not inside \$9.

Step 9. Cap when your calendar says so. If you cannot read the replies or you are slipping the note, close new signups. A fake counter is a trick. A real cap is a number you can host.

Step 10. Keep selling the one-time file. Do not hide it to milk the subscription. The file is how new members appear.

Step 11. Earn month two on purpose. At day 20, look at the vault as a member would. Is there a reason to stay besides inertia? If not, add the file now, not on day 31 after they cancel.

Step 12. Review stay-rate at day 45. Three members still there is a working path. A pile of day-7 cancels means the listing overpromised. Fix the files. Do not raise the price to make up for churn.

A worked example: Avery’s \$9 vault

Avery sold a \$27 playbook: a 10-day content system for one-person landscaping companies. Forty-ish buyers. Then the model started ignoring the ‘keep it local, no corporate voice’

constraint. Buyers emailed. Avery answered the same reply for free, forever.

The membership was not a community. One sentence: **\$9/month for updates the book does not get. Cancel anytime.** The vault opened with three items: (1) the revised prompt stack tested that week, (2) a one-page ‘what changed in the tools this month’ note, (3) a seasonal winter checklist the original file never had.

No Discord. No calls on the page. Avery knew February would be tired. Invites went to existing buyers only. Twelve notes. Five joined the first week. One canceled on day 6 because they wanted custom captions — Avery refunded, pointed them at a productized service, and did not chase. By day 45, three were still there. That matched the first-sale line.

On the first Tuesday of each month Avery spent two hours: rerun the core workflow on a real landscaping example, write what broke, drop a file named by month and job. The \$27 file stayed on the site. Members who never opened the email still had the file in the vault.

Month 4: six workflows, two extra checklists, fourteen members, about \$126 a month. Enough to pay for the morning and to stop giving updates away in a messy inbox. A member asked for a live critique. Avery said no inside the \$9 and offered a one-time package at the freelance rate. The vault stayed a vault.

What Avery refused: a \$99 ‘inner circle,’ a fake countdown, hiding the playbook, and a call schedule that would collapse the first week a job ran long.

Copy you can paste

Checkout line

\$9/month for updates the book does not get. Cancel anytime.

Invite to an existing buyer

You already have [file name]. The tools already moved. I am keeping a \$9 vault with the dated workflows the PDF cannot get. Three files are in there today, including [name the most useful

one]. Cancel anytime. If I disappear, I refund the unused month. The original file stays yours either way.

Public listing, only after buyers have joined

The [file] is a one-time buy. This membership is the update layer: monthly workflow when the models change, new templates, cancel anytime. Built for people who already use the file. \$9/month.

Monthly note

Subject: [Month] vault — what changed, what I added

What changed in the tools: [one paragraph, named model or setting].

What I added: [file name, job it does, where it sits].

What I am not doing this month: [a call / a new niche / custom reviews].

Good questions become next month's file. Custom work is a separate package.

Vanish policy, on the page

Cancel in two clicks from the billing portal. If I go quiet for 30 days without a note, email me and I refund the unused month. I will not hide the button.

Week-by-week

This path does not start in week 1 of your business. It starts **after the one-time file has sold**.

Week 0 (gate). Confirm you have buyers and a list of questions they already asked. If you do not, stop and go sell the file.

Week 1. Three vault items. Member page. \$9. Cancel tested. Invites to existing buyers only. No public thread. No Discord. No countdown.

Week 2. Point joins at the three files. If someone asks for custom, decline inside the membership and name the other path.

Week 3. First monthly note even if it has only been three weeks — pick a cadence (first Tuesday) and hit it. Add one file that came from a real question.

Week 4. Look at cancels. If everyone left, the vault was a teaser. Fix the files before you invite more. If three stayed, you have a path.

Weeks 5–8. Same Tuesday. Same two headings. Keep selling the one-time file. Mention the vault as a second product, not a replacement. Cap if replies turn into unpaid consulting.

Month 3. Count members, stay-rate past day 45, and whether the vault would still be useful if you never hosted a call. If yes, keep \$9. If you now have six-plus dated workflows, you may test \$19 for new members and grandfather the first ones.

Quality bar

The bar: **a member who never attends a call still got something they can run this month.** If that is false, you are charging for a room.

Floor

Three real files on day one, named by job and date.

A monthly note that names tools, not vibes. ‘The follow-up prompt started hedging; here is the blunt version’ beats ‘lots of exciting changes.’

Cancel works without a performance.

The one-time product remains for sale and remains true.

Support

\$9 buys files and a monthly note, not a private desk. Reply to questions that improve the vault. A 48-hour window on weekdays is enough. Custom deliverables get a no and a link to a package.

Calls, if you even have one

One optional session a month, same hour, recorded or written up. Miss it rather than ship a bad one. Never make attendance the only way to get the value. If you are tired, skip the call and write

the file.

What to measure

Invites sent to existing buyers. If this is zero, you launched to the void.

Join rate from those invites. Five from twelve notes is a warm file.

Members who stay past month one. Three is a working vault.

Day-45 stay-rate. Stayers divided by people who had a chance to be charged twice. Under 40% means the vault did not earn the second month.

Monthly note shipped on time. A binary. Missed notes predict churn.

Files added per month. One is enough. Zero is a ghost charge.

Custom requests inside the \$9. If they rise, your copy is fuzzy or you are too available.

Revenue after refunds. Do not screenshot gross joins.

Do not measure Discord online count or likes on the announcement. Measure whether they kept paying after they saw the folder.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

‘I should charge \$99 so people take it seriously.’ People take files seriously. They take a \$99 empty room as a mistake. Earn \$9 first. Raise when the archive is fat.

‘I need a community for this to work.’ You need a vault. Ten quiet downloaders beat a hundred lurkers in a dead chat. If you want a group, that is a different path.

‘Buyers will be mad updates were not in the original file.’ Tell the truth: the file is the job as of a date. The vault is the living layer. You sold a complete file and you are offering a continuation.

‘Nobody wants another subscription.’ True for bad ones. False for \$9 that saves them from re-solving a broken prompt every time a model shifts. Easy cancel respects the fatigue.

‘I will launch this to grow my audience.’ Backwards. The audience of buyers already exists. A membership with no file behind it is a chat room with a card on file.

‘What if I cannot keep it up?’ Then do not open it. Or open it with the vanish rule already on the page. A clean refund is better than a silent charge.

What feeds this path

The one-time file. New buyers are the only honest top of funnel. Mention the vault once after they have the file, not as a popup on page one.

Buyer questions. Inbox, checkout comments, ‘does this still work.’ Each repeated question is next month’s file. If nobody asks anything, you may need a clearer file, not a membership.

Tool changes. Model updates, UI moves, a setting that used to be default. Keep a running log. The monthly note writes itself from that log.

Your own weekly work. If you still run the system, the membership is the dated version of what you already had to fix. If you abandoned the job, the vault will rot.

What does not feed it. Cold ads to a \$9 vault. Affiliate blasts. ‘Join the movement’ threads. Other people’s mastermind screenshots.

Mistakes

Charging for a Discord that is dead. A quiet folder is a product. A quiet chat is a ghost town you billed.

Never updating. The charge continues. The vault does not. Set the monthly note on a calendar. If you skip, refund or extend. Do not hide.

Hiding the one-time product so you can milk a subscription. You starve the only source of members who already trust you.

Launching before the file has sold. You will pitch strangers a living layer on a book they never bought. No context, no trust.

Making calls the product. They will miss the call. You will miss the call. The vault should have been enough.

Fake scarcity. ‘12 spots’ on an infinite folder. People learn. Your calendar is the only honest cap.

Answering custom work inside \$9. You train members to treat the vault as a junior employee. Say no. Point to a package.

A guilt cancel. Two clicks. You earn the next month with files, not with friction.

Tools

Stripe subscriptions or Stan. One product, one price, one portal where they can cancel without emailing you a plea.

A simple member page. A logged-in folder, a locked Notion page, a Stan membership, a Circle space you actually update. The dumbest tool you will keep beats the pretty one you will abandon.

Dated file names. YYYY-MM-job. Searchable in six months.

Your existing email list of buyers. Not a new platform.

A calendar reminder for the monthly note. Same week, same two headings.

You do not need a mobile app, a points system, or a course platform. You do not need Zoom if you are not hosting. If you already sold the file on Gumroad or Stan, use their membership add-on if cancel stays easy. Moving people to a new login in week 1 is a way to lose them before they see the three files.

Checklist

Gate

One-time file has sold to people who are not you.

You can name what members get that the file does not.

You can keep a monthly note when you are tired.

Before anyone pays

Three vault items live, named by job and date.

Price \$9–\$19. Cancel tested from a second email.

Vanish/refund rule on the page. Calls optional. Vault useful either way.

Invite

Existing buyers first. Ten notes, not a public circus. File remains for sale.

Every month

Note: what changed, what file you added.

One new useful file, even if it is short.

Custom asks declined inside the \$9; general answers filed in the vault.

Cap if you cannot support more people. Day 45: count stayers. Three past month one is the first real sale of this path.

FAQ

Do I need a membership if my file is selling?

Only if buyers still need something after they finish it — usually because tools move or seasons change. Do not invent a subscription to look like a ‘real’ business.

Can I launch the membership and the file on the same day?

You can. You should not. You will split your finish energy and have no honest invite list. Sell the file. Answer the follow-up questions. Then open the vault.

What if I hate writing a monthly note?

Then do not open a membership. A quarterly bundle sold as a one-time update pack is allowed. Recurring billing is a promise.

Should I include a Discord?

Only if you will moderate it on a schedule and it is extra, not the product. Most \$9 vaults are better as a folder.

How do I handle a member who wants custom work?

Refund if they joined by mistake. Otherwise: no inside the membership, here is the package. Put the reusable part of their question in the vault.

What if the tools do not change that month?

Ship anyway. A seasonal file, a tighter SOP, a filled example you did not have in the book. Silence is the failure, not a quiet month in the industry.

Can I charge \$19 from day one?

If the vault already has a back catalog, yes. If it has three files, start at \$9. Grandfather early members when you raise.

What counts as vanishing?

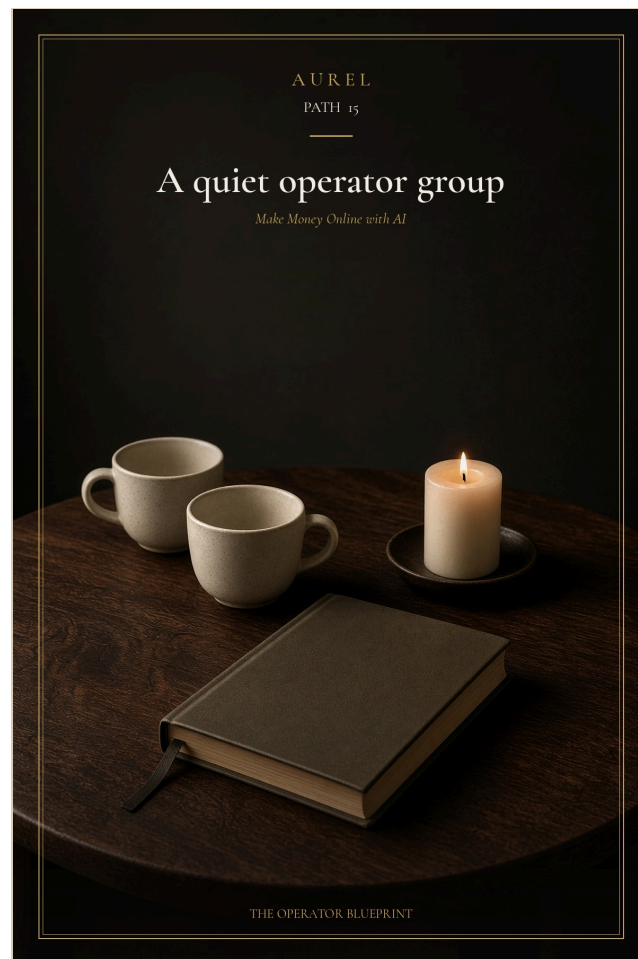
You skipped the monthly note and added no file, and 30 days passed. Charge still ran. Refund the unused month without making them write an essay.

How many members is too many at \$9?

When you cannot keep the note on time or you are doing custom work to keep people. For a folder-only vault, that number can be high. For a vault plus replies, it might be 30.

Do I remove people who never log in?

No. They paid for access, not for your feelings about engagement. They may log in the month something breaks. Measure stay-rate, not nag-rate.



PATH 15

A quiet operator group

Ten people who return next week beat a hundred lurkers.

18 minute read · 3,946 words

Who this is for

People already ask you how you work. You can host a small room without turning it into a second job.

Time to first

1–3 weeks

Tools

First sale

Ten people who come back.

Cash window

Application or a small fee; supports the product

Leave this alone

Circle, Skool, or a chat you actually moderate.

A free group that becomes your unpaid homework.

What this actually is

A quiet operator group is ten people who return next week. It is not a platform and it is not a stadium. It is a room with one rule — **useful or kind** — and one weekly thread with a real question, not a motivational poster.

The community supports the product. It is not the whole business on day one. People already buy your file or your package and they keep asking how you actually run the week. The group is where those questions sit in public so you stop rewriting the same paragraph in DMs. It is also where members show their work to each other, which you cannot fake with a broadcast.

Quality over size. If you cannot read the room, you built a leak. A hundred lurkers plus three people pitching Notion templates is a classified page you have to mop.

You host. You do not guru. Hosting means you post the thread on the same day, you answer the first replies like a person who read them, you remove noise, and you spotlight member work instead of your pitch. If the room dies the week you skip, it was never a community. It was a broadcast with extra steps.

Money here is secondary on purpose. An application or a small fee keeps tourists out. The fee supports the product. If you need this group to pay rent in week two, you will over-pitch, over-admit, and ruin the room.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if people already ask you how you work — not ‘how do I get started in AI,’ but ‘how did you run that weekly upload block’ or ‘what did you tell the client who wanted unlimited revisions.’ You have a point of view specific enough that ten operators would rather talk near it than sit in a giant free Slack.

It fits if you can host a small room without turning it into a second job. Same day each week. Thirty to sixty minutes of presence. A rule you will enforce. You do not need to be magnetic. You

need to be on time and unwilling to let spam sit.

Skip this if

Skip it if nobody asks you anything yet. Build the file or the package first. A group with no shared work is a book club that never read the book.

Skip it if you want a free group to ‘build community’ around a product you have not shipped. You will spend evenings answering homework for people who will never buy.

Skip it if you cannot remove a person. The first noisy member is a test. If you freeze, the room learns the rule was decoration. Skip a 500-person Skool with courses and a pitch on Tuesdays. That is a media company. This path is ten operators and a thread.

The offer, named in one sentence

Ten operators. One weekly thread. Useful or kind. Application or a small fee so tourists stay out.

What they get

A room small enough that a reply can be seen.

One weekly thread with a real operating question: what did you ship, where did it break, what are you running next week.

A host who reads. Not a content calendar of tips.

Spotlight on member work. Your product is in the bio, not in every post.

A rule that is enforced. Pitching belongs in a named thread, if at all.

The door

Application: three questions. What are you actually running? What did you ship in the last 30 days? Will you show up on [day]? A small fee: **\$9–\$19 a month** or a **\$29–\$49** annual desk fee. Either one is enough to make a person think once before joining.

If they cannot name a thing they shipped, they are not an operator yet. Point them at the public product. Do not admit them so the member count looks healthy. They do not get you on demand, a mastermind you cannot staff, or a promise that this group is a business model by itself.

What done looks like

Done for the first 72 hours: the rule is written, ten people are invited, the first weekly thread is a real question, and you answered the first replies like a host.

Done for the first sale of this path: **ten people who come back** the next week. Not ten signups. Ten humans who posted or at least showed up in the thread twice. A Skool with 80 silent members and one weekly broadcast from you is a newsletter with extra login friction.

A week is done when

The thread went up on the same day it always goes up.

Noise was removed the day it appeared.

At least one member's work got a spotlight that was not your funnel.

You did not pitch unless someone asked.

A healthy month is four threads, a stable ten to twenty people, and a room you can still read in twenty minutes. If you need a community manager in month one, you admitted too many people or you never wrote the rule.

Pricing and the cash window

This path's cash window is **application or a small fee; it supports the product**. The group is not the studio. The file, the package, or the vault is the studio. The group keeps operators close and keeps you from drowning in DMs.

Two honest doors

Application, \$0. Use this if your product already sells and you want a tight room. Free still needs a door. An open link is how you get tourists.

Small fee. \$9–\$19/month, or \$29–\$49 for a year. Enough to pay the Circle or Skool invoice and to make a person think once. Not enough that you start performing to justify a high-ticket container.

Do not charge \$199/month for ‘access to me’ in a group you check on Sundays. Do not sell \$2,000 masterminds with a slide deck. If you want high-touch, that is a service package with a name and a date.

Month one might be \$0 if you used applications, or \$90 if ten people paid \$9. Fine. Measure return visits, not MRR, until the room is real. If the fee starts to outrun the product, you will admit anyone who pays, and the operators will leave.

Time to first: **1–3 weeks** if people already ask how you work. You are inviting, not advertising. If you need ads to fill ten seats, you do not have a group.

The first 72 hours

Do not spend this window designing a logo. Write the rule. Invite ten. Post.

Hours 1–3: the rule and the door

Write one rule: **useful or kind**. Add the specifics you will enforce: no pitching in the weekly thread, no dumping raw AI text as ‘value,’ no dunking on other members’ work. Pick the door — three application questions or a \$9 checkout. Pick the tool you will moderate: Circle, Skool, or a chat you already live in.

Hours 4–8: the invite list

List twelve people who already ask you how you work. Buyers, peers, two people slightly ahead of you. Not ‘my whole list.’ Send the invite ten times, personally.

Day 2–3: the first thread, then host

A question you would ask a colleague: What did you ship in the last seven days, and where did it get stuck? Pin the rule. Do not post your product. Answer the first replies with follow-up questions, not advice dumps. Remove anything that breaks the rule the same day. Put next week's thread day on the calendar. Same day, forever, until you change it out loud.

Rule written

Ten invites, not a public blast

First thread is a real question

First replies answered like a host

The path, step by step

Step 1. Confirm people already ask. If your inbox has no 'how did you do X,' you are early. Ship the product. Collect the questions. Then host.

Step 2. Write the rule in the words you will reuse. Useful or kind. Pitching has a place or it has no place. You will remove noise. Put this at the door and in the pinned post.

Step 3. Application or a small fee so tourists stay out. Three questions or \$9. Say no to people who cannot name what they shipped in 30 days.

Step 4. Invite ten, not a hundred. Ten operators who return will teach you how to host. A hundred lurkers will teach you how to broadcast.

Step 5. Pick a tool you will actually moderate. Circle, Skool, or a chat. One space. If you need an app, a Twitter community, and a Discord, you are hiding from the thread.

Step 6. Same weekly rhythm. Same day. Same kind of question. People should guess when the thread appears.

Step 7. First thread is a real question, not a motivational poster. 'What did you ship, where did it break' beats 'Let's crush it this quarter.'

Step 8. Answer the first replies like a host, not a guru. Hosts ask a better next question. Your product link lives in the about page.

Step 9. Spotlight member work, not your pitch. Once a week, lift a specific thing a member did: a listing title, a package name, a kill decision.

Step 10. Remove noise the day it appears. One person dominating, a stealth pitch, a pile-on. Private note first if they might not know. Public removal if they knew.

Step 11. Keep the group in service of the product. When someone is a fit for the file, the about page is enough. Weekly webinars inside the group turn it into a course you will resent.

Step 12. Watch what happens when you skip a week. Skip once on purpose after the room has a rhythm. If it dies, it was a broadcast. If two members start the thread without you, you have a community. Then come back and keep hosting anyway — they still need a janitor and a clock.

A worked example: Cameron's ten operators

Cameron sells a \$19 prompt stack for solo bookkeepers and a \$600 package that turns a messy inbox into a week of follow-ups. People already DM the same three questions after they buy. Cameron is tired of typing the answers and does not want a free Facebook group that turns into homework.

Week 1, Cameron writes the rule on a sticky: useful or kind. No pitching in the weekly thread. Then a \$9/month Circle space — a desk fee, not a transformation. Application is three lines: what are you running, what did you ship last month, can you show up Tuesdays.

Cameron lists twelve people: eight buyers, two peers, two clients who productized their own work. Ten join. Two applications get a polite no — one has not shipped anything, one wants to recruit for a crypto thing. The no is the product as much as the yes.

Tuesday at 9am, the thread: 'What did you ship last week, and what did you refuse?' Four people reply the first day. Cameron answers each with one specific note and one question. Does not drop a coupon. A fifth person pastes a wall of unedited ChatGPT 'value.' Cameron deletes it, DMs them the rule, and lets them stay. They post like a human the next week.

Week 3, a member names a package on the thread instead of an hourly shrug. Cameron spotlights that, not a testimonial for the \$600 offer. A lurker emails in week 4: they used the

refuse question to turn down a bad job. That is a return.

Week 6, Cameron skips a Tuesday on purpose (a client deadline). Two members post the question anyway. The room did not die. Member count is eleven. Fee is \$9. Circle invoice is covered. The \$19 stack still sells to people who are not in the room. The group did not become the business. It stopped the DMs from being the business.

What Cameron refused: a free open link, a public launch thread, a leaderboard, daily prompts, and measuring success by ‘247 members.’

Copy you can paste

The invite

I am opening a small room for people already running this work — not a free-for-all, not a course. Ten operators. One weekly thread. Useful or kind. Application is three lines: what you are running, what you shipped in 30 days, and whether [day] works. [Fee if any]. If you are still shopping for a first product, the [file] is the better door.

The door questions

What are you actually running right now (file, service, catalog, job)?

What did you ship in the last 30 days? One sentence is enough.

Can you show up on [day] for a weekly thread, even if you only read?

Weekly thread starters

What did you ship last week, and where did it get stuck?

What did you refuse this week, and what did that protect?

Which number did you actually look at — downloads, stay-rate, invoices — and what did it change?

The rule, pinned

Useful or kind. No pitching in this thread. No raw model dumps as ‘value.’ No dunking. If you need to offer a paid thing, ask the host first or wait for the monthly classifieds post. Noise gets removed the same day.

The no

Thanks for writing. This room is for people already running a thing and shipping monthly. The better door for you right now is [the public file / the package]. If that changes, apply again with something you shipped.

Week-by-week

Week 1. Write the rule. Choose application or a small fee. Invite ten. Post the first thread the same day you said you would. Answer like a host. Remove noise.

Week 2. Same day. New real question. Spotlight one member’s work. Do not add channels. Do not add a second weekly event. Ten who come back is the only metric you write down.

Week 3. If you have empty chairs, send three more personal invites from the same kind of list. Do not open a public landing page with countdown numbers. A quiet no to a misfit is better than an eleventh tourist.

Week 4. Monthly classifieds post if people need a place to offer work — one post, not a culture of pitching. Review: can you still read the room in twenty minutes?

Weeks 5–8. Same rhythm. Skip one week on purpose only after the room has a pulse, and watch. If it dies, tighten the host habit; do not buy ads. If members start threads, thank them and keep the janitor job.

Weeks 9–12. Cap when you cannot read the room. Twenty is a lot if you are one person. Do not ‘scale community.’ Point extra people at the public product. The group supports that product. It does not have to contain everyone who ever paid you.

Quality bar

If you cannot read the room, you built a leak. That is the quality bar.

Floor

The weekly thread is on time.

The first replies get a human host, not an auto-thank-you.

The rule is enforced the same week it is broken.

Member work is visible more often than your pitch.

New people can see, in one pinned post, what this is and what it is not.

Conversation bar

Useful means a specific artifact or decision: a title, a refusal, a number, a scope line. Kind means you can disagree without a performance. ‘Have you tried ChatGPT?’ is neither.

Size and energy

Ten returning people is success. Eighty silent people is a metric you bought. Add seats only when the current ones still get seen. Thirty to sixty minutes on thread day. Ten minutes on two other days to remove noise. If it is more than that, you opened a second job. Close the extra channels.

What to measure

Returning humans next week. The first-sale number. Count people, not pageviews. Ten who come back beats eighty who signed up.

Thread posted on the promised day. Binary. Late threads train people to stop looking.

Replies that are artifacts or decisions, not vibes. You will know them when you see a package name, a kill, a listing title.

Noise removed same day. If this lags, the culture slides.

Time you spent hosting. If it climbs past two hours a week without a fee that justifies it, you are over-serving. Cap or simplify.

Product support, not product replacement. Are DMs down? Are file buyers still buying? If the group is busy and the product is quiet, you may have turned operators into an audience of free advice-seekers.

Skip-week test. Once a quarter. Broadcast vs community.

Do not measure member count as success. Do not measure online-now dots. Do not measure how many people hearted your announcement.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

‘I should keep it free so it grows.’ Free without a door becomes unpaid homework. Application or a small fee is how operators self-select. Return visits are the point, not growth.

‘Ten people is too small to matter.’ Ten people who ship and talk to each other will change their week. A hundred lurkers will not. You are hosting a table, not a network-effects startup.

‘I need daily engagement.’ You need a Thursday. Daily engagement is how you get spam, pitches, and a second job. Operators have work.

‘What if nobody replies?’ Wrong ten, or you posted a poster, or it is day one. Wait. Two personal nudges, not a guilt speech. If week 3 is still silence, ask one member what would make the thread useful. Do not fill the hole with your content calendar.

‘Someone will steal my ideas.’ Share how you run the week. Keep the paid files paid. People who steal prompts were never going to buy.

‘A bigger creator already has a community.’ You are not competing with their 8,000-person Skool. You are offering a table for ten people who do a specific job. That table can be yours at 40 members of audience, not 40,000.

What feeds this path

People who already ask how you work. Buyers, a few peers, the client who started productizing after they watched you. This is the only feed that matters in week 1.

The weekly thread itself. Good questions produce next week's questions. 'What did you refuse' will feed a month of scope talk.

The product. New buyers who are clearly operators can get an invite after they have used the file, not as a bonus checkbox at checkout for tourists.

Member work. Spotlights create a culture of bringing artifacts. Artifacts attract more operators. Pitches attract pitchers.

What does not feed it. 'Join my community' under every post. Facebook group imports. Affiliate swaps. A scraped list of 'entrepreneurs.' Those feeds fill rooms with people who collect rooms. If you have to go hunting among strangers who do not know your work, you are early. Go back to the file.

Mistakes

A free group that becomes your unpaid homework. Open link, no door, you answering beginner questions at 11pm. That is a badly priced service.

Free-for-all spam. Unmoderated threads become pitches, job ads, and AI-generated 'good mornings.' You own the mop.

Pitching every day. They joined a room of operators, not a webinar sequence. Your about page can hold a link.

Letting one person dominate. The loudest member becomes the culture. Private note. Then a limit. Then a removal if they cannot share air.

Measuring success by member count. Eighty silent accounts is a leak with a vanity number. Ten who return is the line.

Motivational posters as threads. Adults can smell it. Ask about work.

Adding channels to fix silence. Silence wants a better question, not more empty rooms.

Admitting people who have not shipped. They will treat operators as a free course. Say no at the door.

Making the group the whole business on day one. Then you have to over-admit and over-pitch to pay yourself. Let the product pay. Let the group support it.

Tools

Circle, Skool, or a chat you actually moderate. Pick the one you will open on thread day. A pretty ghost town is worse than a boring group chat that is alive.

A form or checkout as the door. A payment link with a note field, Stan, a three-question form. Read three answers or collect \$9 before they enter.

A calendar reminder for thread day. Same day, same hour.

A pinned post with the rule, the rhythm, and where the product lives.

You do not need a course module inside the community on day one. You do not need gamification. You need a lock on the door and a weekly question. If email is where your people already are, a single weekly thread among ten is allowed. A Circle you forget to open is worse. Choose the one you will host.

Checklist

Before you invite

People already ask how you work.

One rule written: useful or kind, plus what you will remove.

Door chosen: application (3 questions) or a small fee.

Tool chosen: one you will moderate.

First 72 hours

Ten personal invites, not a public blast.

First thread is a real question.

First replies hosted. Noise removed same day.

Next week's same-day reminder on the calendar.

Every week

Thread on time. Spotlight member work, not your pitch.

Read the room. If you cannot, stop admitting.

Every month

Count returning humans, not signups.

Classifieds (optional) in one post, not in every thread.

Cap when hosting exceeds a sustainable hour count.

Skip-week test once the room has a pulse: broadcast or community?

FAQ

How is this different from a membership vault?

The vault is files. The group is people. A vault should work if they never attend a call. A group only works if humans return. Do not charge \$9 for a dead chat and call it a vault.

Can the group be free?

Yes, with an application. Free with an open link is the unpaid-homework trap. If you go free, your 'no' at the door has to be stronger.

What should I charge if I charge?

\$9-\$19 a month, or a \$29-\$49 year, to support the product and keep tourists out. If you need more money, sell the package or the file.

How do I pick the ten?

People who already ask you operating questions and who have shipped something in 30 days. Mix of buyers and a couple of peers. Skip the person who only wants to network.

What if a member is kind but never useful?

Kind is allowed. If the chat starts to drown the thread, steer: 'Bring one artifact next week.'

Readers can stay in a room of ten. They cannot stay if there are a hundred of them.

Do I need video calls?

No. Calls turn a quiet group into a calendar product. If members ask, try a single optional hour a month and put notes in the thread.

When do I add more than ten?

When the original ten still get seen and you can still read the room. Add in fives. Cap when your hosting time jumps.

What if my product is the group?

Then you are running a different business. This path assumes the group supports a product that already exists. Day one, the group is not the whole business.

How do I handle pitches from members?

Pinned rule. First offense: private note. Second: remove the post. Third: remove the person. Monthly classifieds are a pressure valve if you want one.

How fast should I launch?

1–3 weeks from the moment you have ten names. Do not wait for a perfect platform. Wait for the rule, the door, and the first question.



PATH 16

Freelance, then productize

Charge the rate now. Build the product from the notes. Stop reinventing the job.

18 minute read · 3,934 words

Who this is for

You already do AI work for money and you are tired of quoting from scratch.

Time to first

You may already be here

Tools

First sale

A second similar job at a cleaner scope.

Cash window

Your current rate, then a package

Leave this alone

Whatever you already invoice with, plus a growing checklist. Random gigs forever. No notes.

What this actually is

You already do AI work for money. Someone asks what you charge. You shrug an hourly number, or you write a custom proposal that eats an evening, or you say yes to a job that does not look like the last one because variety feels like growth. This path is the decision to stop reinventing the job.

Take the last job you did well. Write the steps as a checklist the night you deliver. After three similar jobs, the package writes itself. That package is path 7 — a named service with a date and a price. The checklist is path 1 — a playbook a stranger can run without you.

Charge the rate now. Build the product from the notes. You do not pause income to ‘work on the business.’ You take similar work on purpose, you write it down, and you send a package name the next time someone asks what you charge.

Variety feels like growth. It is usually stalling. AI made it faster. That is what they are buying. Do not undercharge because the draft arrived in twelve minutes. Speed is the offer, not a reason to discount.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if invoices already exist. You have done AI-assisted work for other people — posts, listings, research briefs, internal SOPs — and you can open a folder of paid jobs. You are tired of quoting from scratch. You may already be here.

It fits if you can tell the truth about which jobs were similar. Same kind of input, same kind of output, roughly the same number of days. A realtor listing pack and a dentist listing pack can be similar. A realtor listing pack and a custom chatbot are not.

Skip this if

Skip it if you have never been paid. You cannot productize a fantasy. Skip it if you refuse to write notes. The notes are the whole conversion. Skip it if you want to stop service this month and ‘only sell digital products.’ The honest road is three similar jobs, a named package, then a cheaper file of the job without you in the middle.

If you already run a productized package, this path is still yours: raise when the waitlist appears, and spin the checklist into a file. You are on step 9.

The offer, named in one sentence

When they ask your rate, **name the package, not an hourly shrug.**

The sentence: **[Named result] in [N days] for [price]. You get [files]. One revision. You provide [inputs].** ‘I can help with AI’ is not an offer.

Offers that come from real invoices

12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. You get files, not a login to my brain.

8 listing descriptions plus a Google Business week in 5 days for \$450.

Inbox to 15 follow-up emails in 10 days for \$750, built in your voice.

You do not invent this on a branding retreat. You circle the similar invoices, write the shared steps, and name what you already delivered. The **service package** is you in the middle. The **product version** is the job without you, priced lower. Do not refuse paid work while you ‘wait to productize.’ Charge now. Notes tonight.

What done looks like

Done for the first 72 hours: last three invoices open, similar ones circled, shared steps written, package named, and that name sitting in a note you will paste the next time someone asks what you charge.

Done for the first sale of this path: **a second similar job at a cleaner scope.** Not a bigger job. A cleaner one. Same shape as the last, written scope, deposit, one revision, a date. If you still

said ‘sure, I can also do the chatbot and the brand voice and the ads,’ you smiled. You did not productize.

A job is done when the night-of-delivery notes exist in the same doc you always use: steps, prompts you reused, what they failed to provide, how long it actually took, what you will refuse next time.

A package is done when you can send it without opening a blank proposal. Name, deliverable, timeline, price, inputs, revision rule. One page. The product version is later: the checklist a stranger can run without you. This path’s finish line is the named package and the habit of notes.

Pricing and the cash window

The cash window is **your current rate, then a package**. You do not cut your rate to ‘make it productized.’ You stop pretending every job is unique.

If you already charge \$75/hour, and a job eats 8 hours including the smiling and the revisions, the package is not \$200 because AI drafted fast. The package is **\$600–\$900** with a date, or whatever math matches the last invoices plus a little for the cleaner scope. Speed is what they buy. You keep the surplus.

If you have been undercharging, do not leap to \$5,000 because a thread told you to. Average the last three similar invoices. Round up to a number you can say without coughing. That is v1. Raise when a waitlist appears — meaning someone has to wait a week or you are turning people away.

First packages in this suite’s service path often live at **\$300–\$1,500**. A 3-day listing pack can be \$400. A 10-day follow-up system can be \$900. A 14-day content-plus-page can be \$1,200. Write what is in and what is out so the number has a spine. Deposit before you open the chat. **50% to start**.

When the checklist is boring because you have run it three times, price the file at **\$19–\$47**. Cheaper than hiring you. That is the point. It does not replace the \$600 until you want it to.

The first 72 hours

You are not building a new brand. You are opening invoices.

Hours 1–3: circle

Open the last three invoices, or the last five if three is too thin. Circle the similar ones. Similar = same kind of input, same kind of output, same-ish days. If none are similar, circle the one you would be willing to do again, and treat the next yes as the second data point. Write the names of the jobs on a sticky: ‘listing packs,’ not ‘misc AI help.’

Hours 4–8: shared steps

From the circled jobs, write the shared steps in a single doc. Intake, inputs you needed, the AI draft pass, the edit pass, the delivery folder, the walkthrough, the revision window. Put the prompts you reused under the step where you used them. This doc is the company.

Day 2–3: name, one-pager, paste

Name the package like a result: ‘7-day listing pack.’ Write what’s in, what’s not, timeline, price (from the invoices, rounded up), what they must provide, one revision. Put the name in a note on your phone. The next time someone asks ‘what do you charge?’ you send the package, not an hourly shrug. If nobody is asking this week, send the one-pager to two past clients who already liked the work.

Last invoices open, similar ones circled

Shared steps in one doc

Package named, one page

Paste ready for the next ‘what do you charge?’

The path, step by step

Step 1. Open the last three invoices and circle the similar ones. If you cannot find similarity, you have been collecting gigs. The next yes should look like the best of those jobs, not a new species.

Step 2. Write the steps the night you deliver. Same day, while the mess is still in your head. Tomorrow you will only remember the win. The product lives in the missing inputs, the prompt that worked, the extra round they talked you into.

Step 3. Notes in the same doc after every job. One running file. Dated entries. Do not start a new Notion palace per client.

Step 4. Prompts you reused go in a stack. If you typed it twice, it belongs in a block you can paste. That stack becomes part of the package and, later, part of a file.

Step 5. Name the package. Result, days, price. Stop the hourly shrug. Practice saying it out loud once so you do not fold on a call.

Step 6. Write what's in, what's out, the date, the deposit. One revision is enough. Unlimited revisions is how packages die. They must provide voice, examples, and access on day one or the clock does not start.

Step 7. Send that name the next time someone asks what you charge. Even if the one-pager is ugly. A named package is cleaner than a charming email.

Step 8. Stop saying yes to work that does not teach the product. A flattering weird gig will pay once and steal the notes week. Refer it or decline.

Step 9. After three similar jobs, the package writes itself. You are not guessing scope. You have dates and hours. Tighten the one-pager. That package is path 7. The checklist is path 1.

Step 10. Raise the package price when the waitlist appears. Waitlist means delay or a no because you are full. Add 15–30%, keep the scope. Do not add more deliverables to justify the raise.

Step 11. Make the product version: the job without you in the middle. Price it lower. Let it sell while you sleep. Do this after the checklist is boring, not instead of the next paid job.

Step 12. Do not undercharge because AI made it fast. They bought speed and judgment. If a job that used to take a day now takes three hours, you did not become cheaper. You became a better package. Keep the price. Shrink the timeline if you want, on purpose, as part of the offer.

A worked example: Drew names the package

Drew has been ‘doing AI stuff’ for six months. Invoices: \$400 to rewrite a dentist’s Google posts, \$650 to draft listing copy for a realtor friend, \$300 to ‘just help with ChatGPT’ for a cousin’s bakery, \$800 for another realtor’s listings plus a landing page. Drew quotes from scratch every time.

Tuesday night, Drew circles the two realtor jobs and, after a pause, the dentist posts. Same shape: messy facts in, a week of public-facing copy out. The bakery cousin is not circled. Sticky note: ‘do not take cousin work.’

Shared steps go in one doc that night: intake, folder of inputs, draft pass, human edit, delivery in a Google doc they own, 15-minute walkthrough, one revision window of 5 days. Reused prompts get pasted under the draft step.

Wednesday, Drew names it: **8 listings and one page draft in 7 days for \$750**. Out: ads, chatbots, unlimited rounds. Deposit 50%. The one-pager is a Google doc. Ugly. Fine.

Thursday, an acquaintance asks what Drew would charge ‘to help with AI.’ Drew pastes the package name instead of ‘I usually do \$75 an hour.’ The acquaintance is not a realtor. Drew says this package is for listings and a page. Two hours saved.

The next realtor who asks, week 2, gets the same paste. They say yes. Deposit lands before the chat. Drew delivers in 6 days, writes the notes that night (they always forget parking details; add that to intake). That is the first sale of this path: **a second similar job at a cleaner scope**.

After the third listing-pack job, Drew raises to \$900 when a fourth has to wait a week. The checklist is boring enough to become a \$27 playbook. The file sells twice in a month while Drew is inside a paid week. The hourly shrug is gone. The cousin still wants ‘a little help.’ Drew sends the playbook link.

Copy you can paste

When they ask what you charge

I do not bill a pile of hours for this anymore. It is a named package: **[result] in [N] days for [price]**. You get [files], one revision, and a short walkthrough. You provide [inputs] on day one. Deposit holds the week. Here is the one-pager.

One-pager headline

[Result] in [N] days. You get files, not a login to my brain.

Scope block

In: [deliverables]. Out: [the usual extras — extra rounds, extra channels, strategy decks, sitting in their Slack]. Timeline: [start when inputs arrive, end on date]. Price: [amount]. Deposit: 50% before I open the work. Revisions: one round within 5 days of delivery.

Notes template, the night you deliver

Date. Client type. What they provided / what they skipped. Steps I actually ran. Prompts I reused. Hours start to finish. What I will refuse next time. One line I could sell as a file.

Decline that teaches the product

This sounds like a custom build, and I am not taking those. If you want [the named package], I have a seat in [week]. If you want to run it without me, the [playbook / stack] is [price] and it is the same steps.

Raise, when they wait

The package is [new price] starting [date]. Same scope. I am booking [N] weeks out. Deposit still holds the slot.

Week-by-week

This week. Circle similar invoices. Write the shared steps. Name the package. Put the paste on your phone. Do not rebuild your website.

Next job. Send the package name. Take a deposit. Run the job. Notes in the same doc the night you deliver. Prompts you reused go in the stack.

After two similar jobs. Tighten what's in and what's out. If you got burned by extra rounds, the one-revision line gets bolder, not politer.

After three similar jobs. The package is real. Stop custom proposals for this shape of work. Start saying no to work that does not teach it. Sketch the product version from the checklist — but do not disappear from paid weeks to design a cover.

When a waitlist appears. Raise 15–30%. Keep the scope. Do not celebrate by adding deliverables.

When the checklist is boring. Ship the cheaper file. Mention it after delivery and to people who cannot afford the package. Keep taking packages until you choose not to.

Every week you deliver anything. Notes that night. If you skip the notes, you skipped the path. The invoice is the job. The notes are the company.

Quality bar

They never see the raw model output. That is the floor. AI drafts. You edit. Quality is your name, not the model's.

Floor for a package job

Written scope before work. Deposit before chat.

Inputs listed. Clock starts when they arrive.

Human pass on every deliverable. Facts checked. Voice matches their examples, not 'an AI that heard of their industry.'

Delivery in a folder they own. A 15-minute walkthrough. One revision window with a date.

Notes the night you deliver, in the same doc.

Floor for the conversion

Similarity is real, not branded. You can say in one sentence what matches across the circled jobs.

The package name is a result plus a date plus a price. If it needs a paragraph of hedging, it is still a shrug.

You declined at least one job that would have felt like growth and would have taught nothing.

Cleaner scope means the second similar job has fewer side quests than the first. Fewer extra rounds. Fewer ‘while you’re in there.’ If the second job is bigger and fuzzier, you went the wrong direction.

What to measure

Similar jobs in a row. Two is the first-sale line. Three writes the package. Randomness is the enemy; count streaks.

Proposal time. Minutes from ‘what do you charge’ to a sent package. If this is still two hours, you do not have a package. You have a ritual.

Hours per package vs price. Know the number. Raise or tighten scope if the surplus disappears.

Revision count. More than one as a habit means your definition of done is soft or your intake is weak.

Notes completed the night of delivery. Binary. This is the leading indicator of a future file.

Nos to off-shape work. If this is zero, you are still collecting gigs.

Waitlist days. When people wait, raise. When they do not, do not panic-discount. Improve the ask list.

Product-version sales, later. Separate from package revenue. Do not kill a \$900 week because a \$27 file feels more ‘scalable’ on a slide.

Do not measure how many different industries you have touched. That is a stalling trophy.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

‘Every client is unique.’ Their business is unique. The job is not. Eight listings and a page is eight listings and a page. Unique belongs in their facts, not in your process.

‘I will productize after I quit clients.’ You will have no notes, no proof, and no cash. Charge now. Notes tonight. File later.

‘AI made it fast, so I should charge less.’ They are buying the speed. Keep the price. Offer a shorter timeline if you want the speed visible.

‘A package will make me miss interesting work.’ It will. That is the trade. Interesting work that never repeats is a class you pay for with your calendar. Take one on purpose once a quarter if you must.

‘I need a new website first.’ You need a one-pager and a paste.

‘What if they want hourly?’ You can say no. If a trusted client insists, cap the hours and still write the steps. Do not live there.

‘I only have one invoice.’ Circle that one. Aim the next yes at the same shape. The first sale is the second similar job.

What feeds this path

The last jobs. Invoices, emails, folders, Slack threads. Mine them before you invent a niche.

The night-of-delivery doc. Every entry feeds the one-pager and, later, the file. Skip a night and the feed dries up.

People who already paid you. They are the easiest second similar job. ‘If you need this again, it has a name now.’

The questions inside the job. ‘Can you also...’ is how you learn what to put in ‘what’s out.’ Intake gets sharper. The package gets kinder to you.

Prompts you reused. They are a stack waiting to happen. Do not leave them in chat history.

What does not feed it. Job boards that want a new species every time. ‘Happy to help with anything AI.’ Those feeds train the shrug. When a week has no freelance work, the feed is still the doc. Clean it. Send two past clients the one-pager. Do not fill the week with a random gig so you feel busy.

Mistakes

Random gigs forever. No notes. You will be as good at quoting from scratch in December as you were in March, only more tired. The notes are the path.

Custom work that never repeats. It feels like a portfolio. It is a stall. If it does not teach the package, it is a no.

Undercharging because AI ‘made it fast.’ Speed is the product. Keep the rate. Tighten the days if you want. Put the days on the package. Be done when you are done.

Working before the deposit. The ‘quick call’ becomes the job. Deposit first.

Unlimited revisions. Then there is no definition of done, and the checklist cannot be written because the job never ends.

Building the file instead of taking the second similar job. The file will be theoretical. Take the job. Write it down. Then productize.

A menu of 12 services. If you have twelve, you have none. One package. Not a cafeteria.

Tools

Whatever you already invoice with. Stripe, HoneyBook, an invoice PDF, Venmo with a paper trail. Do not switch billing tools this week.

A growing checklist in one doc. Google Doc, Notion, a notes app. One. Dated. Ugly.

A one-page agreement. Scope, date, price, deposit, one revision, what they provide. You can reuse this 20 times.

A deposit link. Same as the invoice tool. 50% before the chat.

The prompt stack you actually reused, sitting under the step where it belongs.

You do not need a new CRM to productize. You do not need a scheduler until people are actually booking. You do not need a course platform to turn the checklist into a \$27 file — a PDF and a payment link will do when the time comes. The bottleneck is not software. It is writing the steps the night you deliver and sending a name instead of a shrug.

Checklist

This week

Last three invoices open. Similar ones circled.

Shared steps in one doc.

Package named: result, days, price.

What's in / what's out / deposit / one revision.

Paste saved for 'what do you charge?'

Every job

Deposit before the chat. Clock starts when inputs arrive.

They never see raw model output.

Deliver in a folder they own. Walkthrough. One revision window.

Notes in the same doc the night you deliver.

Reused prompts copied into the stack.

After three similar jobs

Stop custom proposals for this shape.

No to work that does not teach the product.

Raise when people wait.

Outline the cheaper file from the boring checklist. Ship it without quitting the paid package.

FAQ

I only have messy one-off jobs. Can I still start?

Yes. Circle the one you would repeat. Make the next yes match it. The first sale of this path is the second similar job, not a perfect history.

What if I am not sure I want to keep doing service?

Keep doing it long enough to write the notes. Three similar jobs. Then the file can carry more of the weight. Quitting before the notes exist leaves you with neither cash nor a product.

How is this different from the productized service path?

That path assumes you can name the package this week and sell it. This path is for people already in the messy middle of freelance. You convert what you have. The destination — a named package — is the same room.

Should I put the package on a fancy page?

A one-pager is enough until strangers you do not know are buying. Past clients will read a Google doc. Do not stall on Webflow.

How many revisions is one?

One round of grouped notes inside a dated window, usually 5 days. Not a drip of ‘quick tweaks’ for a month. Put that in the one-pager.

What goes in the product version vs the package?

The product version is the steps, prompts, examples, and definition of done — the job without you. The package is you running those steps on their mess, with judgment and a date.

The client wants hourly and I am scared to lose them.

Name the package once. If they still want hourly, cap the hours and the extras, or let them go. A client who only exists when the scope is fog is not a client you can productize around.

When do I raise the price?

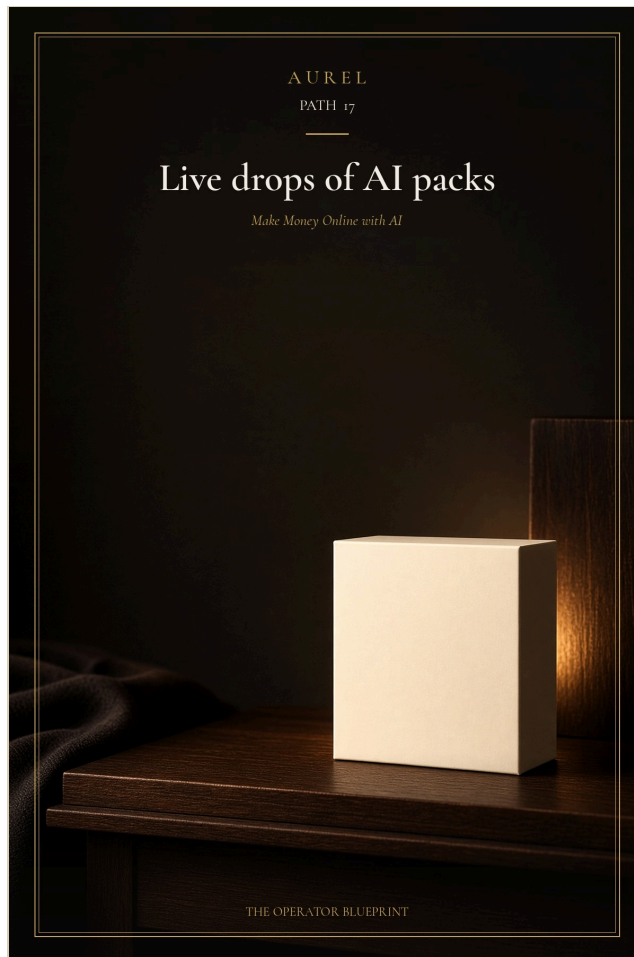
When someone waits, or when you are full, or when the notes show the job is heavier than the old invoices implied. Add 15–30%. Do not add three new deliverables so you feel polite.

Can I productize more than one job?

Later. One package until the paste is automatic and the notes are boring. A second package is how you end up quoting from scratch again.

AI did 80% of the draft. Is charging \$750 honest?

If you edited, checked facts, matched voice, owned the result, and saved them a week in the blank window, yes. You are not selling keystrokes. You are selling a dated result they can use. If you are shipping unedited model text, fix the quality bar before you worry about the number.



PATH 17

Live drops of AI packs

A time, a file, a link in the bio. Scarcity must be real.

19 minute read · 4,196 words

Who this is for

You have a finished pack and a time you can go live without freezing.

Time to first

Same day as the live if the file is ready

Tools

First sale

A live session that produces at least one checkout.

Cash window

Burst sales of the \$19–\$47 file

Leave this alone

TikTok Live, Instagram Live, Stan, a rehearsed first two minutes.

Fake countdown timers. Going live with nothing to sell.

What a live drop actually is

A live drop is a date, a file, and a checkout. You announce a time. You go live for about twenty minutes. You show the pack on screen. People buy while you are still talking. That is the whole machine.

It is not a webinar. It is not a masterclass. It is not an hour of origin story before a slide that says “link in bio.” You are not teaching a course. You are holding up a finished thing and letting people take it.

Why live still converts a file A \$29 pack on a quiet page asks the buyer to trust a stranger and a screenshot. A live drop lets them watch you open the file, click around, and answer one question out loud. Trust happens in public. That is why a plain pack can outsell a prettier one on a dead landing page — the live is the proof.

What scarcity is allowed to mean Scarcity is a date, a cohort, or a version. “I walk through this file Thursday at 7. After that you can still buy the pack on the page, but you miss the walkthrough.” That is honest. “Only three left” on a digital file you can copy forever is a lie. People who buy from you once will remember the lie.

A version is also real. “This is the April pack. The next rewrite ships in six weeks.” A cohort is real. “Twelve people get the live Q&A with this purchase. After twelve, the file is still for sale, the room is closed.” Pick one form of scarcity. Write it down. Keep it.

If the pack is not finished, you do not have a drop. You have a promise, and promises do not check out.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already have a finished pack from an earlier path: a playbook, a skill pack, a prompt stack, a template bundle. You can talk for twenty minutes without freezing. You have one platform where at least a few dozen people already watch or follow you. You do not need a huge audience. You need a time, a file, and the nerve to press Go Live.

You can do this if - You have sold the file quietly, or you could, and you want a burst instead of a drip. - You can demo the product with your screen, not just describe it. - You can keep a Thursday. If you cancel lives, this path will embarrass you.

Skip this path if Skip it if the pack is not done. Skip it if you cannot be on a screen share without your voice leaving. Skip it if you only have a fake countdown and no real date. Skip it if you have never tested the checkout from a second email.

If you need cash this week and the file is ready, this is one of the fastest paths in the suite. If the file is not ready, finish path 1, 2, 3, or 6 first. Then come back and drop it.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you pick a thumbnail: “Thursday 7pm I show the [named pack]. Twenty minutes. Link in bio. \$[price]. After the live the walkthrough is gone; the file stays on the page.”

That sentence is the offer. Everything else is decoration. If you cannot say it in one breath, you are stacking too many bonuses.

What sits in the sentence - A day and a clock time in the buyer’s timezone, or a timezone named out loud. - A file with a job in the title, not “my AI pack.” - A price they can hear once and remember: \$19, \$29, \$39, or \$47. - A reason to show up live that is not fake stock.

What does not sit in the sentence Do not add a 40-minute bonus training. Do not add a private podcast. Do not add “and I’ll also critique your

account.” The drop is the pack plus the twenty-minute show. If you want a higher ticket, that is a different path. Keep this one boring and buyable.

What done looks like

Done is a live that produces at least one checkout from someone who is not you. The replay or the static page is up within two hours of ending. The link still works the next morning. You wrote down what people asked, what they bought, and what confused them.

The live itself, done You started within two minutes of the announced time. You showed the file in the first three minutes. You said the price and the URL out loud at least four times. Twenty minutes, maybe twenty-five if questions are real. Then you leave.

After the live, done - Checkout still delivers the file. - A thank-you comment or story: “Pack is on the page. Walkthrough was tonight.” - Notes: three questions you got, one thing you fumbled, the next date or the decision that there is no next date yet.

If zero people bought, it is still a finished live if you showed the product and the link worked. You do not declare the path dead after one quiet Thursday. You also do not go live again tomorrow to chase the feeling.

Pricing

The cash window is a burst of the \$19–\$47 file. Live does not magically make a \$197 pack feel cheap. Live makes a small file feel urgent and clear.

The numbers that hold up - \$19 if the pack is thin and this is your first public drop. - \$29 if it is a complete job: prompts plus examples plus a one-page how-to. This is the default. Sage sells here. - \$39 if you

include a filled sample the buyer can copy. - \$47 if the pack already sold quietly and you are using the live as a version event, not a rescue.

Do not discount live. “Live special \$9” trains people to wait for you to panic. If you want a live-only extra, make it the walkthrough, not a cheaper file. The file price stays. The show expires.

You never run a fake “only 3 left at this price.” You never drop the price in minute eighteen because the room is small. Hold the number.

The first 72 hours

The first 72 hours assume the pack is already a file you can attach. If it is not, stop and finish the pack. Do not announce a live for a folder of notes.

Hour 1–4: freeze the product Export the final PDF or zip. Name the file like a human: “Realtor listing pack v1.pdf,” not “FINAL_final2.” Test-open it on your phone. Write the one-sentence offer. Pick the price. Confirm the Stripe or Stan checkout. Buy it yourself from a second email. If that fails, nothing else in this chapter matters.

Hour 5–8: the first two minutes on a card Write, on paper you can glance at: hello and how long you will be here; what the file does in one job-shaped sentence; share screen, open the first page, click two things; price and where the link is, said slowly.

Rehearse that out loud twice. Standing up. Do not memorize a speech for minute three through twenty. Human is allowed after the open. The open is not allowed to ramble.

Day 2: announce twice, not twelve Post the time once in the morning, once in the evening. Example: “Thursday 7pm. I show the file. Link in bio. Twenty minutes.” Put the checkout in the bio now. People who cannot attend still need a door.

Tell five people directly. “I’m walking through the listing pack Thursday at 7. Twenty minutes. \$29. If that’s useful, I’ll drop the link when I go live.” Direct beats a story sticker that expires while they are at dinner.

Day 3: the live and the landing Hour before: water, charger, Do Not Disturb, link copied, screen ready. Go live on time. Demo. Repeat the link. End. Within two hours: a static page or a pinned post. The live is the event. The page is the store.

Finished file, named like a human

Checkout test-bought from a second email

First two minutes on a card, rehearsed twice

Two public announcements, five direct asks

Live of twenty minutes, then a store page the same night

The path, step by step

Do these in order. Skipping the checkout test is how you host a room and then apologize.

Finish one pack. One file, one job, one price. Export, open on a phone, fix the page that looks broken at that size.

Set a start time you can keep. Thursday 7pm is a classic. If you work evenings, pick Saturday 10am. Write the timezone. Lock the hour on a calendar.

Build the checkout. Title matches the pack. Price is visible. File delivers. Test-buy. Watch the file arrive.

Write the first two minutes. Card, not a script deck. Include the screen share in minute two, not minute twelve.

Put the link in bio and in a note you can paste. If you fumble the URL on live, the moment dies. Have a short link written on paper.

Announce twice in public and five times in private. Forty-eight hours out, then two hours out. The two-hour reminder fills a small room.

Stage the desk. Charged device. A second device on the checkout. Notifications off except the platform you are on.

Go live on time. If three people are there, you still start. Waiting ten minutes for a crowd teaches the three that you do not respect the clock.

Demo, do not lecture. Open the file. Scroll. Fill one example live if you can do it in three minutes. Answer questions about the pack, not your life story.

Repeat the link and the price out loud every three minutes. Pin it. Say it like a person: “Link is in the bio, it’s \$29, it delivers as soon as you pay.”

Close on purpose. At minute twenty, recap what they get, where to buy, and that you are ending. Stay two minutes for last questions. Then leave.

Same night, stand up the store. Replay if you have one. Otherwise a static page: what the pack is, who it is for, price, buy button, “the live walkthrough was [date].” Write the three questions you got. Those become your next post.

A worked example: Sage on Thursday at 7

Sage finished a \$29 pack on Tuesday night. It is a listing-description stack for solo realtors: twenty-five prompts, three before-and-after listings, a one-page install. PDF plus a short text file. Not a course. A pack.

The date is the product Sage picks Thursday 7pm Eastern. Twenty minutes. Instagram Live, because that is where the realtor acquaintances already watch Stories. Stan checkout already works — Sage test-bought it last month when the pack sat on a quiet page and sold two copies. Those two copies prove the file delivers. The live is for the rest.

Scarcity is the date. Sage writes: “I walk through the listing pack Thursday at 7. After that, the pack stays \$29 on the page. The walkthrough does not.” No fake stock. No “only 5 left.” The version is v1. Sage will rewrite when realtors actually use it, not because a timer hit zero.

The card and the asks Tuesday, Sage writes the first two minutes on a yellow pad: “Hey — it’s Thursday, I’m here twenty minutes. This is the listing pack I

use when a new property hits the MLS and I have twelve minutes before the client wants copy. I'll share my screen, open the PDF, and run one address through the first prompt. Link is in the bio. \$29. It delivers immediately.”

Sage rehearses that twice in the kitchen. Wednesday: morning Story and evening feed post, same core sentence. Five DMs to agents Sage has actually helped. One person asks for the link now. Sage sends Stan. That buyer pays \$29 Wednesday night. The live is not the only door. It is the event.

Thursday 7pm Phone on a cheap tripod. Charger in. Do Not Disturb except Instagram. Stan open on a tablet. Bio already has the checkout. Pinned comment ready.

At 7:00 Sage goes live with eleven people. Not eleven thousand. Sage does not wait. The card gets through minute two. Screen share. A real listing Sage has permission to show, address blurred. First prompt. Ninety seconds of output. Sage reads two sentences, cuts the fluffy one, shows that edit. That is the demo.

Every three minutes: “Bio has the link. \$29. You get the PDF tonight.” Someone asks ChatGPT or Claude. Sage answers: both, the install page says how. Someone asks for a discount. Sage says no, nicely. At minute nineteen Sage recaps and ends.

Four checkouts during the live. One more overnight. Wednesday's early buyer makes six packs in two days. \$174. Sage puts a static post up at 7:40. Friday Sage does not go live again.

Sage refused a countdown sticker that said “3 left.” Sage refused to stay live until 8:15 because a friend was driving home. Sage refused a \$9 upsell on the fly. One file. A real date. Copy the shape, not the niche, unless you also write listings.

Copy you can actually send

Use these as they are. Swap the pack name, the price, the day. Do not add three paragraphs of your origin.

The announcement, public Thursday 7pm. I show the file. Link in bio. Twenty minutes.

Longer caption: Thursday 7pm Eastern. I walk through the [job] pack on my screen. Twenty minutes, then I leave. \$29, instant download. After the live the walkthrough is over; the pack stays on the page.

The two-hour reminder Going live at 7. Twenty minutes. I show the pack, not a slide deck. Link will be in the bio the whole time.

The DM I'm walking through the [job] pack Thursday at 7. Twenty minutes, \$29. If that's useful, I'll have the link in my bio when I go live. If not, no need to reply.

The pinned comment Pack is \$[price] — link in bio — delivers the file as soon as you pay. This walkthrough is tonight only.

After the live The walkthrough was tonight. The pack is still \$[price] on the page: [link]. Next live is not tomorrow. I'll date the next one when there is a new version worth showing.

What you do not post Do not post “ONLY 2 SPOTS.” Do not post a fake timer. Do not write a 600-word caption that hides the time.

Week-by-week if you have a job

You do not need a free month. You need three evenings and a Thursday you will not cancel.

Week 1 Day 1: finish the pack. Export. Phone-check. Checkout. Test-buy. Write the one-sentence offer and the two-minute card.

Day 2: announce in the morning and the evening. Five DMs. Bio link live.

Day 3: go live at the time you promised. Twenty minutes. Static page the same night.

Days 4–7: do not drop again. Answer buyer questions. Fix the one page of the PDF that two people could not find. Ship a quiet v1.1 if it is a real fix.

Week 2 One post that teaches a piece of the pack without giving the whole file away. Soft link to the store page. Count sales from the page versus the live. If the live carried it, date the next drop four to six weeks out, not next Thursday.

Week 3–4 Only schedule a second live if you have a new version, a new sample, or a new audience. Repeating the same twenty minutes every week trains people to ignore you. A drop is an event because it is rare.

The quality bar

The bar is simple. A tired person who joins at minute four can still tell what the file is, what it costs, and where to buy it.

Before you go live - The file opens. The first page states the job. - The checkout works on a phone. - You can demo without hunting through eight folders. - The first two minutes are rehearsed. The rest can be human.

During You show the product more than you show your face talking about the product. You answer product questions. You do not fake a crowd. You do not read comments for ten minutes while the screen is your wallpaper.

After Buyers get the file. If someone pays and the delivery fails, you fix it before you sleep. If you cancel dates as a habit, this path will cost you more trust than it makes. Keep the calendar or pick another path.

What to count

Count a few numbers. Do not build a dashboard.

The only numbers that matter on drop day - Peak concurrent viewers. For a first drop, 8–40 is a real room. Do not compare this to people with a million followers. - Checkouts during the live plus two hours after. That is the burst. - Checkouts the rest of the week from the static page. That tells you if you have a store or only an event. - Questions asked more than once. That is the next caption, or a fix in the file.

What to ignore Ignore likes on the announcement. Ignore whether a stranger from a Facebook group said they would come. Ignore your heart rate. Ignore a view count that includes people who stayed for four seconds.

After three drops Write down: average live checkouts, average page checkouts in the following seven days, and whether you kept the date. If you cannot keep dates, stop this path. If live checkouts are zero three times and the page also sells zero, the problem is the pack or the audience, not the lighting.

Objections you will hear — including your own

“Nobody will show up.” Maybe. You still go live at the time you announced if even one person is there. A cancelled live teaches your small audience that your times are decoration.

“I hate being on camera.” Share the screen. Pin the product. You can be a voice and a cursor. Rehearse the two minutes so you are not staring at your own face looking for a personality.

“Live selling is slimy.” Fake stock is slimy. A date and a demo are a shop hours sign. You are allowed to say the price out loud. You are not allowed to invent a shortage.

“I’ll go live when I have more followers.” Eight people who already trust you will buy more than eight hundred cold viewers. Get the pack right. Date the drop.

“Someone asked for a discount on the live.” Say the price again. Offer the static page if they need to think. Do not negotiate in public. If you made a real error in the file, refund, do not haggle.

“What if they buy and want a course?” You sold a pack. Point them to the page. A setup session is path 20, priced separately, not a surprise at minute sixteen.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Live drops are not a first path. They are an amplifier.

What must exist first You need a pack from path 1, 2, 3, 6, or 9. A live with nothing to sell is a talk show. Finish the file. Then drop it.

What the drop feeds - The static store. People who missed Thursday still need a button. - Your list, if you collect emails on the checkout. Do not build a 12-email sequence before you have a live that works. - Proof. A screen recording of you opening your own product is more useful than a designed ad.

What not to chain on night one Do not launch a membership from the live. Do not pitch an automation setup. Do not read a menu of twelve offers. One file. After the burst, you can point a buyer who asks for more toward a service path — in the DMs, not in minute twelve.

Mistakes that kill a drop

Lying about stock. Reading comments and never showing the product. Going live daily until nobody cares. Those three from the short version still kill it. Here is the rest.

Product mistakes Going live with a draft. Promising a zip you have not exported. Changing the price mid-live. Adding a second product because the room went quiet.

Performance mistakes Starting late. Waiting for “more people.” Lecturing for twelve minutes before the screen share. Fumbling the URL because it lived only in your head. Staying on until the last person leaves so the night feels like a hangout, not a shop.

Scarcity mistakes Fake countdown timers. “Only 3 left” on a PDF. “This price dies at midnight” when you will sell the same file at the same price on Saturday. Real dates only.

Cadence mistakes A live every day. A live that you cancel twice. A live with no store page afterward, so anyone who hears about it on Friday has nowhere to go. If you catch yourself designing a talking-head intro sequence instead of testing the checkout, you have already slipped. Come back to the file and the time.

Tools — only what you need

You need a place to go live, a place to get paid, and a card for the first two minutes.

Live TikTok Live or Instagram Live. Pick the one where your people already are. Do not dual-stream a first drop. One room, one comment thread, one bio link. YouTube Live is fine if that is your actual home. Zoom is a meeting, not a drop, unless you already sell into a private list and sent a calendar hold.

Checkout Stan, Stripe Payment Link, or Gumroad. One product. The link must be short enough to say out loud. Test on cellular, not only wifi.

Staging A charger. A second screen or a tablet for orders. A notes app with the URL and the price. Optional: a \$20 tripod so your demo is not a ceiling fan.

Do not add yet Do not add a webinar platform, a registration funnel, a wait-room video, or an on-air producer. Those are for people who already sell out rooms. You are dating a Thursday.

Checklist

Print this or copy it into a note. Check boxes in order.

Pack is exported and opens on a phone

Filename is human

One price, written: \$19, \$29, \$39, or \$47

Checkout test-bought from a second email; file arrived

One-sentence offer written

First two minutes on a card, rehearsed twice out loud

Day, clock time, and timezone on a calendar

Bio link live at least 24 hours before

Short URL pasted where you can pin it

Two public announcements: 48 hours out, 2 hours out

Five direct messages to people who already know the job

Device charged, Do Not Disturb on, second device on the order screen

Start on time even if the room is small

Screen share in the first three minutes

Price and link said every three minutes

End around minute twenty

Static page or pinned post up within two hours

Delivery issues fixed before you sleep

Three questions written down; no second live scheduled on adrenaline

FAQ

How long should I stay live? Twenty minutes. Twenty-five if questions are about the file. Not an hour.

What if only three people show up? You demo for three. You keep the date. You still put the store page up. Sage's first useful room was eleven. Yours can be smaller.

TikTok or Instagram? Whichever already has your people. If both are empty, this is not your first path. Build a pack and a small audience on one platform, then drop.

Do I have to show my face? No. Show the file. A stable screen and a clear voice beat a nervous talking head that never shares the product.

Can I use a fake timer if “everyone does it”? No. Scarcity is a date, a cohort, or a version. Fake stock on a digital file is how you teach buyers to ignore you.

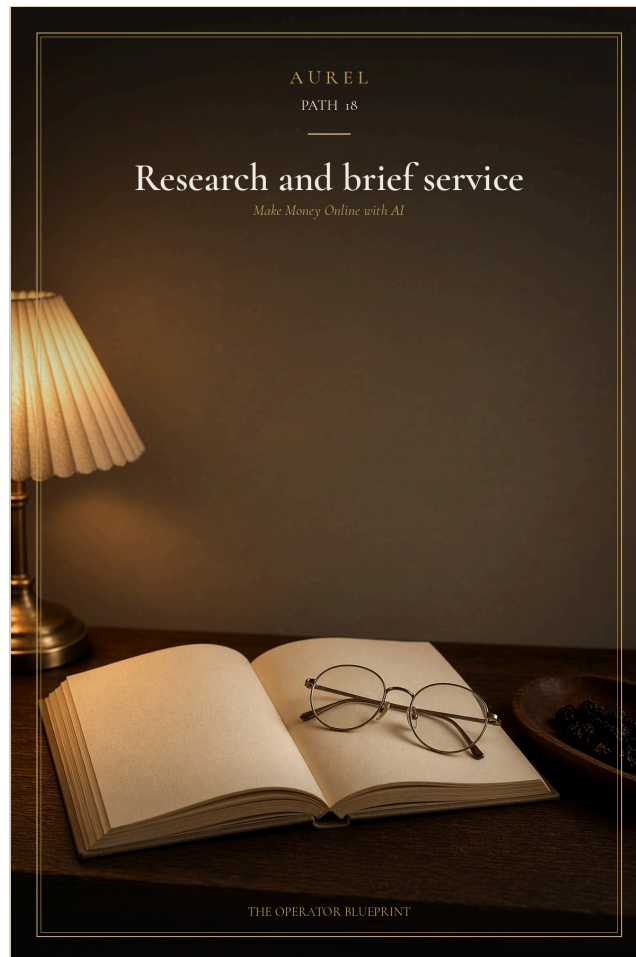
Should I go live every day to feed the algorithm? No. Date the next one when you have a reason: a new version, a new sample, a real cohort.

What if the checkout breaks during the live? Have the URL on paper. Have a backup payment link. If both fail, stop selling, take names, deliver by hand that night. Fix the pipe before you announce another Thursday.

Do I need a replay? Nice if the platform gives you one. Not required. The static page is required. The live is the event. The page is the store.

Can I drop a pack I did not finish because “the live will hold me accountable”? No. Finish the pack first. Accountability theater is how you go live with nothing to sell.

What should I charge if my pack already sells at \$19 on the page? Keep \$19, or use the live to introduce a \$29 version that actually added examples. Do not raise the price only because you turned a camera on.



PATH 18

Research and brief service

A messy question in. A two-page brief out. You verify what the model cannot know.

16 minute read · 3,546 words

Who this is for

You can turn a pile of tabs into a decision someone can use.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

One paid brief delivered on time.

Cash window

\$150–\$600 per brief

Leave this alone

Docs, a simple order form, sources you will and will not use.

Claiming ‘AI knows everything.’ Publishing unreviewed facts.

What this actually is

Anyone can paste a question into a model. What they get back is a confident first draft with a unknown number of invented citations. You sell something narrower: a 48-hour brief. Two pages. What you found, what you verified, what is still unknown, and a recommended next step. One revision included.

The product is judgment. The model is a junior researcher who works fast and lies when bored. You are the person who says which numbers can stand in a meeting.

What a brief is not It is not a white paper. It is not a twelve-page literature review. It is not “I’ll go deep on your whole market.” Executives do not read twelve pages. Operators do not need a seminar. They need a decision, on a date, with the holes labeled.

Why two pages Two pages forces you to choose. If a finding cannot earn a sentence, it does not belong. The “do not know” section is not a cop-out. It is the part that makes the rest believable. People who have been burned by a hallucinated source will pay for someone who will write “I could not verify this” in plain type.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if people already ask you “what should I do about X?” and you already open twenty tabs before you answer. You can tell a primary source from a blog that copied a blog. You can say “I do not know” without feeling like you failed.

You can do this if - You have a niche where you already know the landscape: a trade, a software category, a local market, a regulation you have had to live

with. - You can write two tight pages in a working day after the sweep. - You will check the citations. Not some of them. The ones you present as fact.

Skip this path if Skip it if you want to publish unreviewed model output under your name. Skip it if you freeze when a number cannot be confirmed. Skip it if you would rather build the whole project than recommend a next step. Scope creep into doing the work is how a \$300 brief becomes a \$3,000 job you forgot to price.

If you cannot yet name three people who already ask you for this kind of help, this is not your first path. Do a productized service or a playbook in a job you know, then offer briefs to the same people.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this on the order form: “48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$[price]. One revision included.”

That is the whole offer. If you cannot fit it on a sticky note, you are selling a retainer.

What is in - Intake: the decision they must make, the deadline, what they already tried. - A sweep with a model. - Your verification pass against sources you named in advance. - Two pages delivered in 48 hours from a complete intake, not from the first vague email. - One revision window of 48 hours after delivery. Revision means clarify or correct, not “now also write the strategy deck.”

What is out Building the thing. Sitting in their Slack. Monitoring a topic for a month. Interviews you did not quote in the scope. If they need those, that is a different package with a different number.

What done looks like

Done is a two-page file the buyer can forward without you on the call. It has a recommended next step that a human could take this week. It has a “do not know” section that is specific, not theatrical. Sources that are stated as fact have been opened by you. The clock was kept.

The page-one test Hand the brief to someone who does not know the buyer. In three minutes they should be able to say: the decision, the recommendation, the biggest uncertainty. If they cannot, you wrote an essay.

Delivery, done - PDF or Doc they own, in their inbox, inside 48 hours of a complete intake. - Filename with the topic and the date, not “brief_final_v3.” - One revision if they ask inside the window. Then the job is closed unless they buy another brief.

Pricing

The cash window is \$150–\$600 per brief. Robin sells at \$300. That is the number to copy until you have proof you are slow or uniquely sourced.

How to pick the number - \$150 if this is your first paid brief, the topic is one you already know, and you need a case. Discount once. Then lock the fee. - \$300 for a standard 48-hour, two-page, one-revision brief with named sources. Default. - \$450–\$600 if they need you to include a small set of primary documents they provide (filings, a competitor’s pricing page, a contract clause) and the decision is time-sensitive inside their week.

Do not charge hourly. A slow reader should not earn more than a fast one for the same two pages. Do not charge \$50. That price buys a paste, and they will treat it like one.

Rush and extras Rush under 24 hours: add 50 percent, and only if you actually have the hours. A second topic is a second brief, not a longer first one. A monthly “keep an eye on this” is a retainer you should not sell until five briefs have landed on time.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a website. You need a template, a fee, and three people who already ask you what to do.

Hour 1–4: the brief template Open a two-page Doc with locked headings:

Decision on the table

What I found

What I verified (with sources)

What I do not know

Recommended next step

One thing I would not do

Write a one-paragraph sources policy under the template: sites you will use, sites you will not, and the rule that an unchecked number is not a fact. If you will not use Reddit as a source, say so. If a trade journal is in, say so.

Hour 5–8: the order form Five fields only: name, email, the decision they must make, the deadline, what they already tried. Price on the form. \$300. Payment before you start the clock. 48 hours starts when intake is complete and the payment is in, whichever is later.

Day 2–3: three offers Send the sentence to three people who already lean on you. Not a cold list. “I turned the way I already help you into a 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. If you have a decision this month, I’ll take one.”

Deliver the first even if you discount it to \$150 to get a case. Deliver on time. Then lock the price. A late free brief teaches the wrong lesson.

The path, step by step

Do these in order. The clock is part of the product.

Write the two-page template and the sources policy. If you cannot name sources you refuse, you are not ready to charge for verification.

Put \$300 on a one-page offer. Intake fields, turnaround, one revision, what is out. Payment link above the fold.

Ask three people who already ask you “what should I do about X?” Offer one discounted first seat if you need a sample, then never discount without a reason you can say out loud.

On a yes: collect payment, then the intake. Do not start on a voice note. Incomplete intake does not start the 48 hours.

Sweep with a model. Prompt it for a map: claims, names, numbers, competing views. Dump that into a working doc you will not send.

Verify. Open the sources. Check the numbers. Kill anything you cannot confirm. Move the rest to “do not know” or cut it.

Write two pages in your voice. Short sentences. The recommendation sits near the top, not after a tour of the landscape.

Fill “do not know” with specifics: “I could not find 2025 market share from a primary filing. Vendor blogs claim 18 percent. Treat as unverified.”

Deliver inside 48 hours as a file they own. Restate the revision window in the email.

If they revise, you clarify or correct. You do not add a second question. If they want the second question, sell brief two.

After delivery, ask one thing: which sentence they used. That sentence becomes your next outbound line.

After three on-time briefs, raise from \$150 (if you discounted) to \$300, or from \$300 to \$450 if demand is real and your calendar is full. Do not raise because you feel fancy.

A worked example: Robin's \$300 brief

Robin helps independent clinic owners who keep asking whether they should buy a new scheduling tool. Robin is not a software vendor. Robin has sat through four of these decisions in

two years and is tired of rewriting the same email.

The offer Robin sent Wednesday morning, Robin messages three clinic owners: “48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. One revision. Clock starts when I have the decision, the deadline, and payment.”

One replies. Decision: stay on the current scheduler or move to Tool B before October 1, because two front-desk people just gave notice. They already tried a vendor demo and a Facebook group thread. They pay \$300 Thursday at 9:12am. Intake is complete at 9:40. Clock ends Saturday 9:40am.

How Robin actually works Thursday, Robin uses a model to sweep: feature lists, pricing pages, two complaint patterns, HIPAA claims. That dump is ugly and stays private. Then Robin opens sources. Pricing is confirmed on both vendor pages, screenshots dated. A “HIPAA compliant” badge on Tool B’s homepage is marketing copy; Robin cannot find a BAA sample without a sales call, so that goes in “do not know.” A Reddit thread claiming Tool B lost appointments for a 200-provider group is one anonymous post — not a fact. Cut.

Robin writes two pages, not seven. Page one: the decision, the recommendation (stay through October, run a 14-day parallel on Tool B with one provider, do not cut over during staffing loss), the three verified differences that matter for a two-person front desk. Page two: sources, the “do not know” block, one thing Robin would not do (sign an annual on a sales call this week).

The “do not know” section, copied - Cannot verify Tool B’s uptime for 2025 from a primary status page; vendor says “99.9 percent” on a marketing URL only. - Cannot confirm BAA language without a sales call. If HIPAA is the reason to switch, that call is the next step, not a cutover. - No independent review of Tool B’s SMS reminders in this state. Vendor blog only.

Saturday 8:10am, the PDF lands. Filename: “Scheduler-stay-or-move_brief_18Apr.pdf.” Revision window until Monday 8:10. The owner asks one clarifying question: what “parallel” means in

hours. Robin adds four sentences. Job closed. \$300. Time on the clock: about five hours of real work, two of them verification.

Robin does not offer to implement the parallel. That would be a project. Robin notes the case, locks the fee at \$300, and does not write a twelve-page version “to be thorough.”

Copy you can actually send

Use these. Swap the topic. Do not add a biography.

The outbound line 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300.

The DM or email You keep asking me what to do about [X]. I turned that into a fixed job: 48-hour brief, two pages, sources checked, a “do not know” section so we do not pretend. \$300, one revision. If you have a decision this month, I’ll take one.

The order-form headline A messy question in. A two-page brief out. Clock starts when intake and payment are both in.

The delivery email Attached: two-page brief on [decision]. I verified the items in section 3. Section 4 is what I still do not know — please do not treat those as facts. Recommended next step is on page one. One revision if you send it within 48 hours. After that, a new brief is a new order.

What you do not write “AI knows everything.” “Comprehensive report.” “I’ll keep looking until you are happy.” Those sentences are how you work for free and ship fiction.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1 Day 1: template plus sources policy plus \$300 form. Days 2–3: three offers. Day 4–7: deliver one on time, even if the first is \$150. Then lock the fee. Do not take a second brief until the first has landed.

Week 2 If the first buyer used a sentence, put that sentence in your next three asks. If they did not, ask what they needed that was missing — usually it is a clearer next step, not more pages. Ship that as a template change, not as unpaid extra work.

Week 3–4 Two more briefs at full price, or stop and pick a different path. Three on-time deliveries is enough proof. A monthly retainer is not the goal this month. Speed and a spine in the “do not know” section are the goal.

The quality bar

A brief is good when a skeptical reader can see the seam between verified and guessed.

Hard rules - If a number cannot be checked, it does not go in as fact. - If you will not use a source, say so in the policy, not after they complain. - Citations you did not open do not appear. Hallucinated citations are a firing offense you give yourself. - The recommendation is a verb plus an object plus a time: “Stay on Tool A through October 1. Run a 14-day parallel.” Not “consider exploring options.”

Length Two pages. A third page is a failure of editing unless they paid for a document dump they provided. Do not “add value” with appendices they will not read.

Voice Kitchen table. No hype. You may be wrong in the recommendation. You may not be fuzzy. Wrong and clear can be revised. Vague cannot.

What to count

Per brief - Hours from complete intake to send. Target: under 48, usually 4–8 hours of work inside that window. - Sources opened versus sources the model proposed. If you opened fewer than half, you are not verifying. - Whether they used the next step inside two weeks. A yes is a case. A no is a template problem or a bad-fit buyer.

After five briefs On-time rate. Aim for 5/5. One late brief is a process bug; three is you selling a clock you do not keep. Average fee. If you are still at \$150 after five, you are discounting as a personality trait. Revision count. If every job uses the revision to add a second question, your intake is soft. Tighten the form.

Ignore how clever the model sounded in the sweep. Nobody paid for that dump.

Objections you will hear — including your own

“Can’t they just ask ChatGPT?” They can. They will still have to check it. You are selling the check, the cut, and a next step they can defend in a meeting. If they want the paste, they should not hire you.

“Two pages feels thin for \$300.” Twelve pages they will not read is thinner. Price the decision, not the paper weight. Robin’s clinic owner forwarded one page-one paragraph to a partner. That is use.

“I might miss something.” You will. That is why “do not know” exists. Missing something and labeling it is professional. Missing something and stating it as fact is how this path dies.

“They want me to just hop on a call.” A call without a brief becomes the whole job, unpaid. Offer the brief. If they want a 20-minute walkthrough after delivery,

price it as \$75 or include once, in writing. Do not let the call replace the file.

“What if they want the whole project?” Say no, or sell a different package. A brief that turns into implementation without a new quote is how you train them to ignore your scope.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Briefs sit next to other operator paths. They are not a funnel slide.

What feeds a brief practice People who already ask you for judgment: clients from a productized service, readers of a newsletter, buyers of a playbook who now have a live decision. Cold traffic can work later. First sales come from three names you can text.

What a brief feeds - A productized service, if the next step is work they want you to do. New quote. New scope. - A playbook, if three briefs repeat the same structure. The template becomes a \$19–\$47 file. - Custom project setups, if the recommendation is “configure the tool,” not “I will configure it this afternoon for free.” - Trust for a later retainer you still should not sell in week one.

Do not use a brief as a bait-and-switch into a \$5,000 project they did not ask for. Recommend. Then wait to be asked.

Mistakes that kill this path

Hallucinated citations. Briefs that refuse to recommend. Scope creep into doing the whole project. Those three still kill it.

The rest - Starting the clock on a vague email. - Delivering twelve pages to look serious. - Leaving “do not know” empty because it felt like weakness. - Publishing the brief as a public post with the client’s numbers in it. - Claiming

the model “knows everything.” - A second revision, then a third, because you did not close the window. - Undercharging at \$49 so you feel like you can be sloppy.

If you catch yourself pasting a URL you did not open into a footnotes list, stop and delete the line. That is the whole ethic in one reflex.

Tools — only what you need

Writing and delivery Google Docs or Word. Export PDF. Their inbox. That is enough. Notion is optional and often slower.

Intake and pay A Tally or Google Form. Stripe Payment Link. \$300. You do not need a proposal tool for a two-page product.

Research The model you already pay for, used as a sweep. A browser. The actual source pages. A folder of dated screenshots for numbers that might move. A simple rule list of sources you will and will not use.

Do not add yet Do not buy a “research agent” stack, a scraping farm, or a CRM. Three clients do not need a pipeline. They need you to open the links.

Checklist

- Two-page template with the six headings, including “do not know”

- Sources policy written: in, out, unchecked numbers are not facts

- Offer sentence on one page: 48 hours, two pages, \$300, one revision

- Intake: decision, deadline, what they already tried

- Payment before the clock

- Clock starts only when intake is complete and payment is in

- Model for sweep, private dump, never sent

Every fact opened at the source

Recommendation is a verb, an object, and a time

Filename has topic and date

Delivered inside 48 hours

Revision window restated in the email

Second question = second brief

After delivery: one sentence they used, written down

First discount, if any, is once. Then the fee is locked

FAQ

Why 48 hours and not a week? A week becomes a research project. 48 hours forces a decision-sized file. If they need a week of interviews, that is not this product.

What if intake arrives at 6pm Friday? State your working days on the form. “48 hours on business days” is allowed if you write it before they pay. Do not surprise them with Monday math after a Friday charge unless the form said so.

Do I show my working? No. They get two pages. The sweep dump stays yours. Showing the raw model output trains them to skip you next time.

Can I use the brief as public content? Not with their numbers, names, or quotes, unless they said yes in writing. You may rewrite a generic version weeks later if nothing identifying remains.

What if I cannot verify the key number? Put it in “do not know.” Change the recommendation so it does not depend on a fake number. That section is why they trust you.

Is \$300 too high if I only spend four hours? No. They are buying the turnaround, the cut, and the nerve to recommend. If four hours feels guilty, look at the value of the decision, not your typing speed.

Should I offer unlimited email follow-up? No.
One revision. Then a new brief or a different path.

What if they want citations in academic form? Give enough to reopen the source: title, publisher, date, URL. You are not submitting a journal article. You are making a decision defensible.

Can I do this without a niche? You can try. You will be slower and worse. Start where you already know which sources lie.

When do I raise the price? After three on-time briefs at the current fee, if you are turning work away or the decisions are heavier. Not after one compliment.



PATH 19

Automation setups

A named setup that still runs a week later. Not 'I'll automate your company.'

15 minute read · 3,368 words

Who this is for

You can connect a model to email, a sheet, or a form without setting their building on fire.

Time to first

7–21 days

Tools

First sale

One paid setup that still runs a week later.

Cash window

\$400–\$2,500 named setups

Leave this alone

Make, Zapier, n8n, or native Claude/ChatGPT connectors.

Open-ended retainers with no named job.

What this actually is

You sell a named machine. Lead form to draft reply. Weekly report to Slack. Invoice reminder that waits for a human. The name is the product. “I’ll automate your company” is how you vanish into their operations and never send a second invoice.

A setup is done when it still runs a week later without you in the Slack. You hand off a one-page runbook. You support it for 14 days. Then it is theirs, or they buy a new named package.

Why the name matters “Form to draft reply with your approval” is a thing a tired owner can say yes to. “AI operations overhaul” is a thing they will ghost. If you cannot write the before and after on one line, you do not have an offer. You have a hobby with logins.

Trust is the actual product If the machine can send mail without a human check, put a check in anyway until they ask to remove it. You are selling trust. The first time an automated message goes to the wrong person, they will not remember your cleverness. They will remember that you had no off switch.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can connect a model to email, a sheet, or a form without setting their building on fire. You have built at least one of these for yourself. You can draw the flow on one page. You know what least privilege means, even if you learned it the embarrassing way.

You can do this if - You already use Make, Zapier, n8n, or a native Claude or ChatGPT connector for a real job, not a tutorial. - You can explain an off switch in two sentences. - You will write a runbook. People who hate documentation should pick a different path.

Skip this path if Skip it if you want an open-ended retainer with no named job. Skip it if you have never tested with fake data. Skip it if you need god-mode logins to feel useful. Skip it if the process has never been done manually — automating a fantasy workflow is how you spend three weeks debugging a job nobody actually does.

If you need cash this week, a brief or a productized service is faster. This path takes 7–21 days to a first paid setup because access, testing, and the runbook are the work.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you open Make: “Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750.”

Kai’s sentence is the default. Yours can swap the machine. Keep the shape.

What is in - One named flow, scoped to named tools, in writing. - A one-page diagram before you build. - Tests with fake data. - Human approval on anything that sends, posts, or charges, until they ask in writing to remove it. - A one-page runbook: how to pause, how to know it broke, who to ping during the 14 days. - Fourteen days of support after handoff. Then a new package if they want more.

What is out Rewiring their whole company. Unlimited extra zaps. Sitting in their inbox as a junior assistant. Keeping their passwords in your password manager forever. If they want a second machine, it is a second quote.

What done looks like

Done is a setup that still runs on day 8 without you poking it. The client can pause it without calling you. The runbook is in a folder they own. Your access is the least they needed, and you have a calendar reminder to remove yourself after the support window if they do not need you.

The day-8 test You do not log in “just to check.” They send you a screenshot or a sample output from the week. If it failed silently, the runbook failed. You fix that inside the 14 days as support, then you write the failure into the runbook so it does not stay tribal knowledge.

Handoff, done - Diagram, runbook, and tool logins they control. - Off switch labeled in the first paragraph of the runbook. - Support end date in writing. Not “I’m around.”

Pricing

The cash window is \$400–\$2,500 for named setups. Kai charges \$750 for form-to-draft-reply with approval, runbook, and 14-day support. Copy that until you have a reason not to.

How to pick the number - \$400–\$500 if the flow is one trigger, one model call, one destination, and you already built it for yourself. First paid job only. Then move up. - \$750 for the default: form or inbox in, draft out, human approval, runbook, 14 days. This is Kai. This is you unless the tools are uglier. - \$1,200–\$2,500 if there are three tools, a messy existing sheet, or a compliance reason you have to move slowly. Still one named machine. Not a department.

What you do not sell Hourly “I’ll hop in the workspace.” A retainer that says “automations as needed.” A \$99 special that cannot pay for the runbook. Support after day 14 is a new package at a written rate, or they own the risk. Do not leave yourself on the hook because it feels kind.

The first 72 hours

Do not hunt a client on day one. Demo on your own accounts first.

Hour 1–6: pick one setup Form to draft reply is the cleanest first machine. You already understand email. The approval step is obvious. Build it on

your own form, your own inbox, a dummy customer name like “Test River.” Record your screen for eight minutes: form submit, draft appears, you approve, mail would send. Stop the recording before you philosophize.

Hour 7–10: price and a one-pager Write the sentence. \$750. Tools named: for example “Typeform or Tally, Gmail or Outlook, Claude or ChatGPT, Make or Zapier.” One page: in, out, approval, runbook, 14 days, what is not included. Payment: 50 percent to start, 50 percent on handoff.

Day 2–3: two offers Send it to two people with messy inboxes. Not ten. Two who have complained in your hearing. “You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. I can demo on my accounts this week.”

If they want a different machine, you may swap the name only if you can demo that one too. Do not invent a custom empire because they sounded excited.

The path, step by step

Name the machine in one line. If it needs a paragraph, split it into two products and sell one.

Diagram on one page before you build. Trigger, tools, approval, destination, off switch. If you cannot draw the off switch, do not collect a deposit.

Scope the tools in writing. “Make plus Gmail plus Claude” is a scope. “Whatever we need” is how invoices die.

Take a deposit. Then request access. Least privilege: the form, the one inbox or label, the one sheet. Not their Google admin.

Build in a test environment. Fake names, fake emails you own, a dummy Slack channel. Never test by mailing their real customers.

Put a human check on anything that sends, posts, or charges. They can ask to remove it later, in writing, after they have seen a week of drafts.

Write the runbook: how to pause, how to know it broke, where the logs live, what “looks wrong” means in one example, who you are until day 14.

Walk them through it live, twenty minutes, not a lecture. They pause it once with you watching. If they cannot pause it, you are not done.

Handoff in a folder they own. Invoice the rest. Calendar the 14-day end date.

Support for 14 days is break-fix and small clarifications, not new features. A new branch in the flow is a new quote.

Day 8: they confirm it ran. Day 14: you ask if they want a second named setup. If not, remove extra access you no longer need.

Only then write an SOP for yourself so the second client is faster. Do not productize a setup you have never kept alive for a week.

A worked example: Kai's \$750 form-to-draft

Kai helps a three-person studio that takes project inquiries through a Tally form. The form currently emails everyone, and replies happen two days later, or not. The owner asked Kai to “put AI on our intake.” Kai refused that sentence and sold a named setup instead.

The one-pager Kai sent Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Tally to Gmail draft (not send) via Make. Claude writes the draft from a 12-line studio voice doc. You click Send. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. Half to start.

The owner pays \$375. Kai asks for: Tally editor access, a Gmail label “Leads-drafts,” and a shared Doc with three good replies they liked last year. Not the whole Google org. Not the client's personal inbox.

Build week Monday: diagram. One page. Form submit → Make → Claude (voice doc + form fields) → Gmail draft in the label → human sends. Off switch: a Make scenario toggle, circled in red, screenshot in the runbook.

Tuesday: fake data. Kai submits “River Test / never-use-this@kai.example” four times. First drafts are too long. Voice doc gets a line: “Six sentences max. No ‘excited to potentially explore.’” Third test is boring and correct. That is the goal.

Wednesday: walkthrough, twenty minutes. Owner pauses the scenario and unpauses it. Kai watches. Owner files a real inquiry from a friend’s form. Draft lands. Owner edits one sentence and sends. Kai invoices the remaining \$375.

The runbook, what it actually says How to pause: Make, scenario “Lead drafts,” toggle off. Screenshot. How to know it broke: no draft in the label within ten minutes of a test submit. How to test: a form password Kai set, used only for tests. Who to ping until [date 14 days out]. What Kai will not do after that date without a new package: add Slack, add a second language, wire it to the CRM.

Day 8 and day 14 Day 8 the owner forwards three drafts that went out. One was too stiff; Kai tightens the voice doc inside support, not as a new product. Day 14 Kai removes Tally access, leaves the owner as Make admin, and asks if they want invoice reminders as a second named setup at \$750. Owner says later. Kai does not stay in the workspace “in case.” The machine still runs. That is the sale.

Copy you can actually send

The one-liner Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support.

The ask You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval so nothing sends until you tap it. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. I can demo on my accounts this week.

The scope line, paste into the invoice In: one form, one draft destination, one model, human approval, one-page runbook, 14 days of break-fix. Out: extra tools, extra flows, sending without approval, retainers.

The runbook title How to pause [machine name].

How to know it broke. Support ends [date].

What you do not write “I’ll automate your ops.” “Unlimited zaps.”

“Set and forget forever.” “I just need admin access to everything.”

Those sentences are how this path becomes a second unpaid job.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1 Demo on your own accounts. Record it. Write the one-pager at \$750.

Offer it to two people with messy inboxes. Do not skip the off switch on your own demo. If you cannot pause your own scenario, you have nothing to sell.

Week 2 First paid setup. Diagram before you build. Fake data. Least privilege.

Runbook. Twenty-minute walkthrough. Calendar day 8 and day 14. Do not start a second client in the same week unless the first machine is already drafting.

Week 3 Support window. Break-fix only. Write down every

change you made; that list is either a runbook update

or a quote for setup two. Remove extra access at day 14.

Week 4 If the first machine still runs, you may offer a second

named setup to the same person or repeat the offer to two more. If

it does not run, you do not sell a second one. You fix your process.

The quality bar

The bar is a machine a non-technical owner can pause, and a week of drafts that did not embarrass them.

Before you call it shipped - Diagram exists and matches what you built. - Fake-data tests are saved. - Approval is on. - Runbook is one page, in their folder, with screenshots of the off switch. - They paused it once in front of you.

After Silent failure is a bug in your product, not a quirk of Zapier. If the flow can die without anyone noticing, add a simple alert: an email to them when a run errors, or a daily count in a sheet. Fancy observability is optional. “We would know by tomorrow” is not optional.

Do not ship a clever branch you cannot explain. Clever is how you get a 11pm text in week three.

What to count

Per setup - Did it run on day 8 without you? Yes or no. This is the first sale definition. - How many real drafts or actions in week one. Zero means the trigger is wrong or they stopped feeding the form. - Support touches in 14 days. More than five usually means the runbook is thin or you sold a process they do not actually run.

After three setups On-time handoff rate. Machines still running at day 30 — ask once, do not babysit. Average fee. If you are stuck at \$400 after three, you are discounting the runbook away.

Ignore how many modules the scenario uses. Clients do not buy module counts. They buy a named job that does not catch fire.

Objections you will hear — including your own

“Can’t they just turn on ChatGPT in the inbox?” They can turn on a lot of things. They hired you so it drafts in their voice, waits for approval, and can be paused. Native buttons without a runbook are how a junior sends a wrong quote at 6am.

“\$750 feels high for a zap.” They are not buying a zap. They are buying design, least privilege, tests, a runbook, and two weeks of you on the hook. A \$20/month tool with no owner is cheaper and worse.

“They want it to send automatically.” Not on day one. Run a week of approvals. If they still want send-without-check, get it in writing, add a holdout (never mail a list they did not just submit), and keep the off switch obvious.

“I need admin access to do it right.” You need the least access that makes the named machine work. Admin access is how you become the person who “also” resets everyone’s 2FA. Refuse god-mode.

“What if it breaks after day 14?” They have the runbook. They can pay for a new package. You may sell a \$150 check-in. You may not pretend you are on call forever because you feel responsible for software they own.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

What feeds a first automation job A productized service client who is drowning in a form. A local business you already wrote posts for. Yourself — the demo on your accounts is the sales asset. Cold “automation agency” ads are not how a kitchen-table operator gets job one.

What a living setup feeds - A second named machine for the same client, quoted separately. - A custom project setup (path 20) if they also need the model configured, not just the pipes. - Notes that become a playbook or a template for a narrower audience, later, after you have done it three times. - Definitely not an open retainer in week two.

Keep the machine named. The minute you become “our automation person,” you are on a salary they forget to pay.

Mistakes that kill this path

God-mode logins. No off switch. Automating a process that has never been done manually. Leaving secrets in a shared doc. Those still kill it.

The rest - Starting to build before the diagram and the deposit. - Testing on real customers. - Skipping the approval step to look advanced. - A runbook that is a 19-page novel. One page. Screenshots of the toggle. - Support that quietly becomes new features. - Staying in their workspace after day 14 “just in case.” - Quoting one price for “all the zaps they might want.”

If a password lives in a Google Doc titled “logins,” you have already failed the quality bar. Use a password manager they own, or sit with them while they type it.

Tools — only what you need

Pick one automation tool and get good at it. Make, Zapier, or n8n. Native Claude or ChatGPT connectors are enough for some jobs and better when the client already pays for them.

The rest of the stack A form (Tally, Typeform, native). An email box or Slack channel they already live in. A Doc for voice and the runbook. Loom or a phone recording for the walkthrough. Stripe for the deposit.

Access Least privilege. Shared folders they own. No personal Gmail of yours in the middle of their lead flow — if you leave, the machine should not.

Do not add yet Do not sell them a new CRM as a prerequisite. Do not rebuild their website to “capture leads properly” unless they paid for that as a different job. The named setup uses what they already click.

Checklist

Machine named in one line

One-page diagram includes the off switch

Tools listed in the quote

50 percent deposit before access

Least privilege, not admin

Fake data tests saved

Human approval on send/post/charge

Voice or rules doc they can edit

Runbook: pause, broken, logs, support end date

They pause it once in front of you

Handoff folder they own

Day 8 check: it still ran

Day 14: extra access removed

New features = new quote

No secrets in a shared Doc

FAQ

Make, Zapier, or n8n? Whichever you can demo this week on your own accounts. Do not learn a new tool on their dime. If they already pay for one, prefer that.

What if they do not have a form? Then the named setup is not form-to-draft. Sell a different named machine, or a smaller job to stand up a Tally form as part of the \$750 if you write it in the scope. Do not wander.

Do I include the Zapier bill in my fee? No. They pay their tool bills. You say that on the one-pager. Your \$750 is design, build, runbook, 14 days.

Can I keep access so I can “watch it”? Not after day 14 unless they buy a check-in package. Watching it is how you become unpaid ops.

What if the model writes a bad draft? That is why approval exists. Tighten the voice doc inside the 14 days. If they want a whole new tone for a second brand, that is a new quote.

Is \$750 too much for a first client who is a friend?
Charge \$500 once if you need a case, then \$750. Free is how friends get a machine you cannot afford to support.

Should I sell a monthly retainer? Not until several named setups have survived day 30. Even then, name the hours and the machines. “Retainer for automations” is the leave-this-alone line.

What if they want Slack, email, and the CRM in week one? That is three machines or a \$2,500 scope with a written diagram. Default to one flow. You can stack later.

How do I handle API keys? In their account. Not in yours. Not in a chat log. If a key leaked into a screenshot, rotate it before you go to bed.

When is the first sale “real”? When the setup still runs a week later. A demo on your laptop is not a first sale. Kai’s first sale was the studio’s drafts on day 8.



PATH 20

Custom project setups

They want Claude Projects or Custom GPTs configured, not a lecture.

14 minute read · 3,186 words

Who this is for

Someone drowning in a blank project who will pay for a working one.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

One setup a stranger can use without you.

Cash window

\$97–\$297 per setup

Leave this alone

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs, a 5-minute walkthrough recording.

Selling access to a model you do not own.

What they actually buy

They buy instructions, files, and three starter chats that already work. You intake their actual job. You install it in an account they own. You test it. You record a five-minute walkthrough. You leave. They never need your login.

You are not reselling Claude. You are not reselling ChatGPT. You are selling configuration. Say that out loud so nobody is confused, including you. If your business requires them to keep using a project inside your account, you have built a hostage, not a product.

What “configured” means A blank project is a blinking cursor with extra steps. A configured one knows the job, the tone, the files it may use, and the three first prompts that produce something they recognize. The buyer should be able to open it on Thursday night and get a usable draft without writing a system prompt from scratch.

What it is not It is not a course on prompt engineering. It is not a second brain with forty folders they will never open. It is not you wrapping someone else’s model in a thin login screen and charging rent. Anthropic and OpenAI already sell the model. You sell the setup.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you have already made a project or a custom GPT for yourself that you actually reuse. People around you have said some version of “I never know what to put in the custom instructions.” You can sit in someone else’s job for an hour without needing to become their employee.

You can do this if - You can write instructions a tired person can read, not a wall of role-play. - You will hand the project over. Your name does not need to stay in the admin field. - You can record five minutes on a screen without turning it into a webinar.

Skip this path if Skip it if you planned to sell access to a model you do not own. Skip it if you want to keep their files in your account so they “have to stay.” Skip it if you will load confidential client files into a model against their policy because it is easier. Skip it if you have never finished a project for your own job — do that first, then sell the shape.

If you freeze at the idea of asking five people, this still works, but the first 72 hours will feel like the whole job. That is normal. The page and the five asks are the path.

The offer, named in one sentence

“I configure the project for your job. You own it. Walkthrough included. \$197.”

Jules uses that sentence. Keep it. The number can move inside \$97–\$297. The ownership cannot.

What is in - A 20-minute intake: the jobs, the files they are allowed to add, the tone. - Custom instructions they can read and edit. - Up to a small set of files they provide and approve. - Three starter threads that already return a decent first draft. - A five-minute walkthrough recording. - One tweak window of seven days. Tweak means instructions and starters, not a second job.

What is out Your Claude login. A monthly “I host this for you.” Training their whole staff. Building a forty-file knowledge base they will not maintain. Connecting ten tools. If they want pipes into email, that is path 19, quoted separately.

What done looks like

Done is a setup a stranger can use without you. They open their own project. They click starter one. They get a draft they could send after a human edit. They know how to add a file and how to tweak a line of instructions because the walkthrough showed both.

The hand-off test Log out. Have them log in. Watch them run starter two without you typing. If they cannot, the walkthrough failed or the starters are cute instead of useful. Fix it inside the tweak window.

Ownership, done The project lives in their account. You are not the owner. If they want you as an invited viewer for seven days, fine. On day eight you leave. Files they consider confidential follow their policy, not your curiosity.

Pricing

The cash window is \$97–\$297 per setup. Jules charges \$197. That is the default button.

How to pick the number - \$97 if you need the first case and the job is one you could configure in an hour. Once. - \$197 for a standard job: intake, instructions, three starters, five-minute walkthrough, one tweak window. Copy Jules. - \$297 if they have several file types, a tone that is actually picky, or two related jobs in one project (for example “listing draft” and “email follow-up”) still inside one setup.

Do not charge \$20. That is a prompt, not a configuration. Do not charge \$1,000 unless you are also doing automations and a staff workshop, which is a different quote with a different name.

Hosting is not a price If they ask you to keep it in your account and “just give them access,” the answer is no. That is selling access to a model you do not own, plus a liability you cannot explain to a lawyer. Configure theirs. Leave.

The first 72 hours

Day 1: a sample for a job you know Build a sample project as if you were the client. Pick a job you have done: weekly posts, listing copy, invoice reminders, a study plan. Write instructions in plain language. Add one sample file you are allowed to use. Create three starter chats that already work. Record a five-minute walkthrough: open, pick a starter, add a file, change one instruction line. Do not record forty minutes.

Day 2: the \$197 button One page. Sentence at the top. What they get. What they must provide (job, tone samples, files they are allowed to upload). What they own. Stripe or Stan at \$197. Buy it yourself from a second email so you know the confirmation works even if the “product” is a scheduled setup, not a zip.

Days 3–5: five asks Ask five people who complained about custom instructions. Direct messages, not a launch. “I configure the project for your job. You own it. Walkthrough included. \$197. If you want one, I’ll send the intake.” Do not explain five other services. Hand off so they never need your login.

The path, step by step

Pick the platform they already pay for. Claude Project or Custom GPT, not both, not a new app you invented.

Intake: the jobs (one primary), the files they are allowed to add, the tone in three samples they like, and any policy about data. Write it down. If they cannot name a job, sell them a cheaper pack instead.

Create the project in their account, or create it in yours only as a draft and copy the text over while they watch. They click the buttons. They own it.

Write instructions they can read. Role, inputs, output shape, what to ask if information is missing, what never to invent. Short. They should be able to edit a line without breaking the rest.

Add only the files they approved. Do not scrape their Drive. Do not upload a client list they whispered about.

Build three starter threads that already work: the three jobs they will actually open this week. Name the threads in human language.

Test with a real example they provided. If the output is fluff, cut the instructions, do not add a fourth file.

Record a five-minute walkthrough: where it lives, how to run a starter, how to add a file, how to tweak one instruction, who owns it.

Hand off. Confirm they can run it without you. Start the seven-day tweak window in writing. One tweak, if they ask. Not a redesign. Not a second project.

Leave their account. Delete any copies of their files that landed on your machine.

After the first stranger uses it without you, write the intake as a form so job two is faster. Do not add a membership around a setup you have done once.

A worked example: Jules at \$197

Jules keeps hearing the same sentence from independent bookkeepers: “I opened a Claude Project and then I just... stared at it.” Jules is not selling bookkeeping. Jules is selling a configured project for client follow-up emails.

The sample, built on Monday Jules makes a project titled “Follow-up emails — sample.” Instructions: you write collection and scheduling emails for a solo bookkeeper; you never invent a balance; you ask for the amount if it is missing; tone is plain, no “just circling back” stacks; max eight sentences. One sample file: a fake aged-receivables list with made-up names. Three starters: (1) 14-day reminder, (2) 30-day firmer note, (3) scheduling next month’s close. Jules records five minutes. The \$197 button goes on a page Tuesday.

The five asks Jules messages five bookkeepers who already complained. Two ignore. One says “I don’t pay for Claude.” Jules does not argue. One wants Jules to “just write the emails each week.” That is a service,

path 7, different number. One says yes: Mara, two days a week in her own books, already pays for Claude, hates the blank project.

Intake, Wednesday, twenty minutes Jobs: follow-up on unpaid invoices, and a short “what I need from you for month-end” note. Files Mara is allowed to add: her template phrases, not her real client spreadsheet. Policy: no client names in the project until Mara pastes them per chat. Tone: Mara forwards three emails she was proud of. Jules writes instructions from those, not from a persona Jules invented.

Install, in Mara’s account Screen share. Mara creates the project. Jules dictates, Mara pastes. Three starter chats Jules types while Mara watches, then Mara re-runs starter one on a fake invoice. It asks for the amount because Jules left it out on purpose. That is the quality check. Walkthrough recording is the same five minutes Jules already had, plus a 40-second ending: “this is yours, I’m not in the account.”

Mara pays \$197. Tweak window through the next Wednesday. She asks to soften starter two. Jules changes three lines. Jules deletes the fake sample file from Jules’s machine. Mara owns the project. Jules does not keep a copy “for the portfolio” with Mara’s phrases in it.

Copy you can actually send

The line I configure the project for your job. You own it. Walkthrough included.

The DM You said you never know what to put in the custom instructions. I’ll set up the project in your account for [job], with three starter chats that already work, and a five-minute walkthrough. \$197. You own it. I don’t keep a login.

The page headline A working Claude Project (or Custom GPT) for one job. Not a lecture. Not my account.

The intake ask Send: the job, three examples of a tone you like, and any files you are allowed to upload. Do not send confidential files you would not want in the model.

After hand-off It's in your account. Starters are named. Walkthrough is here: [link]. You have seven days for one tweak on instructions or starters. After that, a new job is a new setup.

What you do not write “Access my GPT, \$19/month.”
 “I’ll host your brain.” “Upload everything you have.”
 Those are the leave-this-alone line and a policy problem.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1 Day 1: sample project for a job you know, plus the five-minute walkthrough. Day 2: page with a \$197 button. Days 3–5: five asks. Do not design a catalog of twelve industries. Hand off so they never need your login.

Week 2 Deliver the first paid setup. Keep the tweak window. Delete their files from your machine. Write the intake as a form. Do not start a “hosted GPT” idea because someone asked.

Week 3–4 Two more asks per week, or stop. If nobody buys, the job is too vague or you asked strangers who do not already pay for the model. Sell to people who already have the subscription. You are not also selling them Claude.

The quality bar

The bar is use-without-you. Pretty instructions that nobody runs are a brochure.

Instructions Readable. Editable. No 2,000-word role-play. A missing-info rule. A do-not-invent rule. Output shape in a few lines.

Starters Three, named for jobs, already producing a draft a human would edit, not a manifesto. If starter one needs a paragraph of extra prompting, you failed the configuration.

Files Only what they approved. Dated. Small. A second brain they will never open is a mistake, not a bonus.

Walkthrough Five minutes. If you need twelve, you built too much. Show ownership. Show the off-ramp: how they edit you out of the instructions later.

What to count

Per setup - Can they run a starter without you in the room? That is the first-sale definition. - Tweak requests that are actually a second job. Those mean intake was soft. - Time from intake to hand-off. Target: inside a week, often one sitting plus the recording.

After five setups How many still open the project two weeks later — ask once. If they never opened it, you overbuilt or you sold to someone who wanted a course. Average fee. If you are stuck at \$97 after five, press the \$197 button and live with fewer yeses.

Ignore how many knowledge files you uploaded. Volume is not quality. Jules's bookkeeper project used phrases, not a dump of five years of returns.

Objections you will hear — including your own

“They could watch a YouTube video.” They could. They have not. You are selling a configured job in their account in a week, not a lecture.

“Isn’t this just writing a prompt?” A prompt they have to paste every time is not a project. Instructions plus files plus three working threads is a small appliance. Price the appliance.

“They want it in my account so they don’t have to pay for Claude.” No. That is selling access to a model you do not own. They need their own subscription. You configure it. If they will not pay the model, they will not pay you fairly either.

“What about confidential files?” Follow their policy. When in doubt, do not upload. Paste per chat. Write that in the intake. Loading their client list into a project “to be helpful” is how you get a story you do not want.

“Can I productize one project and sell access to many buyers?” That is a skill pack (path 2), with generic files, not their confidential ones. Different product. Do not mix a custom setup with a shared GPT you rent out.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

What feeds a \$197 setup People who already pay for Claude or ChatGPT and stall on the blank project. Buyers of a skill pack who want it installed. Service clients who keep asking you to “just set up the GPT.” Your own sample and walkthrough.

What a setup feeds - Skill packs, if three clients needed the same shape. Generic version, no client files, sold as a file. - Automations, if they then want the project to draft from a form. New quote. Path 19. - A productized service, if they want you to run the job, not own the tool. - Not a hosted model business. That is the thing you leave alone.

Hand off. The best compliment is a week of silence because they are using it.

Mistakes that kill this path

Keeping the project in your account. Loading their confidential files into a model against their policy. Overbuilding a second brain they will never open. Those three still kill it.

The rest - Writing instructions they are afraid to edit. - Starters that only work if you are typing. - A 40-minute “training” instead of a five-minute walkthrough. - Selling access to Claude as if you were the vendor. - Bundling automations into the \$197 so you work a week for a setup price. - Keeping copies of their files “for examples.”

If you need their login after day eight, you did not hand off. Go back and finish.

Tools — only what you need

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs. One. The five-minute walkthrough: QuickTime, Loom, or your phone pointed at the screen, as long as they can hear you and see the clicks.

The rest A page with a \$197 button. An intake form: job, tone samples, files allowed, policy notes. Stripe or Stan. A calendar slot of 45 minutes if you do intake live, or an async form if they write clearly.

Do not add yet Do not build a native app. Do not resell API access. Do not stand up a team workspace they do not need. Configure the tool they already open.

Checklist

Sample project for a job you know, tested

Five-minute walkthrough recorded

\$197 button on a page, test-confirmed

Five asks to people who already pay for the model

Intake: job, tone, allowed files, data policy

Project created in their account

Instructions they can read and edit

Three named starter threads that already work

No confidential files they did not approve

They run a starter without you typing

Walkthrough delivered

Seven-day tweak window in writing

Your access removed

Their files deleted from your machine

You said out loud: you are not reselling the model

FAQ

Claude Project or Custom GPT? Whichever they already pay for and open. If they use both, pick the one for this job. Do not configure two for \$197.

What if they do not have a paid account? They need one. You do not sell them yours. Send the signup link. Schedule the setup after they can log in.

Can I do this over email only? Yes, if they write a clear intake. Live screen share is faster for hand-off. Jules uses twenty minutes live plus the recording.

How long should instructions be? Short enough they will edit them. Usually under a page. If you need four pages, you are writing a playbook (path 1) and calling it a project.

What goes in the three starters? The three jobs they will actually run this week. Not edge cases. Not “tell me about yourself.” Named, boring, useful.

Is \$197 too low? It is a setup, not a month of service. If they want weekly-run work, sell path 7. If the setup is truly two jobs and picky files, \$297.

What is the tweak window for? Instruction and starter fixes. Not “also build my content engine.” Write that down.

Can I show their project as a case study? Only with permission, and never with their files. Show your sample instead. Jules shows the fake receivables list.

Do I guarantee output quality forever? No. Models change. You guarantee a working configuration at hand-off and one tweak week. After that, they own the maintenance, or they buy another setup.

What if they ask me to stay as admin? No. Viewer for seven days if it helps them sleep. Then you leave. Ownership is the product.



PATH 21

Your front door

A useful diagnostic. Email required. The follow-up sells path 1. Strangers become a list.

15 minute read · 3,398 words

Who this is for

You finished any earlier path. You need people you have never met.

Time to first

Same week you publish the form

Tools

First sale

The first email from someone you have never met.

Cash window

Feeds every other path

Leave this alone

A form, a PDF scorecard, MailerLite or Beehiiv.

A ‘free’ file that is only a sales letter. Passing this book off as if you wrote it.

What the door actually is

A front door is a useful diagnostic. Seven questions. They get a score and one next step. You get an email. The free file is useful even if they never buy. That is the deal you keep.

You may brand your own scorecard. You may not copy this book and sell it as yours. Build your door. Point it at your playbook.

What it is not It is not a 14-page “free guide” that is a sales letter with a checklist slapped on page 13. It is not this suite with your name on the cover. It is not a 40-field form that feels like a job application. It is not a fake score that always says “you need my \$47 file.”

If they can tell, in two minutes, that the PDF only exists to sell, you built a flyer. Flyers do not earn replies from strangers. Diagnostics do.

Why email is required A stranger who takes a score and disappears was never going to buy this week. That is fine. The door still has to be fair: they get the file instantly. You get a way to teach for a few notes, then ask. No hostage PDF. No “we’ll send it someday.” Instant, then a sequence that earns the ask.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you finished any earlier path. You have something to point at — usually path 1, a playbook — and you need people you have never met. Friends and DMs got you the first sales. The door is how strangers join that line without you hunting each one.

You can do this if - You can write seven questions that change the advice. If every answer leads to “buy my file,” the questions are fake.

- You can write a two-page PDF that still helps if they never pay you. - You will set up a 5–7 note sequence before you buy a single ad.

Skip this path if Skip it if you have nothing to sell yet. A door into an empty house is a hobby. Skip it if you planned to republish this suite as your lead magnet. Skip it if you will not include an unsubscribe. Skip it if you want a list more than you want to be useful — that motive leaks onto page one.

If you still cannot name the paid next step, go back to path 1 and finish the playbook. Then build the door that points at it.

The offer, named in one sentence

“Seven questions. A score. One next step. Free even if you never buy.”

That is the public offer. The private truth: the sequence teaches, then sells path 1. Both can be true if the PDF is real.

What they get - Seven questions, scored honestly. - A PDF that explains the score in plain language and gives one next step they can do this week without paying you. - Instant delivery. The file is in the thank-you email or the next screen, not in a queue you will “get to.”

What you get An email, permission to send a short sequence, and a score you may use to pick which next step to recommend. You do not get a right to spam daily. You do not get a right to sell them twelve things in note one.

What done looks like

Done is the first email from someone you have never met, sitting in a tool you control, with a score attached, and a PDF they already received. The sequence exists. Unsubscribe works. The paid playbook is linked in a later note, not in the first paragraph of the free file.

The fairness test Give the PDF to a friend and tell them not to buy anything. If they can still take one useful action this week, the door is honest. If they cannot, you wrote a sales letter and called it a scorecard. Rewrite until the friend has a next step that does not require a card.

Technical done Form live. PDF attached or linked immediately. Confirmation they expect. Sequence of 5–7 notes drafted, not “I’ll write them when people join.”

Pricing — the door is free, the house is not

The cash window is not a price on the PDF. The door feeds every other path. You do not charge for the seven questions.

Where money shows up - Path 1 playbook, usually \$19–\$47, asked for in note 5, 6, or 7 after you have taught. - Later: a service, a setup, a drop. Not in the first email.

What you never charge for here Do not charge \$9 for the scorecard and also call it free. Do not put the diagnostic behind a “tripwire” that is just the same sales letter. Free means free. Useful means useful without a receipt.

If someone asks to pay you for a live walkthrough of their results, that is a \$97–\$197 setup or a brief, sold as itself, after they already have the PDF. Do not hide that inside the magnet.

The first 72 hours

Day 1: questions plus PDF Write seven questions that change the advice. Not flattery. Each answer should send them toward a different next step: a playbook, a skill pack, “do not buy anything yet, finish one job,” or “talk to a person, not a file.” Build a two-to-four page PDF: how scoring

works, what each band means, one action per band that does not require paying you. Put your email in the footer as a human, not as a funnel.

Day 2: form live MailerLite, Beehiiv, or Tally into either. Fields: first name optional, email required, the seven questions. Thank-you page includes the PDF now. Test as a stranger from a second email. Confirm the file arrives. Confirm unsubscribe is one click.

Put the form above the paid button on your page. The door is the first thing a stranger sees. The playbook is the second.

Day 3: share once Share it once in a place you already help people. One post, one comment, one email to people who already know you. Do not buy ads. Do not spray five platforms. Watch whether anyone finishes the seven questions. If they abandon at question two, the questions are too cute or too many.

The path, step by step

Name the paid thing the door will eventually sell. Usually path 1. Write that on a sticky note so the sequence does not wander into a buffet.

Write seven questions that diagnose, not flatter. If two answers never change the PDF, delete one question and merge them.

Write a scoring key you could defend to a skeptical friend. Bands, not fake precision. “12–18: you need a pack, not a tool binge.”

Write the PDF so the free next step is real. Example: “Run one recurring job in a saved project this week. Do not buy a second subscription.”

Build the form. Email required. Instant file. No 40 fields. No “company size, budget, phone, mailing address.”

Hook the form to MailerLite or Beehiiv. Tag the score band if you can do it without a science project. If you cannot, send one sequence to everyone and mention bands in the PDF only.

Write 5–7 notes before anyone joins. Teach, then ask. Note 1 is the file and what to read. Notes 2–4 teach. Notes 5–6 ask for the playbook. Note 7 is a quiet close or a single service mention if that is truly the better fit.

Test-buy the path 1 checkout from a second email. The sequence must not point at a dead button.

Put the form above the paid button. Share once where you already help.

Reply to the first stranger like a person. One sentence. Not a six-link kit.

After ten subscribers, read where they drop. Fix questions, not your branding.

Only then consider a small ad budget. Sequence first. Ads on an empty sequence buy you unsubscribes you paid for.

A worked example: Noor's 7-question door

Noor finished a \$29 playbook: a 10-day content system for solo trades. Friends bought it. Strangers did not know Noor existed. Noor needed a door, not a second book.

The seven questions Noor used Each is multiple choice. Each changes the band.

In the last 30 days, how many times did you actually finish a job with AI, not just open a chat?
(0, 1–3, 4+)

Do you have one offer a stranger can buy this week without a call? (yes / not yet)

Where does a new customer usually find you? (word of mouth, Google, Instagram or TikTok, they don't)

What happens after someone messages you? (you reply yourself, a form, nothing for days)

Have you saved a prompt or a project you reuse, or do you start from a blank chat every time?
(saved / blank)

How many hours a week can you give this, honestly, with the job you already have? (under 2, 2–5, 6+)

If a file told you the next step, would you rather have a pack to run yourself, or a person to set it up? (pack / person)

Noor scores 0–2 points per question. Bands: 0–5 still-setup, 6–10 ready-for-a-pack, 11–14 ready-but-inconsistent. The PDF gives one action per band. Still-setup: write the offer sentence this week, do not buy a course. Ready-for-a-pack: run one saved project on a real job by Friday. Ready-but-inconsistent: pick one platform for 14 days. None of those actions require \$29. That is the deal Noor keeps.

The form and the sequence Email required. PDF on the thank-you page and in note 1. Noor brands it “Trades AI scorecard — Noor” — a scorecard, not this book. Notes: (1) here’s your file, read the band, do the action; (2) a one-job example from the playbook, no pitch; (3) why blank chat is expensive, still no pitch; (4) a mistake: posting on five platforms; (5) the playbook exists, \$29, link; (6) a customer sentence from a friend who used day 3; (7) last time the link will be in the sequence, plus unsubscribe reminder.

A stranger named Dell finishes the form on a Thursday. Score 8. Note 1 goes out at once. Dell does the “saved project” action. Note 5 sells. Dell buys the \$29 file Saturday. Noor never ran an ad. First email from someone Noor had never met: Thursday 4:12pm. That is the first sale of this path — the address, not the \$29. The \$29 is path 1 working through the door.

Copy you can actually send

The public line Seven questions. A score.
One next step. Free even if you never buy.

The post I made a short AI-readiness scorecard for [your people]. Seven questions, a score, one thing to do this week. It is useful if you never buy from me. Link: [form].

Note 1 (instant) Your scorecard is here: [PDF]. Read the band with your score. Do the one action this week. I’ll send a few short notes. You can leave any time — unsubscribe is at the bottom.

Notes 2–4, shape not script One job, one example, one mistake to avoid. No link to the paid file yet unless they ask.

Note 5, the ask If you want the full sequence I use for [job], it's a \$29 playbook: [link]. If the free action in the PDF is enough, stay with that. Either is fine.

Note 7, close Last note in this set. Playbook is still here: [link]. If you want a human setup instead, reply with the word SETUP and I'll tell you the price. If not, I'll write when I have something useful. Unsubscribe anytime.

What you do not write Do not paste chapters of this suite into your PDF. Do not put a fake 94/100 at the top. Do not forget the unsubscribe. The free file is a diagnostic, not a brochure that happens to have a score.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1 Day 1: questions plus PDF. Day 2: form live, test as a stranger. Then write the 5–7 notes before any ads and before a second share. Share once in a place you already help people.

Week 2 Reply to humans. Fix the question people skip. Do not add a webinar. Count emails from strangers, not likes on the post.

Week 3–4 If ten people finished the form and the sequence is live, you may share again or spend a small amount on ads to the form — not to the paid button. If fewer than ten, the share was weak or the questions feel like a trap. Tighten the PDF's free action. Do not buy traffic to a flyer.

The quality bar

The bar is a file that still helps if they never pay, and a score that would change if they answered honestly.

Questions They change the advice. “Are you an ambitious entrepreneur?” does not. “Do you have one offer a stranger can buy this week?” does.

PDF Two to four pages. Band meanings. One free action each. Your name. No pasted chapters from someone else’s book. You may brand your own scorecard. You may not copy this book and sell it as yours.

Sequence Teaches first. Asks later. Unsubscribe always. Instant file, always.

Ethics you do not get to skip Passing this book off as if you wrote it is off limits. Selling this book as your own is off limits. Building a door that points at your playbook is the work.

What to count

First week - Form starts versus finishes. If half leave, you have too many questions or they smell a quiz trap. - Emails from people you have never met. That is the first sale of this path. - Whether the PDF link is clicked. If not, delivery is buried.

After 30 subscribers - Unsubscribe rate. Over 5 percent on the sequence means you asked too early or you were boring. Under 1 percent and zero clicks can mean nobody is reading — check the from-name. - Playbook click from notes 5–7. A few percent is real. Fifty percent means you only invited fans. - Replies. One genuine reply is worth twenty silent “opens.”

Do not buy a dashboard before you have thirty people. A spreadsheet with date, source, score band, bought-or-not is enough.

Objections you will hear — including your own

“People won’t give an email.” Some will not. They were not going to buy this month. The people who want the score will. Do not open the PDF to the whole internet and then wonder why you have no list. Email required is the deal.

“A free file should be a 40-page guide.” No. Long and useless is still useless. Seven questions and a tight PDF beat a stolen book with your logo.

“Can I just upload this suite as the magnet?” No. You may not copy this book and sell it as yours. You may not give it away as if you wrote it. Write a scorecard for your people. Point at your playbook.

“I should run ads on day one.” Not before the sequence exists. Paid traffic into silence is how you learn to hate lists.

“Fake scores convert better.” They convert once. Then they tell friends. Your name is small. Keep it clean.

“What if they only want the free thing?” Good. You kept the deal. Some of them buy in three months. Some never do. That is allowed.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

The door is last for a reason. It feeds every other path and it needs one of them first.

What must exist A paid next step, almost always path 1. Optionally a service or a setup if the diagnostic band says “person, not file.” The sequence should not invent a product you have not shipped.

What the list then feeds - Playbook sales without you DMing. - Later drops (path 17): you can tell a list about a Thursday live without begging the algorithm. - Research briefs, automations, custom projects — only as a reply offer, not as note 1. - A newsletter if you want one. The door can be the same form.

What the door must never feed A replica of this suite with your name on it. A “free” file that is only a sales letter. A purchased list. Those rot.

Mistakes that kill the door

Buying ads before the sequence exists. A 40-field form. Fake scores. Forgetting the unsubscribe. Those still kill it.

The rest - A PDF that is only a sales letter. - Passing this book off as if you wrote it, or selling this book as your own. - “We’ll send the file in 24 hours” as a drip trick. - Asking for the sale in paragraph one of the free file. - Daily blasts. - Questions that always output the same band. - Sharing on five platforms before you tested delivery from a second email.

If you catch yourself rewriting the PDF to mention the paid file more than the free action, you slipped. Put the paid file back in notes 5–7.

Tools — only what you need

A form, a PDF scorecard, MailerLite or Beehiiv. That is the stack.

Form Tally, the Beehiiv form, or MailerLite’s. Email required. Seven questions. Thank-you with the file.

PDF Google Docs export. Two to four pages. Your name, the year, a sentence that the file is free even if they never buy.

Sequence 5–7 notes in the same tool. Plain text is fine. No twenty-pixel buttons in every paragraph.

Do not add yet Do not add a webinar platform, a quiz app with 14 branches, or a CRM. Thirty strangers do not need HubSpot. They need a file and a way out.

Checklist

You finished an earlier path; the paid next step exists

Seven questions that change the advice

Scoring key you can defend

PDF with one free action per band

You did not copy this book into the PDF

Email required, not 40 fields

Instant delivery, tested from a second inbox

Unsubscribe works

5–7 notes written before you share widely

Teach first, ask later (notes 5–7)

Form sits above the paid button

Shared once where you already help

No ads until the sequence exists

First stranger email treated like a person

FAQ

Do I have to use seven questions? Seven is enough to change advice and short enough to finish on a phone. Five can work. Forty cannot.

What if I do not have a playbook yet? Do not build the door. Finish path 1, or another path with a named next step. An empty house does not need a nicer porch.

Can I brand the scorecard with my business name? Yes. You may brand your own scorecard. You may not copy this book and sell it as yours, and you may not give this book away as if you wrote it.

MailerLite or Beehiiv? Whichever you will actually open. Beehiiv if you also want a public letter. MailerLite if you want simple forms. Both handle unsubscribe. Use that feature.

Should the PDF include my prices? A line at the end is allowed: “If you want the full 10-day file, it lives here.” The body of the PDF should still work with that line deleted.

How fast is “instant”? On the thank-you screen and in the first email. Not “check your promotions tab in a few hours while we wait to look hungry.”

What is the first sale on this path? The first email from someone you have never met. Cash from the playbook is path 1 using the door. Count both. Do not pretend the list is failing because the \$29 did not happen on day one.

Can I sell the diagnostic as a \$9 product? Then it is not this path. This path is a free door. If you want a paid score, that is a small file on path 9, and you still need a free door later.

What about GDPR and consent? Say what they are joining, in one sentence, under the button. Include unsubscribe. Do not buy lists. Do not scrape emails out of comments.

When do I add ads? After the sequence exists, delivery works, and a handful of strangers have finished the form. Until then you are paying to learn that your PDF is a flyer.